



STABBINGTON BEAR: FORBIDDEN EPISODE

A glitchy analog horror chase on a cursed island.



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Introduction

Stabbington Bear: Forbidden Episode is organised into focused chapters, each designed to stand on its own. Read cover-to-cover or jump to whatever catches your eye first.



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Whispers Point the Knife

The tide slapped the fog like a wet hand over a mouth, and the beach underfoot didn't feel like sand so much as old, gritty film - rubbed thin, the grains catching at his claws. Stabbington Bear kept moving anyway, knife clenched in his paw so hard the leather creaked, his patched fur dampening where the mist touched it. Somewhere behind the fog, an engine cough became laughter that never quite formed words. VHS static hissed through his skull with a giddy rhythm, like a throat clearing to speak.

"Stop," he muttered, voice rough as bark. The sound came out wrong, stretched, as if it had to pass through a bad tape before it could reach his ears. He jerked his head at every snap of sound - at every tiny click in the air that might have been a frame skipping. "Who's there?"

The laughter answered by doubling. It slid between gusts, threading itself through the hiss until it felt less like something he heard and more like something he was being shown. He tried to focus on the knife's weight, the shallow bite of cold metal, the way the edge seemed sharper the longer he stared at it. Food was there in his belly - hunger that didn't care about fog or fear - yet the whispers kept pointing, kept tugging at his attention like fingers under his ribs.

He wanted silence. Not the gentle quiet of an empty beach - this was different. He wanted the voices to stop climbing over him, stop laughing through the static, stop making every step feel like a cue. The island had already taught him that wandering didn't end it; aimless movement only fed the loop. So he

followed the direction the sound insisted on, letting his paws carry him along the waterline where the fog churned thicker, where the world seemed to stutter.

The first thing he saw wasn't a person. It was a color - bright, wrong, almost cheerful against the gray. A sliver of something pink and yellow flashed between fog banks like a corrupted cartoon frame, then vanished, replaced by a ripple of static that made the shoreline look bent inward. Stabbington's stomach tightened. He tasted salt and something else: hot rubber, the sour stink of gasoline spilled and burned off too quickly.

Then the newcomers hit the beach like a thrown sound effect.

A crash - wood on stone, a hard thud that shuddered up through his knees - and the fog parted just enough to show bodies stumbling out of wreckage that shouldn't have been there. Sprunkies. Bright little shapes in battered clothes, faces scrunched in confusion, voices higher than his own, like laughter trying to pretend it wasn't fear.

One of them - small, round, too colorful - spun in a circle, blinking at the mist as if it could blink back the danger. "Where - where are we?" it squeaked.

Stabbington didn't answer. He didn't need to. The static in his skull sharpened into something like direction. A whisper slid into his ear, intimate and hungry.

Kill.

The word wasn't spoken with a mouth. It arrived as pressure, as a command drawn on his nerves. He shifted his weight forward, knife paw low, claws digging into gritty film-sand. The Sprunkies clustered together, shoulder to shoulder, oblivious to how tightly the world seemed to close around them. They looked at the fog. They looked at the ocean. They didn't look at him fast enough.

One of them turned, and its eyes went wide when it saw the knife.

Stabbington lunged.

His first strike was clumsy - hunger makes paws heavy, panic makes angles wrong - and the knife scraped instead of sinking cleanly. The Sprunkie yelped, a thin, terrified sound that cut through the hiss like a needle through a speaker. It stumbled back and nearly fell, boots skidding on slick sand. The fog swallowed part of its shape, then spat it back out, as if the island couldn't decide what was real.

"Bear!" someone shouted - too loud, too late.

Stabbington felt the impact of his own movement through his shoulder. The knife's edge caught fur and something softer beneath. He pushed again, forcing the blade where his aim should've been. The Sprunkie bucked, kicking at him with frantic little legs, and the smell hit - warm blood, metallic and thick, mixed with that burned rubber tang from the crash. The Sprunkie's skin was slick under his claws, trembling as if it had become liquid.

The whispers surged louder, ecstatic now, layered over the static like multiple mouths cheering at once.

"Shh - shh - " the voices breathed, and the words weren't words anymore, just excitement shaping sound. Stabbington tightened his grip and finished the motion. The Sprunkie's struggle stuttered, then went slack in a way that made the fog feel cruelly calm. For a heartbeat, the island held still.

Then the laughter returned with teeth.

It wasn't just in his ears anymore. It vibrated in the beach itself. The sand rippled beneath his paws like a screen being dragged under water. The fog tightened into a tunnel, pressing close on both sides of the shoreline, compressing the space between wave and trees until it felt like he'd backed into a hallway.

The Sprunkies who remained - two, maybe three, it was hard to count through the shifting static - froze like marionettes with their strings cut. One scrambled backward, dragging another with it. Their bright colors smeared at the edges, glitching into blur as the world stuttered. They stared at Stabbington like he was an error in the image they couldn't correct.

"Get away!" one of them screamed. "He has - he has a knife!"

Stabbington tried to move toward them, but the voices pulled his attention the other way, yanking him toward the wreckage, toward the place where the bright sliver had appeared. His hunger lunged after the sound. His body followed the wrong cue, and his stumble kicked up sand that felt like powdered film.

He couldn't afford to miss again. The whispers were clearer now, demanding, excited.

More.

He swung his head toward the trees where the fog thickened into a wall. The Sprunkies were already running - small feet pounding, their panic loud enough to drown out the hiss for brief moments. Their footsteps sounded like fast-forward. The island, offended by their motion, distorted around them. The shoreline stretched out longer than it should've, then snapped back, as if the world had been dragged across the rewind button and released too quickly.

Stabbington heard it - faint giggling between the Sprunkies' screams, like laughter tucked inside a speaker cabinet. It came from the forest line, from somewhere dark beyond the trees, from somewhere the fog refused to show.

He broke into a sprint.

Every step hurt in a new way. His paws skidded on grit that shifted under him, and his breath tore at his throat with each inhale. The knife paw swung with him, clattering against his own body, heavy enough to throw off his rhythm. The

air tasted cold and wet, and the static in his skull made his thoughts feel like they were being played at the wrong speed.

Behind him, the Sprunki he'd killed made no sound anymore. That should've been relief. It wasn't. The voices grew louder the instant the life left his claws, as if the act was a signal that triggered something bigger.

*Good. Good. Good - *

Stitch's presence flickered in the edge of perception. Not fully - never fully. Just glimpses, like frames caught between edits. For a fraction of a second, the fog in front of him carried a grin-shaped distortion, a pale curve where there shouldn't be any face. The trees blinked with it, trunks warping like warped tape through a machine. Stabbington flinched, but his feet kept moving.

The remaining Sprunkies ran deeper into the island's throat. Their bright colors bounced between glimpses of real terrain and glitchy patches of false ground. One of them turned a corner and disappeared - no scream, no stumble, just gone, swallowed by a smear of static that looked like spilled snow.

Stabbington roared, not with words but with the raw sound of an animal refusing to be tricked.

"Where'd you - ?" he demanded, breath ragged. "Come back!"

The answer came as laughter that sounded closer than it should've. A whisper threaded through the hiss, urgent now, pointing like a knife pressed to the back of his skull.

Track. Watch. Cut.

He shoved forward, pushing past branches that seemed to grow out of nowhere. The air cooled sharply, then warmed again, as if the island couldn't decide on a temperature setting. Under his claws, the ground shifted from sand into slick roots, then into something that felt like old carpeting - thick, damp,

and wrong. He nearly slipped. His panic flared, and with it, his aim went even more off.

A Sprunki darted into view between two trees, clutching a bright object - an absurd splash of color against the gray. It looked like a toy, like something meant for a living room, not a dying island. It skidded to a stop, eyes darting wildly, and turned as if it had heard Stabbington's footsteps before seeing him.

Stabbington lunged again, knife leading.

The Sprunki flinched to the side at the last second. The edge grazed its arm instead of its chest, biting through fabric and into skin. It screamed, high and broken, and the sound warped into a stutter as the fog flickered. For a moment, the Sprunki's face looked wrong - eyes too wide, mouth too stretched - as if Stitch's grin was trying to occupy the frame.

Stabbington's claws scrabbled for purchase. He could feel the creature slipping away, could feel the knife stuck half in, half out. His muscles strained until they burned, until his lungs dragged air through a throat that felt stuffed with cotton. He shoved his weight forward anyway, forcing the blade deeper with a jerking motion.

The Sprunki bucked. Blood flashed dark against the fog, steaming faintly in the damp cold. It tried to swing its bright object like a weapon, but the motion was sloppy, panicked - too much fear, not enough strength. Its body trembled, and the static in Stabbington's ears surged like a celebration.

*Yes. Yes. YES - *

The voice didn't just demand killing. It demanded attention. It demanded the act be seen by something that wasn't there yet. The laughter swelled until Stabbington couldn't tell whether it came from the woods or from the inside of his skull. He could feel his heartbeat syncing with the hiss. The island narrowed around him, compressing the space between trees until the branches seemed to lean closer, until the fog became a ceiling lowering millimeter by millimeter.

The Sprunki fell to its knees and then to the ground, fingers twitching once like a final glitch. Stabbington stood over it, breathing hard, knife slick and heavy.

Silence didn't arrive.

Instead, the whispers sharpened into instructions, excited and specific, like a director thrilled by a take that went slightly wrong. They pulled his gaze toward the beachline behind him - toward the wreckage where the bright sliver had first flashed. But the path back wasn't stable. The trees ahead stretched into a corridor, then folded sideways. The fog peeled back just enough to show the shoreline in an angle that didn't match where he'd run from.

Stitch's grin flickered again - closer now, clearer for a heartbeat - on the surface of the fog like a reflection that didn't belong to any bear or any Sprunki. It vanished when Stabbington tried to focus on it, leaving only laughter and a static snap.

He snarled through the haze. "No," he said, voice cracking. "Stop pointing."

The whispers ignored him. They grew louder anyway, excited by resistance. They didn't just tell him where to go; they made the island feel like it was already moving him there. His paws carried him forward before he fully decided. Each step dragged through a surface that kept changing texture - sand to roots to that damp, carpet-like wrongness - until he felt trapped inside a machine that refused to hold steady.

Ahead, the fog thickened into a darker patch that looked like a burned area on tape. A faint flicker pulsed there, the same kind of glitch that had flashed the grin. And with that flicker came the sound of someone else - another Sprunki's panic - cut off mid-scream, replaced by a wet, static-choked laugh.

Stabbington's hunger twisted into something sharper than appetite. It wasn't just wanting food anymore. It was wanting the voices to stop climbing louder unless he obeyed. It was wanting the island to unclench.

He forced himself to run toward the flicker, knife paw raised like a conductor's baton.

The chase tightened into a corridor of fog and distorted trees, narrowing with every breath. The ground kept slipping under him, and his exhaustion turned each lunge into a gamble. Behind, the island breathed out static. Ahead, the whispers pointed harder.

*There. There. There - *

He reached the place where the shoreline should've been, and the beach answered with corruption: the sand rippled like a tape being dragged across a spinning head, and the air stuttered with visual afterimages of the wreckage - colors flashing too quickly to be real. Somewhere in that smear, the remaining Sprunkies were waiting, hiding, trying to disappear from the frame.

Stabbington tasted blood on his tongue where he'd bitten his own lip without noticing. He didn't wipe it away. He didn't slow down.

A single figure - bright and terrified - stumbled into view through the fog, turning as if to run back toward him, as if every direction had become the same wrong answer. It locked eyes with Stabbington, and its mouth opened on a sound that couldn't decide between pleading and screaming.

Stabbington lifted the knife and moved.

The edge caught flesh with a wet, final sound, and the Sprunki's body jerked hard, then went slack. The voices exploded louder than ever - cheering, breathless, thrilled - until the static felt like it was coating his teeth.

*More watches. More cuts. Seven days starts now - *

The fog convulsed. For one sick instant, the world around him froze like a frame paused too long, and a grin-shaped distortion spread across the mist where Stitch's face should've been, laughing without a mouth.

Then everything snapped back into motion.

Stabbington stood with his knife still slick in his paw, staring into the fog where the corridor seemed to tighten again, where the beachline reshaped itself into a funnel. The whispers weren't satisfied. They were excited.

And they were pointing - toward the rest of the Sprunkies, toward the hidden pull of the island, toward whatever waited just beyond the next glitch.

CHAPTER 2



The Chase Shrinks the Trees

Stabbington's paw was still slick with the last Sprunki's warm mess when the fog ahead shuddered like a bad tape trying to lock onto a signal. The knife stayed clamped in his grip, leather handle biting into his palm as his breathing came out in ragged bursts. The voices in his skull didn't fade after the kill; they climbed. Laughter threaded through thin VHS static, then sharpened into something that sounded almost pleased - demanding.

"More," the whispers insisted, not spoken so much as pressed into the air between trees. "More. More."

He didn't turn toward the beach. He didn't even look back. The corridor the fog had been shaping tightened again, funneling into a narrow run through twisted trunks and low branches. The ground felt slightly wrong under his feet - soft, then suddenly springy, as if the earth had decided to be a cushion instead of soil. Each time he tried to step cleanly, the path slid a little farther ahead, like the forest was refusing to let him catch up to himself.

The Sprunkies were nearby. He could smell them - cheap plastic sweetness and wet fur, the sour tang of fear. One of them had left a trail: a crushed leaf smell, a scatter of bright color smeared along bark, like someone had dragged a toy across the world. Stabbington followed the smear anyway, knife first, shoulders hunched, jaw working around the taste of adrenaline that never satisfied.

He rounded into the grove and the trunks began to move.

Not like walking trees, not like something that could be explained. They slid sideways in tiny increments, closing gaps with the slow certainty of a closing door. The daylight flickered through the canopy in stuttering frames, greenish and then gray, then green again, as if the sky couldn't decide what it was meant to show. Branches leaned inward, brushing his shoulders with cold, fibrous contact. Every time he ducked, another limb appeared where there hadn't been one a breath ago.

His legs screamed. He was already running, already forcing the sprint to keep going, but the grove kept stealing distance. A path that should've been twenty steps became thirty, then forty, the forest stretching like a VHS recording pulled too far. The voices laughed harder when he stumbled.

"That's it," they crackled. "Chase."

Stabbington bared his jagged smile and pushed harder. His claws scraped bark, leaving pale gouges that bled sap and - wrongly - looked like old film scratches. His lungs burned with each inhale, thick and metallic, and his throat tasted of static. He tried to get his footing under him, but the ground warped just enough to steal his balance. One step landed too far. The next landed too close. He overcorrected and slammed his hip into a trunk that wasn't where he'd just seen it.

A branch snapped close to his ear with a wet crack. He flinched, and for a moment the world stuttered: the snapped branch became a different branch, still bent, still vibrating, like the grove had rewound itself and played the damage from an earlier angle.

Stitch's presence - faint, flickering - showed up in the periphery like a corrupted frame. A blink of pale grin in the shadow between two trunks. A smear of dark eyes that weren't attached to any animal. The laughter in the static rose in response to his fear.

Stabbington growled, low and furious, and shoved through the branches anyway. He had a job now. The voices had pointed, and pointing meant catching.

He heard a Sprunki ahead - small, frantic noises, a squeal of plastic shoes skidding. Something bright snapped around a bend and then vanished, swallowed by the shifting corridor. Stabbington tore forward, knife held low like a hook.

"Hey!" the Sprunki's voice came out thin and panicked. "Stop - please - !"

It wasn't one of the ones he'd already killed. This one was still alive. Still stupidly hopeful. Still loud enough for the whispers to feast on.

Stabbington hit the bend and nearly went down. The ground dipped into a shallow ravine that hadn't been there a second ago; his feet skated on slick mud, and his momentum carried him into a tangle of roots. His shoulder slammed hard. Pain burst white behind his eyes. He tasted blood on his tongue.

The whispers were louder now, almost excited in their cruelty. "Catch."

Stabbington pushed up, claws digging into wet earth. He could see the Sprunki's trail again - bright smear, crushed leaves, a drag-mark through ferns. It zigged right, then left, then straight into a tight knot of trees so close he could almost touch both trunks at once. The grove squeezed him like a fist.

He lunged into the squeeze and the branches closed behind him with a sound like tape being torn.

The Sprunki was there - near enough to smell the sweetness of its cheap plastic coating, near enough to see the wet shine of fear in its eyes. It backed away, stumbling, arms flailing, trying to keep distance from the knife. It looked at him with that helpless, childlike trust that made the voices sound hungrier.

"You can't!" it pleaded, and the words came out warped, like the Sprunki's voice couldn't decide what it meant. "You - aren't - supposed - "

Stabbington didn't wait for the sentence to finish. He charged. His body wanted to collapse, but the chase kept him upright. He swung the knife in a brutal arc, aiming for the center mass like hunger remembered how to be simple.

The Sprunki dodged with frantic luck, and the knife caught instead on a strap - fabric tearing with a loud rip. The Sprunki screamed, high and sharp, and the scream turned into a wet gasp when Stabbington yanked it forward by the fabric and drove the blade down.

Resistance fought his arm. The leather handle slicked with new blood, his paw slipping for half a second, and the grove punished him for hesitation. The trunks shifted again, forcing his stance wider, forcing his swing off-line. He felt something crack - bone or cartilage, he couldn't tell, only the sick certainty that he'd made contact.

The Sprunki thrashed. Its limbs kicked against his chest. Hot breath sprayed his muzzle. The smell of blood and sweet plastic mixed into a disgusting perfume that made his stomach churn, and still the voices rose like applause.

"Good," they hissed. "Good. Good."

Stabbington tried to keep the pressure, tried to hold the Sprunki still. But the forest didn't allow stillness. The ground buckled under his feet; the blade went deeper than he intended, and the Sprunki's body jerked in a way that felt wrong, like something had been pulled from a line of elastic. Its eyes rolled back. Its mouth opened and then - like a tape going static - the scream cut out into a choking rattle.

Stabbington's knife slipped free.

The Sprunki fell, but not all the way. It crumpled against the base of a trunk that slid a fraction closer, trapping part of its body in the narrowing gap. The legs

twitched, then jerked again as the grove shifted around it, smearing its colors across bark. The smell of blood thickened, sour and coppery, and Stabbington's ears filled with static so loud it drowned the Sprunki's final breaths.

He should've finished the job cleanly. He knew that. The voices didn't.

Instead they surged, louder than before, and the laughter became a frantic chorus. "No! Not enough - "

Stabbington froze with his knife raised, breath steaming. His exhausted arms trembled, and that tremble felt like a betrayal. He looked around, searching for the remaining Sprunkies - three, maybe four - whatever was still alive.

The grove responded by rearranging itself.

The trunk knot became a corridor with too many options at once. Branches split into multiple paths, each one leading deeper into the same tight space, each one bending back toward him like a looped recording. The daylight flickered hard - light frames too bright, then darkness too sudden - so his eyes kept losing the world and finding it again.

He heard another Sprunki somewhere left, then right. Then both at once.

"Over here!" one shouted, voice cracking with terror. "I can see you - !"

"No - don't - !" another yelled, followed by a thud and a wet sound like something being dragged through mud.

Stabbington's fur prickled. He couldn't track them with his senses when the environment kept lying. Sound came from directions that didn't match the trunks. The smell of plastic sweetness arrived from the air behind him, then from the air in front, like the forest was spinning his direction around him.

The voices seemed to enjoy that confusion. They weren't just guiding him anymore. They were steering the hunt by breaking his ability to understand where things were.

Stabbington made a decision anyway. His paw tightened around the knife until leather creaked. He chose the loudest sound - an urgent squeal cutting through static - and shoved into a narrow gap between trunks that seemed barely wide enough for his shoulders.

He squeezed through and immediately regretted it. Branches grabbed his fur like hands. Twigs snagged his sleeve-less arms and tore at his skin, leaving thin lines of pain. The gap narrowed further as he moved, compressing him. He had to twist his torso to keep from getting pinned, and each twist made his joints grind.

The grove warped around him again. For a heartbeat, the trees were too close, too tall, bending inward like a tunnel. Then the world snapped back with a sick lurch - like the tape had skipped forward - and he stumbled out onto a small clearing that shouldn't exist in a grove this tight.

In the clearing, the ground was littered with bright fragments - bits of Sprunki clothing, a snapped strap, a smear of color on bark. But there was no Sprunki body. No finality. Just evidence of motion that had been interrupted.

A Sprunki was there a second later.

It burst from behind a trunk, sprinting straight toward him, eyes wide, mouth open in a silent panic that made the static feel even louder. It slipped, caught itself, then changed direction mid-run like it had remembered something too late. It darted left, then right, then right again - too fast for a frightened animal, too coordinated for an oblivious one.

Stabbington tried to intercept. He lunged. His feet hit a root and skidded. His knife scraped bark, leaving a gouge that looked like a scratch across a film reel.

The Sprunki didn't stop. It sprinted past him and vanished behind a curtain of hanging vines.

Stabbington spun, forcing his body to move even as his muscles begged for rest. Sweat poured down his face, salty and disgusting, and the air tasted like damp rot. Somewhere behind him, the trapped Sprunki's body twitched against the narrowing trunk gap, and the voices giggled like they'd made a joke out of his delay.

He shoved through the vines.

The vines weren't vines anymore. They were strips of something darker, slicker - like old tape film, shredded and draped to look natural. They slapped against his face and stuck to his fur with a cold, adhesive tack. When he tore them away, they left behind a thin residue that smelled like scorched plastic and wet metal.

The Sprunki was ahead, just out of reach. Its bright colors flickered, becoming and un-becoming as the world glitched. For a half-second, it looked like it was made of static and smiling cartoon shapes. For the next, it was just a frightened child's toy-animal scrambling through leaves.

Stabbington ran after it, chasing the real shape through the fake ones. His legs burned. His lungs felt too small. His vision tunneled from exhaustion, but the voices kept him moving with cruel insistence.

"Don't let it get away."

"More. More."

The grove narrowed again into a corridor of sliding trunks. This time it felt tighter, like the walls were measuring him and finding him too big. His shoulders scraped both sides. Branches struck his spine with every step. The air grew colder, then warmer, then cold again, as if the temperature itself couldn't hold steady.

The Sprunki ducked under a fallen limb that wasn't on the ground when Stabbington first saw it. He hit it anyway - hard - his head snapping forward,

knife paw jolting. He staggered, and the Sprunki used the stumble like a gift. It darted away, splitting around a bend.

Stabbington caught a glimpse of it - just a flash of bright color and a set of eyes reflecting wrong light. The eyes blinked like a tape frame. The grin on Stitch's flickering presence flashed behind the trees for a fraction of a second, too close to be coincidence.

Then the Sprunki was gone again.

Stabbington stood in the corridor with his breath ragged and his knife raised, shaking. His exhaustion pressed down like a weight. His fur felt heavy with sweat and sticky residue from the tape-like vines. He could feel his heart battering his ribs, each thump loud in his skull, louder than the static.

The whispers changed tone. They weren't just demanding now. They were savoring the delay.

"You're slow," they teased, laughter threading through the words.

Stabbington's jaw clenched until his teeth ached. He couldn't afford slow. He couldn't afford hesitation. He turned toward the direction the loudest sound came from, then immediately corrected - because the sound came from behind him, then in front, then directly above, like the forest was playing with his sense of direction.

He chose anyway. He charged down the narrowing path, forcing himself to keep moving when his legs threatened to lock up.

A Sprunki screamed ahead - closer than it should've been. Stabbington burst around a bend and found a dead-end space between two trunks that slid closer together as he approached. The branches overhead formed a low ceiling, too tight for his full height. The gap felt like a trap built by someone who knew exactly how wide he was.

The Sprunki was there, cornered, pressed against bark. It looked up at him with panic so bright it almost made the static look calm.

"Please," it whispered, and the word came out wrong, as if stitched into the tape by someone else's mouth. "We... we didn't - "

Stabbington didn't let it finish. He lunged, knife forward, but the trunks slid toward each other as if closing around them. The corridor tightened by inches every second, compressing the space until Stabbington's swing lost room. His blade struck, but the angle fought him. His paw scraped bark, and he felt the knife's edge catch on something - bone, maybe, or the spine of a body trapped between moving walls.

The Sprunki shrieked. Its bright colors smeared across the bark like paint dragged by shaking hands. Blood ran fast and hot, spattering his fur and making it itch. The smell was overwhelming now - copper and sweetness and the sour stink of fear.

Stabbington tore the knife free anyway and drove forward again. Something gave with a wet, horrible crunch. The Sprunki's body jerked as if the tape had pulled it out of frame and tried to rewind it wrong.

For a moment, it looked like he'd won. Like the voices would accept the kill and quiet down.

But the corridor didn't release him.

The trunks kept sliding. The branches kept closing. The ceiling pressed lower. The air grew thick, harder to breathe. Stabbington's lungs labored with each breath, and the static in his ears became a roar.

The Sprunki's eyes went wide. Its mouth opened, and the sound that came out wasn't a scream - it was laughter, distorted and delighted, as if Stitch had gotten inside its throat for one cruel second.

Then the Sprunki split into motion.

Not physically, not like a magic trick - like the world had decided it couldn't show what happened next. One second it was in front of him, the next it was slipping sideways through the narrowing gap, colors smearing and reappearing on the other side of the trunks as they slid together. The corridor's walls overlapped for a heartbeat, and the Sprunki was gone without leaving a full body behind.

Stabbington slammed his shoulder into the closing gap, claws digging at bark that moved away under his grip. He couldn't get purchase. His knife paw jerked uselessly at empty air. The voices erupted into a chorus of excited static, and Stitch's presence flickered again - close enough to feel like it was watching from inside his own eyes.

"Run," the whispers urged, not as comfort but as command. "Run, run, run."

Stabbington staggered backward, then forced himself forward. The grove had begun to fracture his control into directions he couldn't track. Sounds ricocheted. Smells arrived from impossible angles. The daylight flickered violently, painting the trunks in harsh green and then bleaching them to gray.

He caught another Sprunki - maybe two - just flashes through the gaps as they scattered away in multiple directions at once, the forest refusing to agree on where "away" was. Each time he chased one bright flicker, another appeared somewhere else, and the corridor shifted like a failing VHS signal, pulling the chase into a braid of paths that kept intersecting without ever letting him settle on a single track.

The knife was slick in his paw again, but this time it wasn't just blood. It was sweat. Sticky residue. Something like film glue.

He ran until his legs stopped feeling like legs and started feeling like raw cords. He ran until his vision pixelated at the edges. He ran because the voices wouldn't let him do anything else.

Behind him, the grove tightened with a soft, grinding sound, like old tape being rewound too fast. Ahead, multiple bright shapes fled through the glitching forest, scattering the hunt into a wider, uglier search - while Stitch's laughter flickered in the static like a grin that never got closer, only closer enough to make it hurt.

Stabbington tore after the next smear of color, forcing his exhausted body through a gap that kept narrowing, knowing the chase had already split and that catching one wouldn't be enough.



Glowing Eyes Behind the Static

"Stop running," the laughter said through the static, and it wasn't one voice anymore - it was layered, too close, as if the tape had crawled into the hollow of Stabbington Bear's skull. Somewhere behind him the grove still made that awful grinding sound, like someone rewinding the world without permission. Ahead, the forest kept flashing brighter and then darker, frames swapping places faster than eyes could focus. Stabbington pushed through it anyway, knife clenched in his paw, leather handle slick with sweat and old spray, his breath coming in broken bursts that sounded like torn film.

"Garrick," the whispers breathed, wrong and intimate, using a name like a hook.
"Look - look - "

He didn't answer. He couldn't. The Sprunkies had scattered when the trees tore and shuddered like a corrupted signal, and the one he'd been on - its bright color smeared across glitching trunks - had vanished into a fold of shadow. Stabbington tasted salt and rot in the air as he ran, his paws slapping mud that didn't stay mud. Sometimes it turned to grit, sometimes to something wet and springy that gave underfoot like old carpet soaked in blood. He could feel the ravine ahead before he saw it, the way the ground dipped and the air thinned.

He wanted one thing, clean and immediate: the next Sprunki. Not the hunt as an idea - just the body, the proof, the silence he'd gotten the last time the voices grew loud after he killed. The knife felt heavier with every step, like it was learning his grip. The voices promised reward in the same breath as they demanded obedience, and that promise had started to feel like the only direction left on the island.

The ravine opened in front of him like a cut in the world. One second it was a narrow channel between dark rocks, the next it was a wide throat with black water he couldn't see the bottom of. The ground narrowed too, walls closing in with a slow, grinding inevitability, forcing him to keep moving forward or scrape himself to pieces on stone. He slid down a slick slope, claws catching, then caught himself with a stumble and kept running anyway, tailbone aching, lungs burning like he'd swallowed smoke.

"Here," the whispers insisted, excited now. "He's here."

Stabbington's vision stuttered. For a blink he saw glowing eyes ahead - two pale orbs floating where there should have been rock - then the image snapped into darkness, replaced by the afterimage of the Sprunki he'd been chasing, sprinting with its limbs too long, too wrong. The laugh cut through the air again, sharp as metal on glass. He flinched so hard his paw jerked and the knife tip scraped stone, sending a hot sting up his arm.

He kept going because stopping felt like dying. He hit the ravine floor - dirt, then gravel, then slick mud again - and his paw pads skidded in a way that made panic bloom too fast. The air smelled like wet earth and something sweeter underneath it, like fruit rotting inside a sealed room. Every breath came with static hiss, like the world was trying to tune him into a channel he didn't want.

A Sprunki's color flashed to his left, a smear of bright fabric caught between rock faces. Stabbington lunged toward it, throwing his weight down an incline that shouldn't have existed. His shoulder slammed into a wall that felt too soft, like flesh wrapped in stone. He recoiled, choking, and the laughter surged louder - closer - until it sounded like giggling recorded on a cheap tape, played through a speaker pressed against his teeth.

"Not that way," the whispers hissed, then corrected themselves with a sing-song edge. "Yes. That way. Keep going."

The ravine flickered again. The walls weren't just walls anymore; they became vertical strips of darkness, each strip showing a different version of the same place. In one flicker the ground ahead was dry and flat, inviting. In the next it was a steep drop where black water churned. Stabbington couldn't tell which was real, but he felt the pressure of the closing trap in his bones either way.

He chose the path that promised the Sprunki.

He barreled forward, knife held low, and the air changed temperature so suddenly it made his fur prickle. Cold seeped into his nostrils, then hot followed, like someone had swapped the tape reel and the weather with it. His vision tunneled. He could hear his own heartbeat thudding over the static, a drumbeat that didn't match the rhythm of the laughter.

The footsteps - his, only his - echoed wrong, too many echoes, too many delays. When he looked back, the ravine behind him looked like a corridor of moving pixels. The walls glitched into tighter spacing, narrowing with a soft grinding sound that matched the grove's rewind. He tried to turn and the stone resisted, pressing against his shoulder like the world had decided he was meant to go one direction only.

Ahead, a cluster of torn fabric lay in the mud. Bright color. Sprunki gear.

Relief hit him so hard it tasted like bile. He dropped to a knee, claws digging, and snatched at the fabric with his free paw. It was warm, as if it had just been pulled from a body. The smell of it was wrong - sweet, sour, and metallic, like candy left too long in a mouthful of blood. A faint rattle came from inside the torn bundle, a sound like a toy wind-up mechanism stuck mid-cycle.

"Come on," Stabbington muttered, voice rough, the whispers already crowding his thoughts. "Where are you."

His words were swallowed by static.

He turned the fabric over and saw a small piece of plastic, cracked but familiar: one of the Sprunkies' bright accessories, the kind that had been flashing when they crashed in. He hadn't seen it up close before. Now it looked chewed at the edges, as if something had worried it carefully, patiently. His stomach tightened. The ravine seemed to lean in, listening.

Then, in the mud beside the gear, he found a smear of boot-print - except it wasn't a boot. It was too narrow, too long, the tread pattern repeating like a printed texture. It led forward, disappearing into a darker patch of stone where the ravine floor should have been continuous.

Stitch's laughter threaded through the static, and it didn't sound like the whispers anymore. It sounded amused. It sounded like someone watching a show they'd already seen.

"Look," the laughter said, and the word carried a sense of pointing, not toward the Sprunki he'd chased, but toward whatever was behind the darkness.

Stabbington followed the trail because his body couldn't do anything else. He dragged himself upright, knife gripped tighter, and stepped where the smear narrowed. The stone under his paw felt tacky, like resin. When he lifted his paw, the residue stretched thin, a string of dark film that snapped back into place with a soft, ugly sound.

He didn't have time to wonder what it meant. The ravine flickered, and the dark patch ahead briefly became a flat screen of black water. In that flicker he saw glowing eyes blinking just under the surface - two pale dots opening and closing, slow and patient, as if the thing behind them was savoring the moment before it lunged.

The image vanished. What remained was only stone and mud and that trail.

Stabbington's breathing turned ragged. He forced himself to keep moving, because the instant he slowed, the whispers got louder, hungry. "He's trying," they teased. "He's trying to find it. Find what we hid."

"Who's we?" Stabbington snarled, and his voice came out too loud in the ravine, bouncing off the walls in distorted returns. The static answered by briefly clearing - just long enough for a different sound to slip through: a muffled crackle, like an old tape being played through a speaker that wasn't connected properly.

Then Stitch's laughter came back, sharper.

Stabbington flung the knife forward toward a dark seam in the stone, just to make contact with something real. The blade met resistance that didn't feel like rock. It pushed into a membrane that yielded with a wet give, then snapped back, recoiling his paw with a sting. He jerked back, eyes watering, and the ravine shuddered as if the world had been interrupted.

"Stop poking," the whispers scolded, and the scolding sounded like a grin. "You'll ruin it."

Ruin it - like the ravine was a recording and he was scratching the tape.

The pressure of the walls increased. The corridor tightened around him with each flicker, shrinking the space he had to turn. He backed into the trail smear and felt the ground tilt. The mud became slick again. His legs threatened to slide out from under him.

He chose forward again, because the trap kept offering only that direction.

The darkness ahead opened into a tighter pocket of space, almost like a niche. Stabbington shoved his way in and saw more torn gear - another piece of Sprunki equipment, a bright strip with frayed edges. It lay in a nest of damp leaves that hadn't been there a second ago. The leaves were cold, crisping at the edges like they'd been stored too long, and when he brushed them aside, something underneath made a faint, electrical hum.

He froze, listening.

The hum turned into a low crackle, and the air smelled suddenly like plastic warmed by a machine. Old tape smell - dust and oil and static. His fur prickled all over, not just from fear but from recognition he couldn't name.

The niche wasn't natural. It felt built, like a small hidden room pressed into the ravine's skin. In the darkness he spotted a rectangle - metal, dull, half-buried. A latch.

Stabbington's paw hovered over the latch. His knife felt useless suddenly, like it was a prop from a different kind of story. The whispers swelled into a chorus, layered on laughter, layered on something else - rustling paper, the faint clack of plastic on plastic.

He pulled the latch anyway.

The metal gave with a wet scrape. A panel shifted just enough for cold air to pour out, carrying the smell of moldy cardboard and old electronics. Static fizzed louder. For a blink, the niche walls displayed a flickering image - white title cards, smeared drawings, and a single distorted line of text that looked like it had been dragged through mud: *Stitch: Forbidden Episode*.

Stabbington's throat tightened. He tasted metal. He pressed his paw against the opening and leaned in, forcing his eyes to adjust to the darkness that flickered like a broken lamp.

Inside, shelves were stacked with old VHS tapes. Some were labeled in handwriting that looked too shaky to be human. Others were blank, their spines scratched as if someone had tried to erase the past. The hum came from somewhere deeper, from a cable that disappeared into a shadow that didn't behave like shadow. It moved wrong, like it was breathing.

Stitch's laughter floated up from that darkness, not from the speakers in the tapes, but from the gap itself.

"Found it," the whispers purred. "Found the place."

Stabbington clutched the edge of the opening until his claws hurt. He wanted to reach in, wanted to snatch proof and tear it apart, wanted to silence the voices by destroying what fed them. But the moment he leaned farther, the ravine shifted again, as if the walls were trying to close around the discovery. The niche shrank by inches, then feet, the opening narrowing until only his shoulder fit.

He jerked back, panting, breath stuttering. The static inside the niche flared into a brighter hiss, and a new sound layered over it: a distant, wet thump, like something heavy being dragged across concrete. Then a whisper that wasn't layered anymore - one voice, clear enough to hurt.

"Stabbington," it said, and the way it said his name wasn't like the voices before. It was calling him like a character being summoned back to set.

He looked down into the opening and saw torn gear again - freshly torn, as if the Sprunkies had been pulled through here recently. A corner of a bright outfit lay near the threshold, and on it was something darker smeared across the fabric. Not blood, not exactly. More like ink that wouldn't dry.

The laughter surged, and the ravine's flicker intensified. For a split second, glowing eyes appeared in the niche behind the tapes - too large, too close - then blinked out. The darkness swallowed them before Stabbington could raise his knife.

He lunged toward the shelf anyway, thrusting his paw into the opening, scraping tapes aside until the plastic cases rattled. One tape slid loose and thumped against the metal floor with a hollow sound. The label on it - partially visible - flashed with the same smeared text, the same impossible phrase.

Stitch: Forbidden Episode.

The instant Stabbington touched the tape case, the voices snapped into a frenzy. The whispers weren't guiding him through the forest anymore. They were pointing. They were screaming direction with giddy hunger.

"Too late," Stitch's laughter crackled, and it sounded delighted. "Too late - show him. Show him where to go."

The ravine tightened as if the bunker was only a door to another trap. The niche opening narrowed until it pinched his shoulder fur and made him hiss through clenched teeth. Static slammed into his ears so hard it made his vision swim. In that white noise he heard movement - soft, careful steps on the other side of the darkness, not approaching him, but circling the niche like a viewer leaning into frame.

Stabbington staggered back, knife clutched in both paws now, and forced himself to keep his eyes on the narrowing gap. The floor beneath his feet flickered between slick mud and hard, dry stone, making his balance wobble like a bad transmission.

He turned his head toward the ravine mouth to find the trail again, because he needed to know what was watching him and where the laughter was coming from.

The trail was gone.

In its place, the mud was arranged in a fresh line of torn Sprunki gear, bright pieces laid like breadcrumbs - each strip facing inward, pointing toward the bunker opening as if the island itself had decided to direct him. The glowing eyes flashed one last time in the dark beyond the tapes, blinking like a camera shutter.

Stabbington's breath burned. He stood there with the knife raised, shoulder aching from being squeezed by the ravine's glitching walls, and the voices surged again - louder, more excited, demanding in a way that felt like hands on the back of his neck.

The ravine didn't let him leave the niche.

It didn't have to.

It was already guiding him deeper into whatever lived behind the static.

CHAPTER 4

Bunker Doors That Won't Stay Open

Marlowe Sprunkie didn't know he was holding his breath until the air tasted wrong.

It was still damp in the ravine, still slick with black water that smelled like pennies and rot, but the sound in his skull - laughter and that thin VHS static hiss - had started behaving like a hand pressing from the inside. The whispers weren't just pointing anymore. They were herding. They tugged his attention toward the overgrowth where concrete should've been impossible, where roots had grown too cleanly around a shape that didn't belong in the mud. The laughing got louder whenever he tried to look away, as if the island itself was replaying the same frame over and over, and the frame always ended with Garrick's boots somewhere close.

Marlowe's knee scraped stone. He felt it through his furred pants - grit grinding against bruised skin - then the ground shifted under him, not like earth moving, but like a tape rewinding and catching. A seam in the wall of the niche appeared where there hadn't been one, faint and gray, and the roots above it stopped looking like roots and started looking like wires. He swallowed hard. The static in his ears crackled, and for a second he heard it like a promise: bunker, bunker, bunker.

Garrick was behind them. He didn't have to see him to know. The air thickened with his presence, a heat smearing through the damp, and Marlowe heard the scrape of something heavy outside the niche - metal on concrete, slow and patient - then a low, wet sound like someone smiling with their teeth full.

Marlowe forced his eyes to the seam. "This way," he rasped, and the word came out too sharp, too loud, like he'd pulled a needle across the wrong record.

He wanted, more than anything, to stop running in circles that tightened when he looked at them. He wanted the group to stop being scattered into hiding spots that vanished the moment Garrick turned his head. He wanted a place with walls that didn't bend. A place where you could shut a door and make the next sound in the world be silence instead of the hunt.

The bunker mouth sat under the roots like a buried secret. When Marlowe crawled closer, the concrete warmed under his palms, not from sun - there was no sun down here - but from something else, something that made the stone feel alive. Moss clung to it in thick mats, and the air coming from the opening was dry and stale, like old books left in a basement after a flood. Under that smell was something colder: machine plastic, overheated electronics, the faint chemical sweetness of VHS tape.

Behind him, the other Sprunkies huddled and flinched at every crackle of static. One of them - Lina, Marlowe thought, though his mind kept slipping between names and frames - whispered, "It's real?"

"It's real," Marlowe lied, because what else could he say? The laughter in his skull didn't care if it was real. It just wanted them moving.

They shoved through roots that snagged their clothes like hooked fingers. Marlowe's shoulder caught on a knot of wood and he felt the fabric tear with a sound too intimate. He tasted sap and dirt. His tongue went numb with panic, and he shoved forward anyway, because staying put meant Garrick's breathing in their ear. The entrance was narrow, just enough for a body to squeeze, and the concrete around it bore scratches - old, repeated gouges like something had tried to get out and failed.

Then the bunker swallowed them.

Not gently. Not like a doorway opening into a hallway. It felt like sliding into the wrong slot on a cassette player. The air inside was colder, and the walls were too close, too smooth in places where they should've been rough. Marlowe's knees hit concrete and bounced. Somewhere behind him, Lina yelped, then the sound cut off as if muffled by a thick foam.

He turned his head and saw a smear of motion where the entrance should be. The opening had narrowed, roots retracting and shifting, concrete plates sliding with a grinding slowness that didn't match the speed of their bodies. The bunker wasn't just hiding a room. It was adjusting itself around them, like a trap that learned.

Marlowe backed deeper, dragging his hand along the wall. The concrete had a film over it - slick, almost oily - and when he wiped his fingers it left a gray streak that smelled faintly of burnt plastic. The static hiss grew louder in here, and now it wasn't only in his head. It was in the room itself, a faint crackle from the corners, like the air was being recorded.

Garrick's voice - if it was his voice - filtered through the concrete from outside. "Come on," it said, low and satisfied, and Marlowe heard the words warped, stretched, like someone dragging a finger across a tape until the sound tore.

Lina tried to crawl forward again, but a root snapped down across the edge of the opening. It wasn't a branch. It was thick cable, wrapped in moss, and it slammed with a heavy thud that made the bunker shudder. Dust rained from the ceiling. Marlowe gagged on it. He coughed once and the cough turned into a wheeze that wouldn't stop.

The obstacle wasn't only that the door wanted to shut. It was that the bunker wouldn't commit to one shape. Corridors didn't line up. The angles between walls seemed to shift if he stared at them too long. He turned left, then right, and the space folded - subtle at first, then sharp enough to make his shoulder bump empty air that wasn't empty. The air had weight here. It pressed against his chest, forcing him to breathe shallow.

"We need supplies," Marlowe said, more to keep panic from swallowing him than because anyone would argue.

A Sprunki - Garrick's earlier scent still clung to the place like a curse - snapped, "We don't have time to - "

Marlowe cut him off. "There's tapes. There's notes." The words came from nowhere and everywhere, like the static had translated itself into certainty. "Find them. Then we hide. Then we wait."

Wait. Like waiting was something you could do in a bunker that rearranged itself.

They moved, scraping along the walls, and every step came with a new sound: the soft squeal of something shifting behind plaster, the faint click of a latch somewhere that didn't look like it belonged to any visible door. Marlowe found a narrow storage alcove and shoved his fingers into a gap between stacked crates. His nails came back with paper dust and a slick smear of grease.

A label, half-molded by damp, flaked under his touch. He peeled it back anyway and saw handwriting pressed into the paper like it had been written with pressure instead of ink. The letters were smeared, but he could make out one phrase, the kind of phrase the island would steal from a television and twist into a threat: "Stitch: Forbidden Episode."

His stomach dropped. The static in his skull jumped as if it had been waiting for him to read it.

Lina grabbed his wrist so hard it hurt. "What is that?"

Marlowe tried to answer, but his throat wouldn't cooperate. He could only listen to the bunker. The walls made small noises now - thin, rhythmic taps - like something on the other side of the concrete was testing the seam.

He heard Garrick outside again. Not loud, not rushing. Just there, circling. The scrape of his boots slid along stone and then moved away. A pause. Then the scrape returned, closer, as if the bunker's shifting corridors were teaching Garrick new routes.

Marlowe turned and saw that the entrance behind them had changed shape. The opening was still there, but now it looked wrong - too tall, too narrow, with roots braided around it like bars. The bunker's interior didn't give them a straight line back. The corridor they'd crawled through seemed to have rotated, as if the room had turned in place when they weren't looking.

"We came in that way," Lina said, eyes wide. Her voice trembled on the edge of sobbing. "Marlowe - tell me we came in that way."

Marlowe opened his mouth. For a second he couldn't remember which direction "that way" had been. His fear made the memory stutter like a corrupted recording.

The bunker offered another problem: shelves. Old shelves, half-collapsed, lined with dusty VHS tapes in cardboard sleeves. Some had artwork that should've been cheerful - bright colors, cartoon shapes - but the ink had bled, and the images rippled if he focused on them too hard. One sleeve showed a smiling bear with a jagged grin, and the corners of the cardboard were chewed as if something had worried it with teeth.

Marlowe reached for the tape anyway, because his brain had decided the only action left was grabbing proof. His fingers closed around the plastic and it was colder than it should've been, like it had been kept in ice. When he lifted it, the sleeve tore with a dry rip, and a strip of tape spilled out onto the concrete floor like a pale ribbon.

The static hiss surged. For a split second, the room flashed - not with light, but with a frame. A flicker of a distorted face behind the tape glass, grin stretched

too wide, eyes too bright, and then it was gone. Marlowe flinched so hard his shoulder slammed into the wall.

"Don't - " Lina started.

Marlowe didn't stop. He shoved the tape back into the sleeve and grabbed another. His hands shook so badly he nearly dropped them. The air smelled sharper now, acrid, like hot circuitry. His ears rang with the voices, and they weren't only static. They were syllables, promises layered on laughter: watch, watch, watch.

From the corridor, a new sound - metal on concrete, faster this time - spit through the bunker like a warning bullet. Garrick was closer. He was testing the door from the outside, running his weight against it in increments that made the whole bunker shiver.

Marlowe's decision came like a reflex. He shoved tapes into his jacket, stuffed notes into a pocket he didn't have time to check, and grabbed Lina by the shoulder. "Move," he hissed. "We find the main room. We get behind something solid."

Lina's face was slick with sweat and dust. "Behind what? The walls move!"

"Then we make the wall our enemy," Marlowe said, and he didn't know where the sentence came from until it was already out of his mouth.

He ran - ran inside a bunker that felt like it was shrinking around his footsteps. He didn't have room to turn without bumping elbows into concrete. The corridor ahead slanted, then straightened, then turned sharply enough to make his stomach lurch. His breath came in harsh bursts that scraped his throat. Each time his chest expanded, it felt like the air resisted, thickening like wet cloth.

They rounded a bend, and the bend became a wall. Marlowe slammed his palms against concrete and felt it flex under the force, like the bunker had a pulse. He stumbled back, heart hammering so hard his vision swam. Lina cried out, and

Marlowe grabbed her arm before she could hit the corner and fold herself into the gap.

A door waited there - gray, heavy, with a round window that looked like an old television screen. There was a handle, but it didn't sit straight. It rotated slightly when he reached for it, as if the bunker wanted him to grab the wrong thing. The door was sealed with an old-fashioned latch and a strip of tape across the seam.

Marlowe tore the tape strip free. It stuck to his fingers with a tacky pull, and when it came loose it left a smear that smelled like vinegar and burned rubber. The door didn't open.

Instead, the latch clicked once - too loud, too clean - and the bunker answered with a sound from above them, a grinding scrape that traveled through the ceiling and into their bones.

Lina pressed her hand to the door, trembling. "It's closing."

Marlowe yanked the handle again. This time it moved, just a fraction. Cold air poured from the gap, and with it came a smell like old water and dust and something sweet underneath, like a cartoon character's candy left rotting in a landfill.

He pushed. The door gave way an inch more, enough for him to see inside: a cramped room with stacks of dusty tapes, a broken player on a metal table, and walls covered in notes pinned with rusted nails. The handwriting was frantic. He could feel the pressure of it without reading. His eyes caught one line, bold and smeared: "Seven Days..."

He didn't have time to understand the message. The door behind them slammed shut with a brutal finality that made Marlowe's teeth click together. The room they'd just entered lurched, as if the bunker had rotated again to make room for whatever Garrick was doing.

Marlowe spun, pounding the door with his fist. The concrete around the frame shuddered. His knuckles hurt instantly, skin scraping on grit. "Open!" he shouted, and his voice came back warped, squeezed, like it had been pressed through a distorted speaker.

Outside, Garrick's footsteps slowed. Then stopped. Silence stretched thin enough to cut.

A new sound followed - something soft dragging along the other side of the sealed door, like a hand searching for a seam. The static in Marlowe's ears peaked, then sharpened into laughter that sounded close enough to be breathing.

Lina backed away until her shoulders hit the wall of tapes. Her eyes darted to the shelves, to the notes, to the broken player. "Marlowe," she whispered. "The voices - "

Marlowe's gaze snagged on the corner of the room where a tape lay half-unspooled, the plastic ribbon twitching as if alive. The label on it was smudged, but the bear's grin was unmistakable - Stabbington's face, the jagged smile, the knife-shaped shadow.

His hands went numb. He knew, suddenly and sickeningly, that the bunker wasn't just a hiding place. It was an engine. It was built to keep the curse playing until it finished with whoever was inside the frame.

The door didn't move. It didn't open. It just held.

And outside, Garrick began to circle again, slow and deliberate, the scrape of him traveling around the building like a camera tracking shot that refused to stop - until the static in Marlowe's skull resolved into one clear, excited demand, as if the island itself had found the exact moment it wanted.

Marlowe looked at the notes pinned to the wall. His eyes caught the same phrase again, repeated across multiple pages in different hands, different

smears of ink: "Stitch: Forbidden Episode."

Then the broken VHS player on the metal table sparked without power - one violent flicker of light in the dim room. The screen flashed a frame of Stitch's grinning face, stretched wrong, eyes too bright, laughing soundlessly.

Marlowe stumbled back, breath tearing in his chest, and the static laughter in the room deepened - no longer distant, no longer just in his skull - like the bunker had finally found a way to show him what waited behind the glass.

Behind the sealed door, Garrick's voice pressed against the concrete, muffled but eager. "Let me in," it said, and the words sounded like they'd been recorded and played back too many times. "I'm almost there."

Seven Days Written in Tape Notes

Marlowe tasted copper in the back of his throat as the bunker's door finally sealed with a thick, wet thunk that sounded too much like a throat closing. The room around him - equipment benches, rusted shelves, taped-together cables - felt suddenly alive, like the walls had leaned in to listen. Static still crawled through the air anyway, not just from the speakers in the corner but from the corners of his eyes, from the spaces between dust motes where the flicker couldn't decide whether to be light or noise.

Behind the sealed concrete, Garrick's voice pressed through anyway, muffled and hungry. "Let me in." It came again, distorted, as if the bunker was chewing on the words before spitting them back out. "I'm almost there."

Marlowe's hands shook around nothing at all - his fingers kept trying to reach for his missing courage, like it might be clipped to his belt. Lina and Garrick had scattered earlier when the corridors rearranged, but now they were clustered in this small equipment room with the others, breathing too loud. The air smelled like old plastic and damp paper. Somewhere deeper in the bunker, a VHS machine clicked like a heart stuttering.

Marlowe forced his eyes to the notes on the nearest table. Cryptic handwriting crawled across taped pages, underlined so hard the pen had torn the paper. The title line was underlined too: "Stitch: Forbidden Episode." He'd seen it on the damaged cover in the ravine, but here the label felt closer, like it was trying to climb off the page. Beside it, a column of dates was scribbled in a tight, frantic hand. Next to each date, a small mark - like a tally - had been scratched and scratched again until the paper looked bruised.

He wanted answers in a way that hurt. Not guesses. Not fear dressed up as intuition. He wanted to know what the bunker was counting down to and why the word "episode" sat there like a trap door. If there were tapes, there were rules. If there were rules, maybe they could break them. Maybe they could stay alive long enough to find a way out before Stabbington Bear returned to the ravine and sniffed at the bunker's seams with that knife-holding paw.

Lina stood with her back half-pressed to a shelf that creaked as if it disliked being leaned on. "It says seven," she murmured, voice thin. She pointed at the dates. Her fingertip hovered over the marks without touching, like the paper might bite. "Seven days."

Garrick wasn't in the room - he was outside, trapped behind a door that refused to listen to him - but his presence still filled the space through sound. Every time his muffled voice rose, the lights in the room flickered, and Marlowe's stomach tightened as if the bunker was synced to Garrick's panic.

Garrick had been loud about fighting. Lina had been loud about staying smart. Marlowe had been loud inside his own skull, arguing with the part of him that wanted to refuse whatever the bunker wanted. But the notes weren't just warnings. They were instructions written in dread, like whoever made them had already lost something and kept writing anyway.

Garrick's voice came again through the concrete. "Marlowe. Open it. Open it now." The syllables sounded warped, stretched, as if the bunker was replaying his plea from earlier recordings and layering it over itself until it became a single long ache.

Marlowe's eyes snagged on the next page. The handwriting shifted there - still cramped, but sharper, like the pen had been held by someone shaking with anger instead of fear. The warning line wasn't just about watching. It was about what watching did. The bunker had made room for a mechanism, not a myth. A small note at the bottom read like a curse disguised as a schedule: Watch the tape. The days begin.

Lina inhaled and made a sound that wasn't quite a laugh. "Days begin," she said, tasting the words like they were sour. "Like... like a timer."

The room answered her with a sound from the corner: a tape deck sliding forward by itself, dust shivering off its edges. The machine's plastic cover popped open with a click that made Marlowe flinch. No one touched it. No one had time to. The air turned colder, pinching at his skin.

A tangle of cables on the wall twitched, and the bulb above the table flickered into a brief, sickly green. In that green, the ink on the notes looked wet. In that green, the underlines looked like scars.

Marlowe grabbed the top sheet before his hands could betray him. The paper rasped against his fingers, dry but rough, like sandpaper that still remembered being alive. "We need to know what it is," he said, and hated how his voice sounded - too tight, too eager, like he wanted the horror to prove it was real so the fear could stop being abstract.

"There's no 'need,'" Lina snapped, then softened immediately, as if even arguing hurt her. "We could hide. We could wait for Garrick. Stabbington Bear is out there. He - " Her eyes darted toward the closed corridor, toward the door that wouldn't open. "He's hunting. That's what he does."

Marlowe didn't say what he was thinking: that Stabbington Bear could smell them through concrete if the bunker had already decided they were next. He didn't say that the voices - those distant laughs and whispers that had ridden the static through the ravine, through the forest that behaved like a failing signal - felt closer in here. They weren't just in the air now. They were in the walls. In the equipment. In the way the lights blinked like corrupted frames.

A thin giggle threaded through the room. It wasn't loud. It didn't need to be. It came from the tape deck's open bay, from the gap between plastic and metal, from somewhere behind the machine's speaker grill.

Lina froze. "Did you hear that?"

Marlowe heard it too - felt it more than heard it, a vibration under his teeth. He stared at the open bay where a tape should have been lying. There was nothing there. Then, like a delayed thought, black plastic slid into view on its own, warped slightly at the edges, label peeling.

"Stitch: Forbidden Episode," the label read, but the letters weren't stable. They wavered as if the ink was struggling to stay spelled. When the lights flickered again, the title looked different for half a second - like "Stitch" was being erased and redrawn with thicker strokes.

Marlowe's skin prickled. He hated the way his mind leaned toward it anyway. The way curiosity turned into a hunger for certainty. The way fear didn't stop him; it guided him, like the voices had always done.

He reached for the tape.

Lina slapped his wrist hard enough to make him yelp. Her palm was damp with sweat. "No." Her eyes shone too bright. "Marlowe, don't. The notes - "

"The notes say seven days," he shot back, and the words came out sharper than he intended. "Seven days left if we watch. Or seven days left anyway if we don't. We need to know what's true."

The giggle returned, closer. Now it sounded like it was coming from behind Marlowe's left ear, like someone standing too near in a dark hallway. His breath came fast and loud, fogging the air in front of his mouth.

Lina stared at the tape deck like it was a mouth. "Or maybe it's already started," she whispered. "Maybe it starts the moment we read the warning."

Marlowe wanted to argue, wanted to prove her wrong with logic. But logic didn't survive the way the room shifted - how the corners felt slightly closer than they had a minute ago, how the floorboards creaked in a rhythm that didn't match anyone's footsteps. The bunker felt like it was tightening its grip around them, not just trapping them but compressing the time between breaths.

A new page slid out from under the stack of notes by itself, paper dragging over paper with a soft, intimate sound. Marlowe didn't touch it. It just unfolded, creasing in the middle as if something inside the paper was pushing.

On it, the handwriting looked different again - less frantic, more certain. The words were blunt, like an obituary disguised as a rule.

If you stop it, it plays anyway.

Marlowe swallowed. The copper taste intensified. Somewhere behind him, another Sprunki shifted - someone breathing too shallow, like they were trying not to exist. The bunker's bulb flickered, and for a split second the room wasn't the room. The shelves looked longer. The bench looked deeper, as if the walls were stretching the way VHS distortion stretches faces.

Then the lights steadied back into sickly dimness, and the only thing that felt real was the tape deck and the tape sitting in it like a loaded weapon.

Marlowe's hands moved before his brain finished debating. He pulled the tape from the bay and shoved it into the slot. The machine accepted it with a soft chattering sound, like teeth clicking into place.

Lina grabbed his shoulders, nails digging through his fabric. "If you do this, you can't pretend it wasn't your choice," she said, voice raw. "You can't bargain with it after."

Marlowe stared at her. Her eyes were terrified in a way he recognized - fear that wanted to be righteous, fear that wanted to be righteous so it could be safe. "I'm not bargaining," he said. He heard his own voice shake. "I'm trying to stop it from winning."

The tape deck whirred, motor whining as it threaded tape through gears that looked too old for something this specific. The screen connected to the machine - an old CRT monitor - flickered to life. Its surface smelled faintly of warm dust

and plastic. The corners of the image crawled with static, lines jittering like a swarm.

For a moment, the monitor showed a bright cartoon set - cheery colors washed in a way that made Marlowe's stomach twist. It looked harmless. It looked like the kind of thing Sprunkies in other places might watch to calm down during storms.

A childlike theme song blared through the speakers, tinny and cheerful, and the walls seemed to vibrate with it. Marlowe flinched at the contrast: sweet sound in a room that felt like a trap.

Lina whispered, "No way..."

On the screen, characters bounced and waved. Simple shapes, simple smiles. Then the image glitched. The edges of the cartoon characters jittered, as if someone had smeared them with a dirty thumb. Static surged and the cheer cut out mid-note.

A new frame flickered in - only a blink - greenish and wrong, like a throat lit from the inside. Stitch's grin flashed across the screen, distorted and stretched, not quite fitting the picture. It wasn't close enough to touch, but it was close enough to be seen. The grin lingered for less than a second, then tore away into static like a film strip snapping.

The theme song tried to restart. It stuttered. The monitor's scan lines bled into each other.

Marlowe felt the countdown ink in the notes turn heavy in his mind. Seven days. A number that suddenly didn't feel like mercy or warning. It felt like a collar you were only allowed to feel once it tightened.

Lina let go of his shoulders. Her hands hovered near the screen, trembling. "It's - it's showing it," she said.

The tape resumed as if nothing had happened. The cartoon characters returned, smiling too wide, too fixed. Their mouths moved in a way that didn't match the audio. The voices were wrong - layered with whispers that sounded like they were being recorded in a room without air. Marlowe pressed his palms to his ears and still couldn't stop hearing it.

Stitch's laughter bubbled up under the cartoon giggles, delayed, like a predator savoring a timing mistake.

The monitor showed a cheerful scene - bright walls, a simple door. A character reached for the door handle.

The image tore.

For one violent second, the door wasn't a door anymore. It was a mouth full of wet teeth, lit by the same greenish glow that had flashed when Stitch's grin appeared. The cartoon character's hand stretched toward it, fingers bending wrong, nails too long, skin turning translucent at the fingertips.

The screen snapped back to the cheerful set. The character continued waving. The audio kept playing, cheerful and intact - until it wasn't. The theme song warped into a thin, squealing sound like tape being chewed.

Marlowe staggered back from the monitor. His knees bumped the bench. Metal rang painfully. The bunker's walls answered by creaking - slow, deliberate, like something shifting weight.

The giggle became a chorus, not just from the speaker. It crawled through the room's corners, through the cables, through the notes on the table. The ink on the pages began to look like it was moving, underlines sliding like bruises spreading.

Lina's face went pale. "Marlowe," she breathed. "It's not - it's not just watching."

Marlowe stared at the screen again, because denying it felt useless. The cartoon scene changed - fast, too fast - like the tape was skipping ahead. A new character appeared, smaller, as if the video was being compressed. Their smile flickered with static.

Then the smile broke.

Stitch appeared - not as a flash this time, but as a presence filling the frame. His grin was too large, his teeth too close to the camera. The frame warped around him like the tape couldn't hold him. His mouth opened and the audio turned into wet ripping sounds, layered with laughter.

Marlowe's stomach lurched. The smell hit next - hot plastic, sour rot, something wet and animal that didn't belong in a children's episode. It filled the small room so fast his eyes watered.

On the screen, Stitch's mouth devoured the cartoon character in jerking, glitchy motions, each bite accompanied by a stutter of frames that made the death feel stretched across time like film spliced wrong. The character kicked, limbs jerking in sync with the video's corrupted rhythm. Their screams were swallowed by laughter.

The monitor's picture smeared. For a heartbeat, the devouring wasn't only on the screen. The air in the equipment room felt like it was being pulled toward the monitor, like suction. Marlowe's hair lifted at his scalp. His ears popped.

Lina choked on a sob. "Stop it," she said, and her voice sounded small now, swallowed by the bunker's oppressive hum.

Marlowe tried to reach for the power switch on the monitor. His hand jerked in the wrong direction. The switch was there, inches away, but the distance felt wrong - like the bunker had stretched the space between his fingers and the control. He grabbed anyway, knuckles scraping metal, and the switch depressed with a click.

The monitor did not turn off.

Instead, the image sharpened.

The cheerful set returned for half a second, bright and innocent, before the door-mouth reappeared and swallowed another character. Stitch's grin flickered again, and this time it angled toward the camera as if it knew where the audience sat. As if it could recognize eyes.

Marlowe's breath came in ragged pulls. He tasted bile. His arms felt heavy, soaked in sweat that cooled too quickly, then warmed again as if the bunker couldn't decide on temperature. His mind kept trying to calculate the seven days like a life raft.

Then the notes on the table began to hum.

Not aloud. Not audibly. The paper vibrated under the air, and Marlowe realized the ink had started to change - dates shifting, marks deepening. The countdown wasn't written on paper anymore. It was written into the room itself, into the flicker of the lights and the jitter of the CRT.

Lina backed away from the table, eyes fixed on the notes. "It's counting," she said. "It's counting down to... to what?"

Marlowe couldn't answer. He couldn't even think clearly enough to lie.

The tape kept playing. Stitch's laughter threaded through the cartoon audio until the cheerful voice sounded like it had been dragged through gravel. The devouring scene repeated with slight distortions - different characters, different angles, but always the same grin, always the same wet tearing, always the same glitch that made the death look like it had been edited by someone who enjoyed breaking time.

Behind the equipment room's walls, Garrick's voice slammed against concrete again and again, muffled and frantic. "Marlowe!" The bunker shook in response,

like it was enjoying the struggle outside. "Marlowe, please - "

The lights flickered green.

For a split second, the corners of the room were too close. The ceiling lowered. The space between Marlowe and Lina narrowed until their shoulders brushed. The air thickened with static and the smell of hot plastic turned sour, turning into something like blood left too long in a warm sink.

Marlowe understood, with an awful clarity that came from inside his bones instead of his brain: the tape wasn't showing them a curse. It was feeding the curse with attention. It was making their fear part of the mechanism.

Seven days wasn't a warning.

It was a leash.

He stood there trembling while the CRT fed Stitch's grin to the room, and the bunker tightened around the sound. The notes on the table stopped looking like ink and started looking like scars. Lina's breath hitched, her eyes glassy with a terror too immediate to be denial.

Marlowe reached for the tape deck again, desperate to yank the tape out, to break whatever thread the bunker had tied between the screen and their bodies.

His fingers closed on the cassette casing.

It was warm - too warm - like it had been sitting in a mouth.

He jerked his hand back, and the smell that clung to his skin wasn't plastic anymore. It was wet fur and metal and something sweetly rotten, the kind of scent that made his stomach twist even before his mind named it.

On the screen, Stitch's grin widened.

The image glitched, and for one horrible frame, Stitch's face wasn't on the monitor at all. It was in the room - right there in the equipment room's green flicker, too close to be screen, too wrong to be reflection - watching, teeth too many, laughter too delighted.

Then it snapped back to the cartoon set, bright and innocent again, as if nothing had happened.

Marlowe's knees buckled. He grabbed the bench edge, metal biting through his sweat, and the bunker's hum deepened like a throat clearing.

Somewhere in the walls, something clicked into place. Not a lock.

A start. A count.

The tape played on, and the seven days became a thing they could feel creeping forward with every frame.

Marlowe Runs While the Walls Glitch

The tape didn't just distort - it tore. One moment the screen had been bright enough to feel harmless, the next the colors stuttered into sickly greens and bruised reds, and Stitch's grin crawled across the frame like something alive under the plastic. Marlowe saw characters open their mouths in mid-laugh and then mid-scream, teeth too many, hands too long, and Stitch's shape devoured them frame by frame while the VHS audio warped into a wet, delighted chortle. The sound crawled off the monitor and into the bones behind his ears.

"Stop," Marlowe rasped, but his voice came out thin, already swallowed by the bunker's low hum. The walls around him felt closer than they had seconds ago - concrete sweating cold, corners pinched by invisible hands. Somewhere beyond the room, the sealed door shuddered as if someone kept testing it from the other side. Garrick's presence was still there, still pressing, and the tape kept laughing like it could hear him.

Marlowe yanked the tape out of the player anyway, fingers clumsy from panic, and the cassette came away slick with static heat. The moment the label cleared the slot, the bunker's air changed. Not warmer or colder - closer, like the room had decided to keep him. He shoved the cassette into his pocket, not caring if it cut into his skin, and turned toward the hallway where the others had gone to find a way out.

He wanted the exit. He wanted it now, before the seven days could turn into a countdown he could feel chewing through his ribs. Marlowe had tried to tell himself the tape notes were just notes - ink on paper, old handwriting, a

warning scrawled by someone who didn't understand what they were writing. But now Stitch was inside the distortion, inside the sound, inside the way the bunker's lights flickered in time with that devouring laughter. He could still see the frame where Stitch leaned closer to the camera, eyes bright and wrong, as if he were watching Marlowe watch him.

"Marlowe!" Lina's voice carried faintly from deeper in the bunker, muffled by walls that didn't stay put. "Where are you - "

"I'm going." He didn't wait for an answer. The corridor stretched ahead with the same old-painted cinderblock he'd seen moments ago, except the floor tiles looked slightly misaligned, like the hallway had been spliced and reassembled wrong. He moved fast, because fast was the only way his lungs could pretend they weren't filling with panic-breath. His sneakers slapped against concrete. Every step sounded too loud, too crisp, like he was walking inside a recording.

The hallway greeted him with a stutter.

He reached a corner and the world refused to stay square. The bend that should have led to the exit corridor swung sideways, and the fluorescent light above it blinked - once, twice - then steadied with a different hum, a different rhythm. Marlowe skidded, catching himself on a wall that felt wet under his palm. It wasn't rain. It was condensation, but it spread in thin streaks like something was sweating from the inside.

"Don't - " he began, and then the bunker answered him with a sound like tape being rewound too hard. A low mechanical whine dragged through the concrete. The air shivered. His breath fogged and then cleared too quickly, as if the temperature had been edited out.

He forced himself forward. "Lina!" His voice bounced back wrong, returning with a slight delay that made it feel like the bunker was looping his speech. Somewhere behind him, the tape in his pocket clicked as if the cassette had its own teeth.

The next obstacle wasn't a door. It was a hallway that remembered him.

Marlowe ran. He didn't think about how he'd learned the route from memory - he just let his body follow the idea of escape. The corridor narrowed without warning. The ceiling dipped a fraction, compressing sound and air until even his footsteps felt muffled, dampened like running through thick carpet. The walls drew in by degrees so subtle he could pretend he was imagining it until he turned his shoulder and it scraped concrete with a sharp sting.

"Ah - fuck!" He yanked his arm back, fingers vibrating with pain. The wall where he'd hit it had a seam now. A thin vertical line, fresh and pale, like cement had been cut and stitched. The seam pulsed once, just once, like it was alive.

He kept going, because turning back meant admitting the bunker had already decided.

The hallway folded mid-sprint. Not like a collapse - like the space itself was being spliced. One second he was chasing the end of the corridor where light spilled faintly under a door. The next second the door was gone, and the corridor looked the same but wrong in the way a picture looks wrong after you've stared at it too long. The numbers stenciled above the light fixture - he hadn't noticed them before - now read different. The last digit had shifted.

Marlowe's pocket felt heavier. The cassette shifted against his thigh, and heat radiated through denim in pulses. The tape wasn't just cursed; it was warm like something breathing. When he stopped running for a fraction of a second to adjust his grip, the bunker used the pause to steal him forward. The corridor lengthened. The distance to where he'd seen the door stretched like a bad VHS tracking line.

"Stop playing games," he shouted, and his words came back brittle, distorted. The laughter from the tape - maybe from the pocket, maybe from the walls - rose in volume for half a beat, then dipped, like Stitch was listening for his reaction.

Marlowe's heart hammered so hard it made his vision swim. His lungs burned with the kind of exhaustion that didn't come from distance but from fear that wouldn't let him settle into rhythm. He could taste metal, coppery and stale, as if his mouth were already preparing for blood. Sweat slicked his neck. His shirt stuck to his spine.

He could hear Garrick somewhere close - outside, through concrete, muffled but unmistakable by the shape of menace in it. A thud. A scrape. Then Garrick's voice, low and furious, pressed through the bunker like a blade through cloth.

"You think you can run?" Garrick rasped, distorted by distance that didn't behave. "Marlowe - come out."

Marlowe didn't answer. The bunker's corridors were changing too fast for conversation. He needed the exit. He needed to warn Lina and the others before the curse finished whatever it started when the tape devoured those characters. He had seen the note about seven days. He had watched the tape distort into Stitch. He knew what waiting did.

Decision became action because there was no room left for doubt.

Marlowe took a breath and slammed his shoulder into the wall where he'd hit concrete earlier. Pain flared - hot and immediate - but he didn't slow. He shoved again, harder, until his shoulder felt like it was grinding against stone. The seam pulsed under his palm, and the wall shifted - not outward, not breaking, but reconfiguring. A new passage opened where there hadn't been one. Narrow. Black. A gap between walls like a cut in reality.

"Here," he choked out, and sprinted toward it.

The passage swallowed sound. His footsteps dampened instantly, his breathing turned to a wet rasp. The walls on both sides were too close now - close enough that he could feel the vibration of his own body through the concrete. He twisted through the opening with his arms out, palms skimming the surface

for balance. The air smelled like old paper and rust, but underneath it was something sour, like sweat trapped in fabric for days.

He stumbled into the cramped corridor and nearly bit his tongue when his teeth clicked against a protruding pipe. The pipe was cold enough to numb his lip. He tasted blood anyway - tiny, metallic, undeniable.

Behind him, the main hallway's fluorescent light flickered, and the corridor he'd entered shivered as if it were being rewound. Marlowe ran faster, forcing his legs to obey even as exhaustion turned heavy and sluggish. His calves cramped with every step. His lungs dragged air like it was thick syrup.

"Lina!" he called again, but the sound came back as a warped echo, stretched and shortened, as if the bunker was trying to decide what his name should sound like.

Then he heard something else - knife metal, sharp and intimate, scraping against something hard.

Garrick.

The sound drew closer, not because Garrick ran faster, but because the bunker rearranged distance to put him where he was needed. Marlowe's skin crawled. He spun around without meaning to, nearly tripping in the narrow passage, and saw the corridor behind him fold in the wrong direction. The opening he'd come through narrowed, pinching like a closing mouth.

Marlowe's throat tightened. He tried to backpedal, but the passage contracted. His shoulder scraped again, this time deeper, and his shirt tore with a ripping sound that made him wince so hard his eyes watered.

"No," he hissed, and shoved forward into the darkness, trusting momentum more than logic.

He burst into a tight side passage barely wide enough for his body. The floor slanted, and the walls seemed to breathe - shifting by millimeters, then centimeters. The corridor glitched at the edges: for an instant the concrete pattern duplicated, repeating like a frame held too long. Marlowe blinked, and the world snapped back, but his stomach dropped like he'd stepped into a hole.

The bunker's light - what little there was - flickered. In the dimness, a strip of reflected metal caught his eye.

A knife.

Not his. Not the tape's metal tang. Garrick's knife - leather-handled blade held in a paw-like grip, raised at the perfect height for someone lunging. Garrick wasn't supposed to be in here. Garrick wasn't supposed to be inside the walls.

But the passage ahead had become a stage, and Garrick stood at the far end of it, close enough that Marlowe could see the tension in his posture and the slick wet shine of his breath.

"Marlowe," Garrick said again, and his voice was rougher now, as if he'd already yelled until his throat was raw. "Come here."

Marlowe tried to run past him. His body turned sideways to squeeze through the narrowing gap, eyes locked on Garrick's knife tip. He could see the edge. He could see the way it caught the light, how it looked almost too bright for something meant to cut. He heard the scrape of it against concrete as Garrick adjusted his grip, patient and certain.

Marlowe lunged.

The corridor answered with collapse.

Not a crash - more like the passage had been cut out and replaced with a different section of hallway. The concrete walls jerked inward, the floor pitching up under his feet. The narrow space twisted. Marlowe's shoulder slammed into

a wall so hard his arm went numb, and the impact vibrated up into his teeth. The air exploded out of him in a ragged cough.

For one awful second, his vision filled with moving concrete patterns - repeating squares, wrong angles, the kind of visual distortion you got when a VHS tape lost its tracking. The world stuttered. Then the passage folded completely closed behind him with a sound like a door being slammed by something too strong.

Marlowe hit the new wall hard enough to taste blood again. He clawed at the seam where the corridor had been, fingers scraping until his nails burned. The concrete didn't give. It pulsed once, like the bunker was amused.

"Marlowe," Garrick's voice came from the other side, now muffled and farther away at the same time, like the bunker had changed distance settings. "You can't leave."

Marlowe pressed his forehead to the wall, breathing in shallow, panicked bursts. His pocket felt like it was vibrating. The cassette label - *Stitch: Forbidden Episode* - was warm through denim, warm enough to feel alive. The tape's laughter slid into the room's silence, creeping through the concrete as if the bunker had become a speaker.

From somewhere inside the wall, a faint giggle answered, and it sounded like it was coming from too many places at once.

Marlowe backed away from the sealed passage, shaking with exhaustion and fear. His muscles trembled. His legs ached with cramps that felt like they were tightening from the outside inward. He turned toward what he hoped was another way out, toward any hint of a corridor that might still be willing to be escape.

The hallway in front of him stretched... and then didn't.

It was the same corridor, the same cinderblock and fluorescent hum, but the direction was wrong. The light flickered in a rhythm that matched the tape's devouring laughter. The end of the hallway moved farther away the moment he committed to running again, like the bunker was dragging the goal just out of reach.

Marlowe sprinted anyway, because stopping meant listening to Stitch.

Behind him, the wall stayed shut. Ahead, the corridor glitched at the edges, folding into itself like tape doors misaligning mid-play, and with every frantic step the bunker narrowed further, compressing his world down to the length of a single breath.



Garrick Forces Eyes Open

The leather-handled blade in Stabbington Bear's paw scraped a seam of air as he shoved forward, forcing his weight into a corridor that didn't want him. His ribs slammed against the narrowing walls, fur catching on damp concrete grit, and the corridor angled down like a picture tilting on a cracked TV screen. Behind him, the last of Marlowe's sprinting echoes had already thinned into static - thin enough to pretend it was nothing, loud enough to make Stabbington Bear's jaw ache with want.

He could smell the bunker on his breath. Old dust. Wet metal. Something sweet underneath it all, like spilled soda left to curdle in the dark. Every time the bunker shifted, the smell shifted too, as if the air itself was being rewound and fast-forwarded without permission.

The voices had followed him anyway. Not footsteps. Not breath. The voices were inside the walls, inside the gaps between frames, excited like children watching a tape start to roll.

"Open your eyes," the whispers crooned.

Stabbington Bear growled, low and ugly. "I have eyes."

A faint giggle answered from somewhere deeper - closer than the last time, wrong in the way it timed itself with his heart. Then the corridor ahead glitched: a ripple ran across the concrete, and for half a blink the wall became a screen. Stitch's grin flashed there, too bright and too wet, and Stabbington Bear's stomach flipped like the tape had caught on a splice.

He couldn't afford to be slowed by fear. He'd learned that much. He'd learned that what waited behind those corrupted glimpses only grew hungrier when he hesitated.

So he lunged, shouldering through the bend, and his shoulder caught on a jutting pipe that wasn't there a moment ago. The impact jarred his paw; the knife skittered, scraping stone, then he snatched it back with a jerk that made his wrist sting. The corridor narrowed further, compressing his world to a fistful of space - his fur brushing both sides at once, his breath tasting like pennies.

A Sprunkie's sound broke through the static ahead: a frantic, staccato squeak - too close to be far, too muffled to be right in front of him. It came with the wet scuff of feet on something that wasn't quite floor. Stabbington Bear tasted panic in the air, sharp and metallic, and the voices sang louder, impatient.

He wanted the viewing. He wanted the curse to take hold again.

The bunker had shown him that the tape didn't just punish - it fed. It demanded witnesses. It demanded eyes that wouldn't look away.

Stabbington Bear could almost hear Stitch laughing at the thought of it, like a needle dragging across tape.

He rounded the corner and found a storage nook barely big enough for a bear to fit. Shelving leaned inward, overcrowded with cardboard boxes and plastic bins swollen from damp. The light was wrong - too green, too flickery - as if the bulbs were trying to decide what color they wanted to be. A VHS player sat on a low workbench like it belonged here, like someone had been using it in secret and never stopped.

The tape label was there, too, smeared by fingerprints that weren't his. Thick black letters on white plastic: STITCH: FORBIDDEN EPISODE.

Stabbington Bear's throat tightened. The voices pressed in until they were almost a physical thing, a chorus leaning into his ear.

"Again," they hissed.

He moved to the bench, knife raised, and that was when he saw the Sprunkie.

Marlo - no. Not Marlowe. Another one. A smaller Sprunkie with a face streaked in mud and a bright color still trying to look cheerful under the grime. It had crawled behind a stack of warped boxes, knees tucked, hands scrabbling for something to hold onto. The Sprunkie's eyes were wide enough to swallow the whites.

It didn't speak. It made a sound like breath tearing. Like a squeal trying to become a prayer.

Stabbington Bear's hunger and voices braided together into one command. He stepped forward and the air tasted suddenly colder, as if the nook had exhaled.

The Sprunkie scrambled back, bumping shelving. The shelves shuddered. Boxes slid and then - wrongly - stuttered, as if the bunker couldn't decide where they should be in the timeline. One box lurched sideways and knocked into another, and the collision echoed with a delay, like bad audio.

Stabbington Bear lunged anyway.

The knife didn't need finesse. It needed contact. He grabbed the Sprunkie by the torso, felt fabric stretch and then give, and the Sprunkie kicked, heel scraping plastic bin edges with a shriek that made Stabbington Bear's teeth buzz. The Sprunkie's body was slick with sweat, and its fingers clawed at his fur, leaving damp trails that smelled like sour fruit.

"Don't," the Sprunkie rasped, voice cracking as if it had been forced through a cheap speaker.

Stabbington Bear lowered his head, and the voices surged, ecstatic.

"Watch," they sang.

He dragged the Sprunkie out from the hiding place. The nook seemed to shrink in response, walls inching closer with each violent yank. His shoulder scraped the shelf until it burned. A box toppled and collapsed around the bench, but the bunker corrected itself mid-fall - wood planks snapping into different positions, as if the space was being edited while he moved through it. The Sprunkie's scream cut off and reappeared a beat later, chopped and warped like sound through static.

The VHS player's screen glowed dimly, waiting.

The Sprunkie twisted in Stabbington Bear's grip, eyes darting toward the bench and away, back and away again. Panic made its pupils shake.

"No - no - " it choked.

Stabbington Bear felt the voices pull him closer, not by force of will but by the bunker's shifting geometry. The corridor behind him seemed longer now. The door that might have led out had become a wall of shelving and damp concrete, and the nook's ceiling lowered a fraction as he moved, like the bunker was pressing him into the task.

He grabbed the tape with a claw and slammed it into the player. The plastic case clicked with a sound too clean for the grime around it. The player whirled, gears catching, then the screen bloomed with the first frame.

A childlike cartoon intro - colors too bright, music too cheerful - spilled across the green light. The Sprunkie flinched at the sudden innocence, as if it hurt worse than the horror.

Stitch's laughter flickered beneath the tune, faint at first, like a laugh heard through a wall.

Stabbington Bear held the Sprunkie's face closer to the screen.

"Eyes," the voices demanded.

The Sprunkie fought, jerking its head away. Its cheek smacked against Stabbington Bear's knuckles, teeth clicking. The leather-handled knife was still in his other paw, and he could feel the Sprunkie's body tremble with the fear of being cut again.

"Please - please stop!" the Sprunkie sobbed, not to Stabbington Bear - never fully to him. It seemed to be bargaining with the sound itself, the hum of the player.

Stabbington Bear's grip tightened until the Sprunkie's fabric bunched painfully. The Sprunkie's eyes watered instantly. Tears streaked down its muzzle, catching the screen's flicker and turning into tiny reflective puddles.

Stitch's grin flashed in the cartoon frame, then dissolved into static. The screen stuttered like a tape being chewed.

The voices rose, louder than the player now. They didn't ask. They commanded.

Stabbington Bear forced the Sprunkie's gaze forward with a brutal patience. He tilted the Sprunkie's chin up, thumb pressing where the skin dipped and the neck thinned, and the Sprunkie's breath hitched as if it had been yanked by a hook.

The Sprunkie's eyes locked on the screen.

For a moment, it looked almost relieved - like it had found what it was supposed to look at, like obedience would earn mercy.

Then the tape corrected itself into something worse.

The cartoon's bright colors bled into sickly greens and bruised purples. Lines that should have been clean became jagged, crawling, as if the ink was trying to escape the screen. Stitch's face appeared behind the smiling characters for a fraction too long, and the laughter that followed wasn't music anymore. It was wet, hungry, delighted.

The Sprunkie jerked, but Stabbington Bear's grip held.

"No - stop!" it screamed, voice turning hoarse, eyes glassy as the curse took root.

The screen glitched harder. Stitch's grin expanded, stretching past the boundaries of the frame like it was being pulled by invisible hands. Teeth showed in a way that wasn't cartoonish at all - too real, too dark between them. The Sprunkie's pupils dilated until the irises looked like bruises.

Stitch's laugh echoed around the nook, and the bunker answered it. The walls shuddered, shelves rattling as if someone upstairs had slammed a fist. The air thickened, syrupy with static. Stabbington Bear could taste it on his tongue: metallic and electrical, like licking a battery.

The Sprunkie started to shake so violently its entire body made a stuttering blur. It tried to clamp its eyes shut, but the lids couldn't cooperate. The more it resisted, the more its gaze skittered back to the screen as if the curse had built a hook inside its skull.

"Seven days!" the voices chanted, delighted and hungry. "Seven days!"

The Sprunkie heard it. Stabbington Bear could tell because the Sprunkie's mouth opened on a silent gasp, then the sound burst out in a raw sob.

"I don't - I don't want - " it choked.

Stabbington Bear watched the Sprunkie's frantic reaction like he was feeding. It wasn't satisfaction exactly. It was need - an ache that only tightened when the curse intensified.

The tape began to warp faster. Frames skipped. The cartoon characters flickered into outlines of bodies being pulled apart, then snapping back to innocence for a second like a cruel joke. Stitch's grin appeared in the

background of the set - behind props, behind curtains, behind the very idea of distance - always just out of reach, always closer than it should be.

The nook's ceiling lowered again. Stabbington Bear's fur brushed it. His shoulders cramped. The walls pressed in until he had to choose between breathing and keeping the Sprunkie's eyes pinned to the screen.

He chose the screen.

The Sprunkie's screams turned sharp, animal. Its hands clawed at Stabbington Bear's wrist, trying to pry him away. Its fingers left red marks through his fur. The smell of blood rose - warm, coppery - mixed with that sweet curdled soda scent from the bunker.

Stabbington Bear's exhaustion clawed at him too. Not the kind that came from running - this was deeper. His legs felt like they were full of stones, and every movement dragged. The voices didn't care. They only grew louder, like they were pumping adrenaline through the bunker's walls.

Stabbington Bear leaned closer, forcing the Sprunkie forward until its forehead nearly touched the vibrating glass of the TV.

The screen flashed white.

For one sick blink, Stabbington Bear saw Stitch not on the tape, but reflected in the Sprunkie's eyes - grinning behind the pupil, too close, too personal. The reflection moved half a second out of sync with the tape, as if Stitch was watching from a different version of the room.

Stabbington Bear flinched, just for a breath.

The Sprunkie took advantage of that breath.

It bucked hard, twisting its torso like it could slip free through bone and muscle. Its shoulder slammed into Stabbington Bear's chest, and the impact knocked him back a step. The knife paw swung wide, scraping the edge of the bench.

The VHS player jolted. The tape spun faster, whining, and the screen glitched with a seizure of color.

The Sprunkie tore free - barely. It rolled across the floor and scrambled toward the only shadowy corner that looked like an exit. It skidded on damp dust. Its feet slapped slick concrete, and it hit the floor hard enough to leave an ugly smear.

Stabbington Bear lunged again, but the bunker stole his footing.

The floor under his left paw didn't stay floor. It rippled and angled, like a floor being edited mid-motion. His paw slid on something that wasn't there - slick plastic, then cold mud, then bare concrete. His body pitched sideways. The knife struck the ground with a clang that rang too long.

The Sprunkie scrambled, head low, eyes darting between the screen and the corridor that had become a wall and then, for one nauseating second, a corridor again.

Stitch's laughter crackled from the player.

Stabbington Bear straightened, breath rasping in his throat, and the voices surged into a new hunger. They weren't just telling him to force watching. They were telling him to hurry. To do it again. To do it now.

He grabbed the Sprunkie by the back of its shirt - fabric tearing with a wet sound - and yanked it upright. The Sprunkie whined, face contorted in pain and terror, and its eyes flicked to the screen with betrayal in them, like the curse had already stolen the ability to choose.

"No," the Sprunkie whispered. "No, no, no - "

The tape hit a new distortion. Stitch's face split across the screen in jagged slices, each slice showing a different moment of the same grin. The laughter

became layered, too many giggles at once, all of them close enough to be breathed into.

The Sprunkie's pupils went huge.

Its mouth opened, trembling, and the words came out like a confession pulled from a throat that didn't want to speak.

"Seven days," it said, and the way it said it wasn't fear anymore. It was recognition. Like it had always known.

Stabbington Bear held the Sprunkie's gaze there, even as the bunker buckled around them. The walls creaked. Shelves leaned. The nook felt like it was folding inward on itself, compressing the air until Stabbington Bear's lungs burned.

The screen glitched so violently the picture stuttered into a smear of Stitch's grin and the cartoon's innocent faces, layered like a bad memory being overwritten. For a fraction of time, the screen went black, and in that blackness Stabbington Bear saw Stitch again - standing too close, grinning with wet teeth - then the tape snapped back to the cartoon like nothing had happened.

The Sprunkie screamed until its voice broke.

It thrashed, but the curse kept its eyes locked. The bunker seemed to tighten around the viewing, sealing the nook into a trap built out of frames and panic. Stabbington Bear could hear the voices riding the whine of the player, louder now, eager, as if each forced viewing made the bunker better at finding victims.

Stabbington Bear's exhaustion roared at him, heavy and suffocating. His fur was damp with sweat. His shoulders ached where the walls had scraped him. His grip tightened anyway because stopping meant losing the moment, and losing the moment meant Stitch would laugh somewhere else and he would have to chase that laughter all over again.

The tape's corruption surged another step. Stitch's grin bled into the cartoon's background so thoroughly it looked like the entire room was the screen. The green light turned sickly and the air tasted like hot static.

The Sprunkie's frantic reaction confirmed it - confirmed it in the way its eyes stopped searching for escape and started tracking the screen like it was a mouth.

"Please - " it sobbed, and even that plea sounded like it was being dragged through a speaker.

Stabbington Bear watched the tape glitch harder, watched the forced viewing take hold faster than it had before, and felt the voices swell with satisfaction. The bunker didn't feel merely alive now. It felt trained. Like it had learned how to make the eyes stay open.

Behind the Sprunkie, the shelves shifted again, and a new gap opened in the wall - just enough space for someone to run through if they were fast enough, if their body fit the geometry the bunker allowed.

Stabbington Bear didn't let go. Not yet.

He kept the Sprunkie's gaze on the cursed screen as the colors curdled and Stitch's laughter multiplied, and in the flickering light he saw the tape's frame smear toward something worse than devouring - something like an invitation.

Then the player's picture snapped, violently stable for half a heartbeat, and Stabbington Bear saw Stitch's grin fill the entire screen.

The Sprunkie jerked like it had been struck.

Stabbington Bear leaned in, knife still raised, and listened to the bunker's shifting walls click into a new arrangement - one that promised the viewing would happen again, and again, until the curse had nowhere left to hide.



The Cave Where the Tape Breathes

Juniper Sprunkie's breath came out in wet, broken puffs that sounded too loud in the dark. "No," she whispered, then swallowed the word like it could choke her throat shut. Behind her, the bunker corridor wasn't just rearranging anymore - it was chewing. The air on her back tasted like old plastic and rust, and every time the walls clicked, the sound traveled through the stone like teeth grinding.

Something scraped in the black. Not claws. Not paws. A drag, slow and deliberate, like a tape being rewound by a hand that didn't care if it tore.

Stabbington Bear's voice - ragged, excited, chewing the same syllables until they turned into a command - threaded through the cave mouth. "Juniper."

The name landed wrong, too close, as if it had been pressed from the inside of her skull.

She didn't answer. She pressed her shoulder against the slick rock and forced herself to keep still. The cave was damp enough to make her fur sweat, damp enough that her tears cooled instantly against her cheeks. The darkness here felt thick, like it had weight. Like if she moved the wrong way, the dark would take her shape and hold it.

Then the tape-light breathed.

It wasn't a real light source - more like a pulse that carried sound without being heard. Pale flickers, greenish and sickly, washed over the wet stone in short bursts, and with each burst the cave walls seemed to inhale. The darkness

tightened around the edges, narrowing the space between her and the exit she couldn't see.

Juniper's first instinct was to run deeper, away from the cave mouth where Stabbington would come in. Her second instinct was to hold her breath and hope the dark would swallow him the way it swallowed her footsteps. In the space between those instincts, the third thing happened: a glitch frame snapped across the cave like a bad video cut.

For a fraction of a second, Stitch's grin appeared on the far wall - too large, too wrong, drawn in the sheen of moisture. His stitched mouth stretched wider than any bear could bite through, and his teeth looked like thumbnails of tape frames, all jagged black-and-white. He wasn't fully there. He flickered at the edges like a signal struggling to lock.

Juniper's stomach rolled.

It wasn't just that she'd seen Stitch before, in the bunker's forced viewing - she'd felt the tape's demand crawl under her skin. The curse wasn't a sentence that ended when the tape stopped. It kept counting. Seven days - something about watching, something about eyes being held open until the world learned how to blink wrong.

A wet chuckle drifted closer. Not Stabbington's laughter. Something else, playing between the bunker's clicks and the cave's slow drip.

Juniper fought the panic the way she fought swallowing water when it filled her mouth - by forcing her body to do what it could. She slid one hand along the wall, searching for a seam, a crack, anything that might be an exit. Her fingers came away slick with mineral grime and something that might have been mold or old blood. The smell was sharp and metallic, like coins left in rain.

Her other hand clutched her torn gear - thin fabric and plastic pieces that scratched her palm. She'd ripped it off her own clothes when she'd run, because the tape had taught her to distrust anything that looked intact. Now the

scraps warmed against her skin as if they were still trying to keep her body together.

Stabbington's footsteps reached the cave mouth in heavy, impatient beats. "Where'd you go, girl?" His voice dragged the word girl out like it was being pulled across tape.

Juniper's throat tightened so hard she tasted pennies.

She wanted one thing, concrete and immediate: to get out of the cave before the tape-light found her eyes. Before the light pulsed again and the curse made her watch something she couldn't unsee. She wanted the darkness to be enough of a wall that he'd get bored and move on. She wanted - she wanted - she wanted the hunt to forget her name.

The cave didn't care what she wanted.

The floor sloped just enough to trick her into stepping down. She shifted her weight, careful, and the stone beneath her foot gave a soft, wet squeal. The sound carried. It turned Stabbington's attention like a magnet catches a nail.

"Found you," he said, and the way he said it made the word feel like a promise he'd already fulfilled.

Juniper backed into a narrower passage, dragging her body sideways through damp rock. The cave's walls were close enough now that she could feel the temperature differences - cool wet stone on one side, warmer slickness on the other, like the cave had veins. The passage bent sharply, and for a moment she thought she'd made it. Then the tape-light breathed again, and the flicker traveled around the bend before she did.

A slice of light painted Stitch onto the curve of stone.

Not on the far wall - on the wall beside her.

Juniper flinched so hard her shoulder struck rock. Pain sparked bright and immediate, then faded into a dull ache that throbbed in rhythm with the light pulses. The cave seemed to shrink with each breath.

Stitch's silhouette wavered in the wet sheen, all wrong proportions and too many angles. His head tilted as if he was listening, as if he could hear her panic through the stone. His grin stretched again, wider this time, like the tape was learning her face and practicing.

Juniper clamped her eyes shut.

The tape-light still came through her eyelids.

A wet crackle sounded from somewhere behind her. Not a branch snapping - more like VHS static spitting in a corner. The air filled with the sour smell of overheated plastic, and along with it came the faintest giggle, layered like a recording played through a broken speaker.

Stabbington's knife scraped when he entered the cave. Leather against stone, slow and threatening. "You're not gonna make it," he murmured, and the voices in his throat - those excited demands - rose under his words like a choir learning harmony.

Juniper squeezed her eyes harder until they burned. She tried to crawl backward, but the passage narrowed enough to trap her hips. Her breath turned ragged. The damp stone pressed against her ribs with every failed attempt to back away, and the pressure made her feel like her body was being folded into the cave's shape.

The obstacle wasn't just Stabbington anymore.

It was the architecture of the curse. The cave wasn't a place where she could hide. It was a corridor, rearranging itself into a viewing space.

Stabbington rounded the bend and the tape-light hit him too - painted his patchy fur in sickly green. The knife in his paw caught the flicker and glinted like a tooth. His smile looked jagged even in the brief bright pulses, like it had been cut into him by the tape itself.

"Juniper," he said again, softer, like he was savoring the sound. "You're gonna watch."

Juniper's mouth opened on a protest that didn't come out. Her legs couldn't find purchase. Her claws scraped rock, making a thin screech that echoed too far down the passage. The sound made her think of a tape being rewound until it caught, until it tore.

She needed a decision, something that changed what happened next instead of letting the cave and the bear dictate the pace.

When Stabbington stepped closer, she shifted her weight and shoved herself forward into the tightest part of the passage, toward the deeper darkness. It wasn't escape. It was trade. Crawl into a spot where she could lunge and maybe find a crack before he pinned her.

She moved.

Cold stone bit into her palms. Her shoulder screamed as she wedged herself between two walls that felt like they were creeping closer. The tape-light flickered overhead - there was no overhead, just the cave's idea of light - and the pulses strobed across the walls with a rhythm that matched Stabbington's breathing.

He followed fast, confident. "There you are."

The moment he reached for her, she turned, grabbed his wrist, and drove her momentum into his body. The knife dragged, leather handle slipping against her fur. Stabbington grunted, startled - then his grin sharpened. The voices in him surged louder, excited by resistance.

"Stop that," he hissed, and the words came out wrong, too pleased. His free paw slammed into the rock beside Juniper's head, trapping her between stone and bear. Damp air filled her nose - stale sweat, old smoke, something sour beneath it. His breath steamed against her cheek.

Juniper tried to crawl out from under his arm. Her claws scraped his fur and found purchase for half a second. Then the tape-light breathed again, and the wall behind Stabbington flickered with Stitch's silhouette, bigger now, closer.

Stitch's grin appeared between them like a mouth opening in the cave itself.

Juniper's vision tunneled. The flicker dragged her eyes to it even with her mind screaming not to look. The cave felt suddenly too small to hold her and Stitch at once. The air thickened until her lungs struggled for space.

Stabbington leaned in, knife raised, and her body decided for her.

She flinched backward - - and the knife's edge caught her shoulder.

Not a clean slice. A scrape that tore fur and skin in a line that burned and then went numb. Pain flooded hot, then cooled into a trembling ache. She tasted blood. It came up metallic and bitter at the back of her tongue, and it made the giggle sound clearer, like the curse was feeding on the taste.

Stabbington pressed closer. "Look."

Juniper's eyes snapped open before she could stop them, because the cave's light had become a hook. The tape-light pulsed across the damp stone, and with each pulse Stitch's warped silhouette shifted. It didn't stay on the wall. It moved like a figure stepping out through the surface of wet rock.

The glitch wasn't random anymore. It was directed.

Stitch's outline slid along the curve of the passage, as if the cave had become a screen and the light was the cursor. His head turned toward Juniper's face. His

grin widened. His teeth looked like frames extracted from a tape that had been chewed and pasted back together.

For a breath, Juniper saw something else in the flicker - her own shape in the wrong angle of light, eyes held open, mouth stretched too wide. Not a memory. Not a hallucination. A frame.

The curse counted down in frames.

Juniper's mind tried to reject it, tried to close itself, but the cave's pulses made her vision stutter. Sound tore at the edges: Stabbington's growl, the drip-drip of the cave, the static crackle that came in time with the light. Under it all was the voice of the tape - faint, unintelligible, but demanding to be watched, demanding to be obeyed.

Stabbington's hand clamped her shoulder, fingers digging through torn fur. His knife hovered near her throat, not yet striking, as if he was waiting for the moment the tape-light fully locked on.

"Watch," he said, and this time the word sounded less like an order and more like a release. Like he'd been waiting to see her obey.

Juniper tried to turn her head away. The cave resisted. The corridor tightened around her neck like the dark had grown hands. Her shoulder wound screamed whenever she moved, and the pain made the panic sharper, cleaner. She couldn't tell what was her body and what was the curse deciding her limits.

The tape-light surged brighter.

Stitch's silhouette resolved for a single, sick second into something almost real - an image with depth, with wet shine, with a grin that looked wet enough to drip. Then the glitch snapped and the wall became blank again, leaving only the afterimage burned into her eyes.

Juniper's stomach lurched. She couldn't breathe right. The cave smelled like hot plastic and damp stone and the sharp iron tang of her own blood. Every inhale scraped her throat. Every exhale came out in a shaky hiss that sounded like static.

Stabbington leaned in close enough that Juniper could see the patchiness in his fur, the way it looked like it had been scraped off in strips. "You're gonna help it," he whispered, and the voices inside him rose, excited and hungry. "Seven days. Seven days for you."

Juniper's breath hitched at the number. Not comfort - recognition. The curse's clock was no longer an abstract rule. It was a thing in the cave air, counting her down with each pulse.

She tried to force herself to look at the dark instead of the light, but the darkness now carried the same flicker. The cave wasn't offering hiding. It was converting every surface into a screen.

Her vision bounced again. Stitch's grin flashed across the wet stone - this time closer, framed by the narrow passage walls so Juniper couldn't avoid it even if she wanted to. The silhouette shifted into a distorted version of Stabbington's posture, like the tape was teaching the curse how to wear different bodies.

Juniper's eyes watered. Tears mixed with sweat and blood. The wetness made the cave feel even more alive, like it was sweating with her.

Stabbington's knife pressed harder against her skin, enough to make her flinch again. "Look at it," he said, and his voice cracked with joy, with need. "Look."

The cave's pulses sped. The light breathed like an animal. Stitch's silhouette warped across the walls in a loop - grin, tilt, grin - each flicker slightly different, slightly more certain, like the tape was running through variations until it found the version that held Juniper still.

Juniper realized, with sick clarity, that the hunt had already become a viewing. Stabbington wasn't just cornering her.

He was pinning her to the cave's screen.

She jerked against his grip, her shoulder wound flaring with fresh pain. The passage squeezed. The darkness waited. The tape-light demanded. And Stitch - never fully in reach, always just out of frame - kept appearing in the wet stone, close enough that Juniper could feel the cold of his grin without ever seeing his body.

The last thing Juniper managed was a shallow breath that tasted like overheated plastic and blood.

Then the flickering tape-light slammed into place again, and the cave walls warped around Stitch's distorted silhouette until it looked like the dark itself was grinning at her from inches away.

The countdown became unmistakable, not a rule written on paper or a rumor whispered in static - an immediate, rhythmic pressure, as if seven days were being pressed into her eyes one frame at a time.

And Stabbington Bear held her there, knife lifted, while the cave breathed and the light refused to let go.

CHAPTER 9

Marlowe Hears Stitch Laughing Inside

The water kept time in the dark - drip, drip, drip - except it didn't land where it should. Juniper's teeth worried at the inside of her cheek while her body shook with cold that felt too sharp to be real. The cave corridor pinched in at the shoulders, stone sweating slick as old glass, and somewhere behind her the tape's laugh wasn't coming through any speaker at all.

It was in her head.

Marlowe's head.

The thought came like a stutter in a VHS recording: *Marlowe, move. Marlowe, hide. Marlowe, watch.* Words without mouths, syllables that slid under his thoughts and smeared them until they couldn't hold their shape. The countdown pressure - seven days being pressed into eyes one frame at a time - had stopped being a concept. It was a weight behind his eyelids, a bruise that kept blooming as he tried not to stare at the black.

He tried anyway, because the alternative was listening.

He could feel the corridor narrowing around him like a throat. Not metaphor. The air itself got thinner the farther he crawled, damp grit scraping his palms, his breath turning to a wet rasp that sounded borrowed. The cave walls were close enough that when he swallowed he tasted mineral iron and something sweeter underneath it, like burned plastic warmed by a machine that shouldn't have power.

A whisper threaded through the drip rhythm, bright and childish and wrong.

"Mar-lo-we," it sang, stretched across a hiss of static. "Watch. Watch. Watch."

Marlowe's hands tightened on nothing - his fingers flexed as if they still needed to grip the edge of a decision. He didn't know where Garrick was in this moment, only that Garrick had been close enough to smell like sweat and cloth and fear, close enough to be a moving threat. The voices had been worse since the last time the tape had glitched inside the bunker walls; worse since Juniper had been forced to watch. Marlowe clung to that memory like it could anchor him to reality, but the cave kept turning it into a loop. Juniper's forced staring became his own reflection in a dark screen. The same laugh, the same pressure, the same sense that the cave wasn't just containing him - it was playing him.

He needed something concrete, something that didn't dissolve the second he tried to touch it.

Protect the remaining Sprunkies.

The thought rose with a kind of desperate clarity, and for a second Marlowe almost believed it could be a plan. He could feel the way the curse behaved - each time it got a viewing, it got louder, more demanding, more eager. If he could keep eyes away from the tape, keep bodies from being dragged into frames...

The corridor flexed.

Stone bowed inward with a soft crackle, like tape being rewound too hard. His shoulder brushed it and the rock responded with a slick, warm smear, as if the cave had skin. Marlowe yanked his arm back and tasted copper through his nose. The drip rhythm shifted to **tick-tick** - like a metronome trying to become a heartbeat.

His goal split in two: keep the others safe, and keep himself from becoming the next forced witness. Both were impossible. The voices didn't care which

Sprunkie he was trying to protect. They only cared about watching. They only cared about the tape completing its cycle.

A new sound cut through the drip: a scrape of leather on stone, not far. Garrick? No - too slow, too certain. A different animal in the same room. Something heavy shifting its weight in the dark corridor ahead.

Marlowe froze, because moving felt like lighting a match.

The cave answered his hesitation with a glitch - his vision stuttered, edges of the corridor breaking into faint scanlines. For one frame, the narrow passage widened into a bunker hallway with flickering fluorescent seams, and the carpet was replaced by a strip of distorted VHS tracking noise that crawled like mold. Then it snapped back to the cave, close and suffocating, as if it had only shown him a punishment preview.

The whisper returned, closer now.

"Hide," it urged, but it sounded excited, like a child encouraging a game. "Hide... and still watch."

Marlowe's breath trembled. He pressed his back to the stone and tried to become part of it. The wall was wet where he touched it, slick with a cold that seeped into his skin like ink. He could hear his own heartbeat - too loud, too fast - and under it, the drip rhythm kept counting, patient and cruel.

He could feel the tape's laugh crawling up his spine.

Then a faint, distant grunt - Garrick's voice? - muffled by stone, followed by the sharp click of something being dragged across a surface. A scrape that sounded like a hunt continuing outside the cave.

Marlowe's throat tightened. He didn't know where Garrick was, but he knew Garrick wasn't alone anymore. The curse wasn't content with making one

person suffer. It wanted the chase. It wanted the pursuit to stretch and squeeze until there was nowhere left to run.

The corridor ahead shivered. A seam appeared in the rock like a splice in film, and for a blink Marlowe saw a strip of television static where stone should be. His eyes snagged on it involuntarily, and the laugh in his head brightened with relief.

"See," the voices hissed. "See it. See - "

Marlowe snapped his gaze away so hard it burned. Tears sprang anyway, hot and useless, blurring the cave's damp darkness into an oily smear. He wiped at his face and his fingers came away streaked with something that wasn't just water - an oily gray that smelled like old tape cases: plastic warmed by heat, paper dust soaked in smoke.

The obstacle wasn't just Stabbington's reach. It was the curse rewriting what his senses could trust. The corridor could become a bunker hallway for a frame. The darkness could behave like a screen. The voices could speak in the rhythm of the dripping water until his mind couldn't tell whether the sound came from the cave or from inside his skull.

He needed to do something anyway. If he waited for clarity, he'd be waiting until the seven days pressed through his eyes and turned him into a viewing.

A new sound crawled in - faster footsteps in the corridor, not Garrick's heavy shuffle, but something else moving like it knew the space intimately. Something stalking. Something with a knife in its paw. The memory of Stabbington's clumsy brutality flashed in Marlowe's mind, knife-lifted and hungry, and the voices surged like they'd smelled blood.

"Run," Stitch's laughter breathed through static, a giggle that didn't belong to any throat. "Run... and bring them with you."

Marlowe's body moved before his mind could argue. He shoved off the wall, scraping his shoulder hard enough to sting, and sprinted down the narrowing corridor. The cave answered immediately, squeezing tighter. Stone brushed his sides with every step, close enough to steal warmth from his skin. His sneakers - mud-caked, torn at the edges - slacked on wet rock, then skated, then caught, and the momentum turned into a brutal stutter.

The drip became a drumbeat. He could feel it under his feet through the damp ground, a metronome counting down his breath.

Behind him, the footsteps grew louder.

Not just footsteps. The sound of a presence adjusting itself to his movement, syncing like a recording matching a playback speed. Marlowe ran until his lungs felt like they were lined with sand. Every inhale tasted stale, chemical, and the air felt too thick, as if the cave had decided breathing was optional.

He tried to keep his eyes forward, but the walls kept glitching at the edges of his sight. For one sickening moment the corridor split into overlapping frames - two versions of the passage, one slightly out of sync, like a double exposure that couldn't decide where he was. He saw himself running twice, his own body flickering between positions, and the laughter in his head matched it, delighted by the confusion.

"Don't stop," the voices demanded, and he didn't know whether they were telling him to run or to watch. Their words didn't have consistent shape anymore. Sometimes they sounded like Stitch. Sometimes they sounded like Garrick. Sometimes they sounded like Juniper screaming as she was forced to stare.

Marlowe's legs buckled. He stumbled, caught himself on the stone with a hand that came away numb, then kept going anyway because stopping felt like stepping into a trap that would close around his eyes.

The corridor opened into a wider pocket - just enough space to breathe - then immediately narrowed again, like a throat clenching. At the new bend, Marlowe saw a glint of something wet on the rock: a strip of torn Sprunki gear, half stuck to the wall, the fabric fluttering though there was no wind. He recognized it - someone's attempt to leave a trail, someone's desperate scrap of identity ripped away by the chase.

The curse used it like bait.

The laugh spiked. The air cooled sharply, then warmed too fast, and his vision blurred with a sudden wash of static. He could almost hear a TV screen powering on. He almost saw the tape's label - **Stitch: Forbidden Episode** - burning into the wet stone like a brand.

He didn't dare look long enough to confirm it.

Ahead, the cave corridor twisted into a half-light shaft where water ran down the walls in threads so thin they looked like wires. Marlowe could smell damp metal and old smoke. Somewhere in the dark, a voice - Garrick's, strained and furious - called out, and the sound bounced wrong, like the cave was repeating it from a different angle.

"Mar - !" Garrick tried again, the rest lost under a growl that wasn't Garrick.

Stabbington.

The knife-scrape sound returned. It was closer now, so close Marlowe could feel the heat of its presence even through the damp cold. The voices in his head screamed with pleasure at the nearness, and for a nauseating second he thought he could satisfy them - just once, just to get them quiet, just to stop feeling like his skull was being used as a television.

The thought came with a hook of relief.

Then Marlowe pictured the Sprunkies being forced to watch. He pictured the way the tape degraded, how it didn't just show terror - it **created** it, frame by frame, until the curse had nowhere else to go but deeper into the viewer.

He didn't want relief. He wanted control.

The decision split him again: hide and hope the others stayed out of range, or act while the corridor still offered him distance. The voices tried to steer him either way. They pushed him toward freezing, toward swallowing the panic, toward becoming still enough to be dragged into a viewing.

They also pushed him toward a different kind of sacrifice - the kind that didn't involve his eyes meeting a screen.

He ran toward the bend where the light shaft swallowed sound. He aimed for the place where Garrick's voice had echoed. If he could draw Stabbington's attention away from the others - if he could pull the hunt like a leash - maybe the remaining Sprunkies could slip into hiding without being cornered into watching.

The cost was obvious. The voices made sure he understood it with brutal clarity: luring Stabbington meant becoming the target. Becoming the target meant the tape's curse would try to track him, try to force him into the same fate.

Marlowe didn't have another lever to pull.

He rounded the bend and the cave floor dropped into a shallow channel of water. His foot hit it hard and he nearly fell. Cold slapped his ankle and climbed fast, numbing his skin. The drip rhythm became louder here, and he realized - too late - that the water wasn't just dripping. It was running along channels cut into the rock, forming a pattern like tracking lines on a video display.

His stomach rolled. The cave was playing the same game as the tape.

Garrick's silhouette appeared ahead - dark against darker stone - moving as if his body remembered how to fight even while his mind screamed. He was turned slightly, as if he'd heard Marlowe and expected him to be somewhere else. His face was tense, eyes wide in the low light.

"Marlowe!" Garrick called, and the word sounded like a lifeline until the voices inside Marlowe's skull twisted it into something else. Stitch laughed, and the laugh rode the sound of Garrick's name until Marlowe couldn't tell which one was real.

Stabbington's presence surged into the opening behind Garrick. The footsteps came like a stomp, heavy and hungry. The air thickened. Marlowe could smell wet fur and blood in his imagination before there was any blood on the stone.

He made the choice anyway.

He shouted - loud, sharp, forcing his raw throat to do it - then ran sideways into the water channel, splashing hard enough to spray his face with cold. The sound of splatter echoed like a distorted laugh. He kicked off the slippery rock and moved toward the brighter shaft, keeping his body between Stabbington and Garrick as best he could, like a living barrier.

"Over here!" Marlowe yelled, and his voice cracked on the last word.

Garrick's head snapped toward him. For a breath, he looked relieved - then confused. Stabbington's footsteps redirected. The knife-scrape sound shifted. The voices inside Marlowe cheered as if his shout had fed them.

He could feel it: the curse tracking movement. Not just hearing him. Not just guiding him. Adjusting the cave itself to follow his decisions, bending corridors and light shafts like a camera searching for focus.

The rock seam appeared ahead, a glitch in the stone, and the darkness inside it flickered with a brief smear of television static. Marlowe glimpsed the tape's

distorted imagery - Stitch's grin, too wide, too close - before his panic slammed his eyes shut.

When he opened them, the corridor was still there, still narrow, but now the air smelled stronger: hot plastic, wet mold, and something like burnt sugar.

The voices erupted, demanding payment.

"Watch," they shrieked, synchronized with the drip. "Watch him. Watch - "

Marlowe staggered, ankle numb, lungs burning. He tried to run faster, but the corridor squeezed tighter around his ribs with each step, as if the cave were compressing him into a smaller and smaller version of himself. His muscles screamed; his breath turned into a wet, ragged wheeze. The cold water kept climbing his leg as the channel sloped.

Still, he pushed forward, because if he stopped, the curse would catch the pause and use it.

Behind him, Garrick's voice rose, sharp with anger and fear. "Marlowe - don't - !"

But Stabbington's presence surged again, cutting Garrick's words off as if the cave swallowed sound. The knife-scrape moved closer to Marlowe's blind side, and he felt the pressure of being hunted like a hand on the back of his neck.

Marlowe's mind fractured into three competing images: Garrick lunging to help, Juniper being forced to stare, and Stitch's laugh playing in frames that never ended. The corridor blurred until he couldn't tell whether the walls were moving toward him or his eyes were.

He forced himself to look once - only once - toward the seam in the rock.

The seam widened like a mouth. Static poured out. Within it, Stitch's grin appeared as a glitch-frame, flickering so fast it felt like a warning strobe. The

laugh in Marlowe's skull matched the flicker perfectly, brightening and dimming as if the curse was syncing to his attention.

He understood then: hiding wouldn't save anyone. Even sacrifice wouldn't break the tracking. The curse could follow through distortion, through movement, through whatever he did to avoid becoming a viewer.

But he could still choose what he gave it.

Not his eyes. Not the others' eyes.

Marlowe threw himself forward into the tunnel of water, letting the current drag at his boots. He slipped, caught himself on the stone, and kept going with raw, bleeding determination. His shoulder hit rock and pain flared bright enough to make him see scanlines. His fingers scraped until they stung with every friction. He tasted blood where his lip split, metallic and hot, mixing with the damp chemical smell.

Behind him, Stabbington's footsteps hit the water channel and splashed. The sound was too close now, immediate, no distance left to negotiate.

Garrick's voice broke through again, closer than it should've been, and Marlowe realized with a sick lurch that the chase had tightened around the space between them. The cave didn't just track Marlowe. It tracked the whole act of pursuit.

The curse didn't want one victim. It wanted a sequence.

Marlowe reached the next bend and felt the air change - thinner, warmer, like a room where a TV had been left on too long. In that warmth, the voices softened into something almost intimate. Stitch's laughter curled around his thoughts like smoke.

"Good," the voices purred. "Now run... and keep running."

Marlowe staggered, listening for Garrick, for Stabbington, for any sign of a gap in the corridor. The cave walls rippled once, a subtle glitch that made the drip rhythm stutter and then resume in a new pattern.

The curse had adjusted again.

And somewhere behind him, the knife-scrape stopped - only for a heartbeat - like the hunter had paused to watch him decide whether he was going to keep being prey or turn into a viewing.

Marlowe didn't wait for the next breath. He ducked into the narrowing passage anyway, forcing his exhausted body forward as if pushing could rewrite what the curse had already chosen.

The last thing he heard before the tunnel swallowed sound was Garrick's shout turning into a choke of static, and in Marlowe's head Stitch laughed - closer than ever - while the cave pressed tighter around him, as if the world had finally found the exact frame where he belonged.



The Bridge That Turns Into Teeth

Marlowe's last breath still tasted like static in the air when Garrick hit the mouth of the ravine and found daylight where it shouldn't be. The world snapped - one frame wide, then another - and the narrow passage he'd been stalking along for too long opened onto black water and rotting timber.

A bridge sat over it like a bad repair: planks swollen and split, nails half-rusted into toothy hooks, rope railings sagging under their own weight. Garrick's throat burned with the effort of running after Marlowe, but the air on the bridge was colder than the forest behind him, slick with damp algae and something else - sweet in the way old tape smells when it's been warmed too many times.

The laughter came again, faint and delighted, threaded through the rushing water sound. Not from the ravine. From under the boards.

Garrick's paw tightened around the leather-handled knife until the handle squeaked against fur. His ears flicked at the static-choke of the tunnel that had swallowed Marlowe, and his own voice came out raw. "Marlowe!"

He didn't wait for an answer. He wanted the tape. He wanted Marlowe's eyes on it again - wanted the curse to do what it had been doing in the bunker corridors, what it had been doing to Juniper in that cave, what it had been doing every time someone tried to look away. The voices in his head weren't asking anymore. They were leaning in, hungry and excited, demanding he bring the hunt back into the frame where it belonged.

Marlowe's footsteps had been quick, but there was always a stumble when the ground started lying. Garrick had started to recognize it, the way the world would distort a fraction too late for Marlowe's body to catch up - like the tape was trying to edit out the moment before it happened.

If Garrick could catch him on the bridge, if he could wrench him down before the environment decided the bridge was done being a bridge - He ran.

The first plank under his foot flexed like wet muscle. The second slid sideways with a soft, wet scrape, as if the boards were tired of pretending they were aligned. Garrick's balance went hard and wrong. He threw his weight forward anyway, the knife clawing his fur through the grip, and his momentum carried him onto the next section - only to find that the bridge had shifted again.

Not collapsed. Repositioned.

Straight ahead, the planks were level and wide, but to his left the railing dropped into a gap that hadn't been there. The black water below seemed closer, the surface thick and glossy, reflecting nothing but a warped smear of light that didn't match the sky.

Garrick heard a giggle - thin, pleased - follow his footfalls, and the sound made him angry enough to ignore the way his calves tightened in protest. "Stop. Stop running."

A shape flashed at the far end of the bridge: Marlowe, small and frantic, sprinting with his head turned back as if he could see Garrick through layers of glitch. For a second Marlowe's face looked too sharp, eyes too wide, like a frame held too long. Then the image stuttered, and Marlowe was a smear of color again - Sprunki paint and panic - fighting the delay.

Garrick lunged.

The bridge answered like it had teeth.

A plank rose under his stride, a sudden pivot that snapped his foot upward. For half a heartbeat Garrick was airborne over black water, the knife hand flailing to regain grip. His stomach dropped so hard he tasted bile, and his breath came out in a harsh, broken sound.

Then the board settled, but it didn't settle flat. It angled, forcing his weight onto the outer edge of his foot. Pain flared through the joint like a hot wire. Garrick kept running because stopping meant the laughter would get closer, meant the curse would find a new way to make him watch.

"Marlowe!" he shouted again, and this time the name came back wrong - echoed with a stretched, tape-warped version of itself, the syllables dragged as if someone had rewound his voice and played it through something that chewed sound.

Mar-low - low - low.

Mar-low - low.

Mar-low - low.

The bridge grew narrower. Garrick's stride didn't change, but the world did. The planks didn't just shift; they squeezed. The space between railings tightened until rope pressed into his shoulders, until his arms brushed wet wood that felt too close to skin. The air smelled more metallic, less like damp and more like blood left too long in a pocket.

He saw movement in the gaps between boards - dark shapes that weren't water, weren't shadow. They shifted with each step, as if the underside of the bridge was alive and testing the distance between him and falling.

A thought flashed - not a careful one, but a command from somewhere inside his skull: seize him. Make him look. Make him watch.

Garrick barreled forward anyway, limping now, the injured foot catching awkwardly on misaligned edges. His fur stuck to sweat. His lungs rasped, each breath scraping his throat raw as if the bridge was sanding him down.

Marlowe reached the midpoint. Garrick could see the torn gear now - caught on a nail like a hook trying to keep a body in place. Marlowe kicked at it, swore something that sounded like a high squeak, and kept moving.

Garrick's heart hammered against his ribs.

The voices rose with it, excited and demanding, a chorus of whispers that didn't quite form words but carried intent like a shove. They were louder than the water. Louder than the rope creaking. Louder than the pain.

"Here," the voices seemed to say, and the bridge seemed to understand.

The next plank in front of Garrick split down the center, then split again - two seams becoming five, five becoming a grin of narrow openings. The edges of the wood curled upward, not like splinters but like teeth, each one too clean and too evenly spaced to be an accident. The gaps yawned just enough to catch his foot if he misstepped.

He tried to jump.

The world glitched.

For a fraction of a second, Garrick's body froze mid-stride, his fur and breath locked in place as if the tape had been paused. The water beneath him stopped moving. The laughter cut off like someone yanked a plug. Even his knife hand held still, clawed fingers spread, the leather handle pressed into the same spot on his paw.

Then the video resumed at the wrong speed.

The plank snapped down. The teeth rose higher. Garrick landed hard on the angled wood and his injured foot buckled with a sick crack of joint. Pain shot up

his leg so fast his vision went white at the edges.

He stumbled forward, grabbed at the railing - rope slick and damp, rope that vibrated under his grip like a snare drum skin - and kept his momentum from turning into a fall.

"Marlowe!" he gasped, voice thick.

Marlowe was still ahead, but the distance wasn't shrinking anymore. It was slicing open and widening, the bridge curving in a way that made no sense. The far end looked closer than it was, then farther. Garrick's sense of direction kept getting edited.

The bridge wasn't a straight line anymore. It was a path drawn by a failing signal.

Black water churned below. The surface reflected something that wasn't the sky - faint frames of a cartoon face, too wide-mouthed, too wrong, flashing in and out like corrupted VHS tracking. Stitch's grin flickered there, not in the air, not in the darkness above, but on the water itself like the world had decided to show him what it wanted him to look at.

Garrick's stomach turned. He didn't want to look. He couldn't stop himself anyway.

He ran with his gaze forward, but his eyes kept catching the grin in the reflection. The laughter under the boards became louder, the giggle now layered with a whisper that sounded like Marlowe's voice being played back through a broken speaker.

"Marlowe," it said, and the word wasn't a call. It was a cue.

Marlowe spun around at the end of the bridge and - just for one glitching instant - his face wasn't Marlowe's anymore. It was a warped, cartoonish version, eyes too glossy and mouth too stretched. Then the frame corrected and Marlowe

was himself again, panting, clutching something in his hands that might've been the torn gear or might've been nothing at all.

He lifted his arm as if he could throw it back toward Garrick.

A second later, the bridge buckled under Garrick's weight again. The teeth-planks flexed, and one section dropped just enough to send a wave of cold through the air. Garrick's foot slid, and his body pitched sideways.

The knife hand jerked out too far.

Marlowe's eyes widened. "Garrick - "

The name hit the air like a plea and a curse at once. Garrick surged anyway, throwing his shoulder into the momentum, trying to grab Marlowe by the back of his vest before the bridge could shove him into water.

He got close enough to smell Marlowe's sweat - sharp and tangy like fruit gone sour - and then the bridge decided to change the angle of reality entirely.

The planks ahead warped upward, as if the bridge were trying to become a wall. The railing on one side rose, pressing rope into his ribs. The other side sank, making the gap below look impossibly deep. Garrick's body tried to follow the old path; his feet landed on new geometry.

His injured leg betrayed him.

He slipped, full weight tipping off-center, and his hands scrabbled for purchase. His fingers found wood - rotted, splintered - then found nothing. The plank edge tore away under his grip like it had been cut with a knife.

Garrick fell forward instead of down, landing on one knee and one palm on the tooth-grin boards. The nails scraped his fur. Heat and cold surged together. His lungs emptied in a wet cough.

Marlowe was almost there - almost within reach.

Garrick pushed up with the knife still clutched in his paw, teeth clenched against the pain. "Come here," he growled, hoarse, and his voice broke again on the last word.

Marlowe stumbled back, eyes darting to the water, to the teeth, to the glitched reflections. He clutched at the air like he could grab the right frame and pull it into place. "No - "

The bridge shuddered.

A sound like tape being dragged across a dirty head filled the space, harsh and metallic. The planks under Garrick's hands vibrated, and the tooth edges sharpened further, turning from jagged wood into something that looked almost like bone, pale and slick, too smooth for rot.

Garrick's vision tunneled. The voices surged - closer, louder, excited to the point of nausea. They didn't just demand. They promised.

The promise was always the same: make him watch.

Garrick lunged one more time, too desperate to be careful.

Marlowe jerked sideways, and the space between them collapsed for a heartbeat - then the bridge glitched again, snapping the distance into a mismatch. Garrick's outstretched paw caught only air and damp rope, his knife hand scraping across a tooth-plank that bit into his forearm.

Pain flared white-hot. The knife stayed in his grip, but his arm went numb at the wrist, fingers spasming around the leather handle. The world stuttered, his balance failing from the shock.

Marlowe stumbled toward the far end - toward wherever the bridge led when it wasn't a bridge anymore - and Garrick heard the faintest sound of something clicking and whirring, like a VHS player being turned on.

Not in his own head.

In the air.

A cold draft rolled across the bridge, smelling of old plastic and warm electronics. The planks beneath Garrick's knee softened, then tightened, as if the bridge were breathing around him. The tooth shapes sharpened until they crowded his peripheral vision, each one casting a shadow that looked like a row of teeth inside his eyes.

"Marlowe!" Garrick screamed, and the scream came out warped, stretched by static.

Marlowe looked over his shoulder. His mouth moved, but the words got caught in the tape-scratch sound. His eyes were fixed on something beyond Garrick - something behind him, something that made his expression twist into fear.

Garrick turned his head.

The water reflection showed Stitch's grin again, larger now, filling the black surface like the world had become a screen. In that reflection, Stitch's hand reached up out of the water and dragged a shape across the "frame" - a quick, distorted glimpse of a tape label, the letters smeared and wrong, then corrected into something Garrick recognized too well:

Stitch: Forbidden Episode.

The image held for a fraction too long, like a warning frozen in place.

Garrick whipped back toward Marlowe.

Marlowe was already moving, already slipping past the last stretch of bridge that looked solid. The environment tried to help him - planks sliding under his feet like a runway, railings lowering just enough to let him pass. Garrick's body responded too late, hampered by the injured leg and the bite of teeth into his arm.

He reached.

His fingers closed on Marlowe's sleeve - cloth damp and thin - and for a breath Garrick felt the fabric resist him, felt Marlowe's body jerk against his grip.

Then the bridge shifted like a knife turning in a wound.

The plank beneath Garrick dropped a half-step. The tooth edges rose. Marlowe's sleeve tore free with a wet rip, and Garrick's grip yanked nothing but air.

Marlowe staggered forward, out of reach, and the cold draft intensified as if a door had opened somewhere nearby. The bridge's end - boards that should have continued - seamed into something else: a doorway made of rotted wood and static, edges flickering between solid and transparent.

Garrick's vision swam. His arm throbbed where the knife had bitten into the tooth-plank. His knee burned against the rough board. The laughter rose into a delighted chorus, and the whispers became clearer, almost sing-song.

Not words. Commands shaped like music.

Garrick pushed himself up anyway, teeth grinding, breath ragged. He could still chase. He could still force a viewing. He could still - Marlowe vanished past the shimmering doorway, swallowed by the glitching end of the bridge. The portal snapped back into plain wood so abruptly it made Garrick flinch, as if the world had slapped him.

Black water slapped the underside. The tooth-planks around him clicked and shifted, rearranging themselves like a trap resetting its jaws.

Garrick stood half-bent, arm hanging wrong, knife paw trembling with shock. The voices in his head were no longer excited like before. They were angry - impatient with the delay, furious that the tape hadn't been delivered when it was supposed to be.

Somewhere close, beneath the boards, the VHS tape smell thickened. A faint electronic whir threaded through the water sound, and Garrick realized the bridge hadn't just sabotaged him.

It had moved the curse forward without his permission.

He took one step, then another, and the tooth-planks shifted immediately, tightening the corridor of wood between him and where Marlowe had gone. The bridge narrowed until his shoulders brushed both sides, rope scraping fur raw, and the black water below seemed to rise.

Garrick's mouth tasted copper. His lungs burned. His leg shook with exhaustion that felt like it had been stored up and released all at once.

He reached for the air where Marlowe had been.

His fingers closed on nothing.

The laughter under the boards turned into a wet, delighted chuckle, and the last reflection on the water - Stitch's grin, too close, too bright - flickered once more before the surface went blank, swallowing the image like it had never been there.

Garrick stood on a bridge that had already decided to bite back, and the chase kept moving without him - toward the place the tape wanted him to fail.

Tape Scratches Reveal Stitch's Method

The bridge's boards were still talking to Marlowe in his bones.

He staggered off the last warped plank and into the bunker's archive room with his ears ringing and his throat full of salt-dry panic. The air back here was cooler, stale with paper rot and old plastic, but it didn't feel like relief - more like stepping into the shadow of a soundproof door while something on the other side kept laughing. His hands shook as he pressed them against the wall to steady himself. The concrete was damp, and when he pulled his fingers away, the skin came off in a thin film of dust like the bunker had been sweating for years.

Behind him, the last echo of Garrick's voice had been chewed into static by the bridge's distortion. The silence that followed wasn't empty. It was crowded with the shape of a question: why the curse wanted Garrick on that water, why the tape's logic kept slipping through reality like a wet hand through cloth.

Marlowe shoved himself upright anyway. Every step made his legs protest in sharp, hot bursts, and his vision kept strobing at the edges - like VHS tracking was trying to catch up to him. He could feel the tape in the back of his mind even without seeing it, the way a song sticks after the speakers die. Stitch's grin had flashed in glitch frames during the bridge chase, bright and wrong, and it had felt less like an image and more like a verdict.

He found the archive room by the mess: shelves sagging under binders, drawers yawning open, loose index cards scattered like teeth across the floor. A

pale light buzzed overhead with a fluorescent sickness. Marlowe dropped to his knees, grabbing at the nearest stack of notes with trembling fingers.

He wanted the rules. Not rumors. Not warnings. The actual pattern behind the curse - how it spread, how it tracked, how it forced viewings. If Stitch's logic could be read, maybe Garrick's forced watchings could be stopped before they turned into something irreversible. Maybe the tape could be beaten by understanding what it was doing.

The bunker gave him pages, but the pages didn't behave.

The first note he yanked free was titled in thick marker - faded, then suddenly too dark, like the ink had decided to remember its original color. Letters swam as he tried to read them. One line looked like it said, *Exposure worsens after each viewing.* Another line, written in a different hand, contradicted it immediately: *Repetition stabilizes the signal.* The paper edges rippled under the fluorescent light, not bending like paper should, but flexing like skin under a scalpel.

Marlowe leaned closer, breath scraping dry in his throat. Sound came from nowhere: a faint, cheerful giggle threaded through the buzzing lights. It wasn't loud enough to be certain, but it was close enough to make him flinch like it had been spoken inches from his ear.

"Garrick..." he rasped, forcing the name through his teeth. "Where are you?"

No answer. Only the building's hush and the soft, irritating hiss of static that seemed to rise from the floorboards.

He shoved the contradictory notes aside and grabbed another folder. Inside were VHS-era clippings - tape labels, diagrams of a player's insides, and handwritten margins full of frantic corrections. The name *Stitch: Forbidden Episode* appeared more than once, each time in the same blunt, panicked script. But the surrounding text changed when he blinked. A sentence would

settle into something readable, then snap into nonsense as if his eyes were the only thing being recorded.

Marlowe's pulse thumped in his wrists. He could barely stand the pressure of it. The bunker wanted him to stay kneeling, wanted him to keep looking, because looking was the same motion as feeding the thing behind the tape.

He heard a scrape down the corridor beyond the archive room. Not the groan of settling walls - something heavier shifting its weight. Metal-on-concrete. Patient. Like Garrick had finally found his footing after the bridge tried to spit him out.

Marlowe's relief curdled instantly into dread. If Garrick was coming in, then the forced viewings couldn't be far behind. He grabbed for the archive's VHS equipment - old players bolted into a cabinet, cords tangled like restraints. His hands found a tape case with a familiar label. **Stitch: Forbidden Episode.** The plastic felt gritty under his fingertips, tacky in a way that made his skin crawl.

He didn't know if the tape was already in the player - he couldn't remember the last time he'd been sure of anything that had happened inside this bunker. But he recognized the smell of it anyway: warm dust and old electronics, overlaid with something sour and wet that shouldn't exist in a storage room.

Marlowe yanked the case open. The tape inside wasn't fully still. The spool turned in tiny, jerky movements that looked like the mechanism was rehearsing without being powered. The label on the cassette face was clean for half a second, then the ink bled outward like it was being pulled by gravity toward the center.

A new note slid from a gap between pages and hit the floor with a soft slap. Marlowe stared at it, trying to decide if the movement was real. His eyes snagged on a line written in thick, angry black:

The curse learns your pace.

He swallowed hard. His body remembered the chase - how he'd run until his lungs screamed; how the bridge had twisted underfoot; how the static had tried to crawl into his mouth. The curse had been matching him. Tracking him. Turning his motion into data.

Another sound came from the corridor. Closer now. A thud like a shoulder against a door. Then Garrick's voice, strained and broken at the edges, as if it had already been run through a bad tape.

"Marlowe - "

He tried to answer, but his tongue stuck. The bunker's fluorescent light flickered, and in that stutter of darkness, the archive room felt smaller. Not metaphorically - physically. Shelves leaned in by a fraction, the air tightened, and the corners sharpened like the room was being redrawn by an unstable signal. Marlowe backed away and hit a table, knocking over a stack of index cards. They scattered again, and this time the writing on them was clearer, like the bunker wanted him to read:

Seven days begins at viewing.

Each additional exposure accelerates.

Stops only when the tape is unspooled completely.

The last line made something cold bloom in Marlowe's stomach. Unspooled completely. Like the curse needed the tape emptied out, like it would keep spreading until there was nothing left on the spool to record. But the contradictory note - repetition stabilizes - flared in his mind like a warning flare.

He needed to know which part was real.

The corridor scraping became a forceful, impatient pounding. Something - someone - was coming in, and the bunker was already reacting. The cabinet doors in the archive room rattled as if a draft had hit them. Paper trembled in

midair where it shouldn't have been. The fluorescent buzz rose in pitch until it felt like it was vibrating through Marlowe's teeth.

He grabbed the tape case again, thumb hooking under the plastic latch. His fingers were slick with sweat. The moment he touched the cassette face, the room's temperature dropped hard, and a thin layer of ice formed along his knuckles - painful, immediate, as if his skin had been dipped in freezer burn.

Marlowe jerked his hand back, breath hissing. "No," he whispered, not sure if he was saying it to Stitch or to the bunker or to whatever logic lived behind the notes. "Not yet."

He didn't have time to decide. The bunker had already made the decision for him.

The archive room's doorway shuddered. A figure filled the frame - Garrick, half-caught in the flicker of light, face smeared with grime and water-dark streaks from the bridge. His clothes looked torn at the shoulder, and his eyes were too wide, as if he'd been running for a long time even after the chase ended. He leaned in like he was bracing against invisible weight.

"Marlowe," he said again, louder this time. Then his gaze snapped past Marlowe to the tape case. His expression changed - hunting focus bleeding into fear. "Don't - "

Marlowe turned, and the room's air tightened again. The fluorescent light flickered so violently the world stuttered. In the black gaps between frames, Marlowe saw Stitch's grin in the glass cabinet door - only for an instant, only long enough to make his stomach lurch.

Garrick didn't just look at the tape. He flinched like it looked back.

"Why is it out?" Garrick demanded, voice shaking with exhaustion and anger. "I thought - I thought we were past this."

Marlowe's hands tightened around the cassette case until the plastic creaked. "The notes are wrong," he said. "Or they're - they're changing. Stitch's logic. It's - it's tracking exposure. Repetition - it says it accelerates, then says it stabilizes. Like it's lying to keep us - "

Garrick cut him off with a sharp breath. "It isn't lying." He stepped closer, and the fluorescent light caught something on his neck - thin red marks, like a strap had been pulled too tight. His throat bobbed. "It's bait."

The bunker answered with a sudden, wet click from somewhere inside the archive cabinet. A tape player, locked and unused, clicked like it had been fed a command. A drawer slid open on its own, revealing a VHS unit with a slot that looked dark and hungry.

Marlowe stared at it. He hadn't touched it. He hadn't even moved close enough.

The static hiss deepened, turning into a soft chorus, like a roomful of tiny speakers all trying to tune to the same frequency. Then came laughter - cheerful, wrong. Stitch's laughter, but warped through the bunker's old wiring until it sounded like teeth chattering.

Garrick's face went pale. "It wants him to watch," he said, eyes darting around the archive room as if he could locate the source of the sound. "It wants forced viewings. It - " He swallowed. "It started with the bridge. It started with me losing control."

Marlowe's mind raced. Stitch's curse followed motion. It learned your pace. If Garrick had been chasing him, if Garrick had been pulled toward the bridge, then the bunker was using Garrick's pursuit as a delivery system. The tape didn't just curse the person who watched. It hunted by creating conditions that forced watching.

Marlowe lifted the cassette case. "Then we stop it," he said, even though the words felt brittle. "We don't let it get a viewing cycle. We - "

The fluorescent light cut out.

For a heartbeat, the archive room went dark, and in that darkness Marlowe heard the tape's mechanism inside the cabinet revving like an engine spooling up. When the light snapped back, the tape player's slot was open, and a strip of VHS tape had already slid out a few inches - slick black ribbon with faint, oily sheen. The label on the cassette case in Marlowe's hands was no longer the same. The ink had shifted, letters smearing into a different arrangement, as if the tape had updated its own name to match whatever version of Stitch's logic was in control at that exact second.

Garrick lunged toward the player, grabbed at the tape ribbon with bare hands, and hissed when it bit into his skin. The strip jerked as if it had teeth. Garrick yanked back, shaking his fingers, blood beading quickly and then vanishing under a smear of gray static.

"No," he choked, eyes watering. "No, no - "

Marlowe's body surged forward before he could think. He shoved Garrick aside and grabbed the tape ribbon with both hands. It felt wrong - too cold, too slick, like pulling a wet tongue from a throat. The ribbon trembled in his grip. The bunker hummed with anticipation.

The notes on the floor around them began to crawl.

Index cards lifted at the corners as if dragged by invisible fingers. Handwriting blurred, then re-stamped itself into new lines. Marlowe caught words like punches: *CORRUPTION - * and then *EACH PLAY - * and then *ACCELERATES - * until the message became a smear of black ink that looked like it was trying to become a picture.

He yanked the ribbon free from the player's slot. The mechanism whined, angry. The cabinet door slammed shut hard enough to rattle bones. Static roared louder, and the archive room shrank again, walls inching inward with each

flicker of light. Marlowe's shoulders scraped against a shelf. He felt splinters bite skin through fabric.

Garrick stood there panting, blood shining on his fingertips. His eyes were fixed on the tape ribbon in Marlowe's hands like a man watching a fuse burn down. "It's still counting," he said. "Even if we pull it out, it - it's still learning exposure."

Marlowe stared at the ribbon. The surface was no longer just tape. It had faint, translucent images flickering across it - frames of a children's show gone wrong, bright colors bleeding into jagged shapes. Stitch's silhouette flashed between frames, grin too wide, eyes like glossy marbles. For a split second, Marlowe saw his own face inside the glare - mouth open, not screaming, just watching.

He ripped the ribbon away from the player and shoved it back toward the cassette case. His hands were shaking too hard to be steady. The ribbon didn't want to go. It wriggled like something alive, and when he tried to force it, it left a thin line of raw, pale burn across his palm.

Garrick grabbed Marlowe's wrist, pulling him back. "Stop fighting it," he snapped, but the words sounded more like fear than instruction. "If it's counting exposure - if it's learning - then every second you handle it is another - another - "

"Another viewing," Marlowe finished, breath ragged. The realization landed like a weight. The bunker wasn't just cursing people who watched the tape. It was corrupting the tape's logic into the environment, into objects, into contact. Every interaction with the artifact was a kind of exposure. Every attempt to stop it could be feeding it.

The archive room's lights flickered again. In the strobing glare, Marlowe saw the torn edge of a note curl into a shape that looked like a film perforation. The paper was trying to become part of the tape. The bunker was trying to turn itself into a player.

He forced himself to move anyway, dragging the cassette case toward the back wall where the notes were thickest. There had to be a line about countermeasures. A rule that could be trusted. Something that would break the cycle without giving Stitch more chances to record.

He shoved aside a pile of binders and found a stack of bunker logs bound with twine. The first page was legible - until the ink crawled. Then the words rearranged into a contradiction that made his eyes ache.

Corruption worsens with repeated exposure.

Underneath it, in smaller handwriting, a second line appeared like a bruise forming:

Unspooled tape resets the count. Only if no one sees the frame that follows the unspooling.

Marlowe's chest tightened. The "frame that follows" sounded like the part Stitch laughed through - the moment the tape's innocent story breaks and the real horror shows up. If unspooling required reaching that frame, then stopping it meant risking the exact thing they were trying to prevent.

Garrick leaned over the logs, face lit by the flicker, and his expression twisted with a grim understanding that looked too familiar. "So it doesn't just spread," he whispered. "It escalates. Every time we try to interrupt it, it gets worse."

Static laughter bubbled from the corridor again, closer now, as if someone was walking right outside the bunker's sealed door. The air smelled faintly of warm plastic and wet copper. Marlowe's skin prickled, every hair on his arms lifting.

He turned toward the doorway. The archive room's walls gave a slow, nauseating lurch, like the bunker had shifted its weight to keep them trapped inside. The doorway narrowed by a fraction, and the buzzing fluorescent light dimmed, then flared, as if the room was buffering.

Garrick's hand clenched around Marlowe's shoulder. "It's not done with you," he said. "It's not done with either of us."

Marlowe opened his mouth to argue, to demand answers from the bunker's corrupted records, to force the logic into something he could use. But the corridor behind the doorway answered first.

A deep scrape, then the unmistakable click of a tape player mechanism - somewhere beyond the room, somewhere that meant a forced viewing was already starting. A muffled voice - someone's voice - warped through static, then broke into laughter that sounded like Stitch had learned a new way to imitate comfort.

Marlowe's gaze snapped back to the logs. The handwriting on the page was changing again, ink bleeding into fresh lines as if the bunker couldn't stand being read.

He managed one thought before the room truly tightened: the corruption worsens with repeated exposure.

And Garrick arrived just in time to make sure Marlowe couldn't do anything about it.



Marlowe Breaks, Then Runs Anyway

The bunker exit chamber shuddered like something breathing from the other side of the wall. Marlowe had his shoulder against the jammed door, palms slick on cold metal, and the whole frame vibrated in a frantic, tooth-rattling rhythm that made his teeth ache. Somewhere deeper in the bunker, tapes clicked and rewound themselves with wet little sounds, and the air smelled like burnt plastic and damp earth pressed together until it turned sour. When Marlowe pressed his weight harder, the door didn't open - it only buzzed back at him, vibrating through his bones, through the tendon in his wrist, as if the metal wanted to crawl into him.

"Stop," Garrick's voice barked from behind, rough with effort and something that sounded too close to delight. Static crackled between his words, and for a heartbeat Marlowe couldn't tell if it was the radio in the wall or laughter inside his own skull. Marlowe's head snapped toward him. Garrick was there, close enough that Marlowe could see the grime in the creases of his face and the way his eyes kept sliding off Marlowe like they didn't want to focus on him for long. He held himself upright with the stubbornness of a man who'd already fallen once and decided gravity was negotiable. In Garrick's paw, his leather-handled knife glinted - small, patient, waiting.

Marlowe swallowed a mouthful of panic and forced air down his throat. He could still remember the note in the bunker - watch it again, and the curse got meaner. He'd felt it when the tape degraded and the room tightened. He'd felt it in his bones when he'd yanked the tape away and the corridors seemed to lean closer. The seven days wasn't a comfort. It was a countdown. And if Garrick

was here now, if the bunker wanted him to stay, then it would keep finding ways to make him watch.

"I can get out," Marlowe said, and the words came out thin, like they'd been filtered through static. He shoved the door again, hard enough to bruise his shoulder. The vibration spiked, a buzzing that crawled up his arm and left his skin prickling. "The air - outside. There's - there's open space."

Garrick laughed once. It wasn't loud, but it was wrong - too steady, too certain, like he'd rehearsed it in a mirror. "Outside doesn't save anyone." His gaze flicked to the exit seam where the door met the frame. "It just gives Stitch more room to look."

The name hit Marlowe like a shove. Stitch wasn't supposed to be near. Stitch was supposed to be a distortion in frames, a grin that flashed and vanished, a laugh that didn't belong to any mouth. But it had been in the tape. It had been in the bunker's way of turning corridors into traps. It had been in the way the walls had seemed to tighten when Marlowe tried to leave.

Marlowe leaned in again, breath tearing at his throat. The door's vibration became a rhythm, stuttering - then aligning with something inside his chest. Every time his heart thudded, the metal buzzed back as if it was syncing to him. The handle shivered under his grip. The seam between door and frame flashed, not with light but with a brief, glitch-like smear of wrongness: a smear of brightness that looked like a VHS tracking error had been painted over the gap. For half a second, the crack showed a slice of forest - too green, too sharp, as if it had been ripped from another tape and pasted over the real world.

Marlowe's lungs flared with hope so hot it hurt.

He tried to twist the handle. It didn't turn; it vibrated harder, like the mechanism had decided his touch was an insult. The door resisted with a stubborn, living pressure. When Marlowe yanked back, pain shot through his fingers, and the

sensation wasn't just physical - his nerves tingled with a phantom pressure, like someone had grabbed his hand from the other side of the metal.

Behind him, Garrick took a step. "Marlowe." The way he said it made the name sound like a command. "Don't fight the lock."

"I'm not fighting you," Marlowe rasped, and he hated how desperate it sounded. He shoved the door again with his shoulder, then his hip, then both hands flat as if brute force could bully reality into compliance. The vibrations made his vision wobble. The room seemed to shrink around the exit chamber - walls inching closer, ceiling lowering by degrees so small the mind argued with the eyes. He could feel the bunker's breath in the air, warm and stale, smelling of old paper and plastic rot.

The jammed door answered with a surge, and Marlowe stumbled back a step, nearly colliding with the wall. The metal rang. The sound didn't travel normally; it seemed to bounce inside his skull, ricocheting between thoughts. In that ringing, laughter threaded itself - faint at first, then sharper, like a needle dragged across a record.

"Seven days," the laughter seemed to whisper, but it wasn't a voice in the room. It was in the spaces between Marlowe's breaths, in the gaps where his panic wanted to fill. "Seven days - seven days - "

Marlowe pressed his hands to his ears anyway, as if he could keep the curse out. His palms came away damp. Sweat. Fear-sweat. His skin felt too tight on his bones. His legs trembled with exhaustion he hadn't earned yet - like the bunker had started spending his energy for him. The faster he moved, the more the air thinned. The more he tried to run toward freedom, the more his body acted like it was being dragged backward by unseen hands.

Garrick moved again, closer. "You already watched it," he said, and his voice went smooth around the words. "You already gave Stitch what it wanted."

Marlowe shook his head. "I pulled it out." He remembered the tape's image smearing, Stitch's grin flashing for a fraction of a second before the screen cut to static. He remembered ejecting it like ripping out a tongue. "I stopped it."

Garrick's smile twitched, and Marlowe felt it like a cold draft. "You stopped the tape. You didn't stop the curse."

The exit chamber's buzzing shifted pitch. The vibration sharpened into a high whine that made Marlowe's teeth hum. The air grew thicker, almost syrupy, sticking to his tongue. He tried to breathe through his mouth; it tasted like pennies and mold. His eyes watered. The world wavered, edges crawling like they were being re-rendered by a bad signal.

For a moment, the exit door wasn't a door. It was a strip of screen. The seam wasn't metal - it was a glowing line of corrupted color, and beyond it was the wrong forest again, closer now, inviting like a promise stitched onto a lie. Marlowe could almost smell the wet leaves, the cold air outside.

He reached for the handle again, fingers shaking so hard he could barely close them around it. The handle was slick with something that wasn't sweat - greasy, warm, as if the metal had been held against skin from the other side of the world. His stomach rolled. He yanked his hand back, breath stuttering.

"Don't touch it," Garrick snapped, suddenly urgent. His eyes flicked to Marlowe's fingers, and in them Marlowe saw something like fear. It didn't last. It got swallowed by obsession. "It'll - "

The door spasmed.

The exit chamber's walls buckled inward by an inch, then another. Not enough for anyone to fall - just enough to make every movement feel like it was being corrected by invisible hands. Marlowe stumbled forward to catch himself. His shoulder slammed into the doorframe. Pain flared bright, then dulled into a throbbing ache that made him nauseous.

The seam flashed again, and this time it didn't show forest. It showed the inside of a child's classroom on a screen - bright colors, too cheerful, too clean - then the image shattered into a smear of teeth. Stitch's grin flickered across the gap like a frame that refused to be forgotten.

Marlowe flinched back. His heel hit the floor, and he nearly went down. The bunker's air pressed against his ribs, restricting how far his lungs could expand. He could hear his own breath - ragged, wet, too loud. He could hear Garrick behind him too, but the sound came with a lag, like the bunker had started buffering reality.

"Stop," Marlowe said again, not to Garrick this time. To the curse. To the vibrating door. To his own body that kept trying to shut down. "Stop."

Garrick stepped around him with the patience of someone approaching prey. "You can't outrun it," he murmured. "It already knows where you'll go."

Marlowe's vision sparkled at the edges. He blinked hard, and the room briefly rewrote itself: the exit chamber stretched longer than it should've been, walls sliding like a tape being pulled too fast. Then it snapped back, leaving him dizzy and half-certain he'd imagined the lengthening. He tasted static. It coated his tongue like ash.

His goal was clear: out. Open air. Somewhere the curse couldn't ride the walls. Somewhere his lungs could take a full breath without the bunker breathing back.

He ran.

Not far - just from the door to the corner where the chamber narrowed into a maintenance passage. He'd seen it earlier while searching for the exit route, a thin gap behind a panel with a rusted latch. He'd almost fit his shoulders through. Almost. Now he lunged at it anyway, shoulder first, knuckles scraping metal. The bunker's temperature seemed to drop around him, cold enough to make his sweat chill. The passage squeezed his arms. The walls vibrated with the exit door, synchronized like a chorus.

Behind him, Garrick's boots scraped. "Marlowe!"

The sound of his name, again - like a tether.

Marlowe forced his body forward, teeth clenched to keep from screaming when the passage bit into his ribs. His shirt tore. A sharp pain flared where metal rubbed skin. His breath came in burned, harsh pulls. Every exhale felt like it scraped his throat on the way out.

He squeezed through the narrowing gap until his head nearly wouldn't fit. The world turned bright at the edges, then black, then bright again, as if his eyes were trying to stream a corrupted file. He could hear the laughter again - fainter now, but it didn't stop. It followed him like a tag on the back of his neck.

Then the passage ended.

Not with the open air he'd imagined - no corridor leading outside, no sliver of daylight. It ended with a second door, smaller, flush with the wall, the kind built for emergency access. Marlowe slammed into it hard enough to jolt his shoulder again. His hands found the handle. It was there. It felt real. It felt colder than the other door, as if it had been waiting longer.

He threw his weight against it, twisting until his wrist screamed.

The handle didn't give. The metal didn't vibrate like the first exit. Instead, it felt... sealed. Like it had been welded to the world. Like the bunker had decided this was the last place he'd ever run to.

Marlowe pressed his ear against it. Silence, thick and airless, except for the muffled static hum that seemed to come from inside the door itself. Under the hum, another sound: a wet clicking, like tape spooling in a machine behind a wall.

He backed away, lungs wheezing, and the room seemed to tilt. His stomach churned with exhaustion so deep it wasn't just fatigue - it was a collapse. His

muscles trembled with the need to stop, to sit, to let the curse catch up. The bunker wanted him to surrender. Every instinct screamed to keep moving, but his body argued back, refusing to obey.

Footsteps filled the chamber. Garrick's voice came from the other side of the passage, closer now. "You're right there."

Marlowe's mouth was dry. "Let me - " He couldn't finish. The words tangled on his tongue. He tried to swallow and felt his throat catch.

He looked down at his hands. Scrapes and smears of grime. A faint smear of something darker on his fingertips, sticky like oil. His skin felt wrong - tingly, as if the curse had touched him and left a residue that would keep spreading.

The door's seam - where it met the frame - widened by a hair, just enough for a line of light to show. Marlowe leaned in, squinting. For a heartbeat, he saw open space again: the island's air, the cold breeze, the smell of wet sand. He could almost hear gulls. Almost.

Then the light flickered.

Stitch's grin flashed across the seam like a corrupted frame. Not a full image - just the suggestion of teeth and a tongue too dark, a face that didn't belong to any angle. Laughter poured out of the crack, wet and delighted.

Marlowe recoiled so hard his shoulder slammed into the wall. The pain was sharp enough to make him gasp. His knees buckled. He caught himself with his palms against the metal, leaving streaks of sweat.

Garrick's silhouette blocked the gap of the passage. He didn't need to push to enter; the bunker seemed to make room for him. His boots scraped, then stopped. He leaned forward just slightly, knife held low, like he was deciding how to taste the moment.

"You hit the wrong door," Garrick said, voice calm.

"It's a door," Marlowe rasped. His throat burned. "Doors open."

Garrick's eyes flicked to the seam of the smaller exit. "Not anymore."

The sealed door vibrated once. A short, angry twitch. The seam light vanished. The handle, still in Marlowe's grip, went numb under his fingers as if his touch had been erased. The metal absorbed the vibration and held it. Then, with a sound like rubber tearing and plastic snapping, the door's frame tightened around itself.

Marlowe jerked the handle again, twice, three times, harder. His muscles screamed with each pull. The door didn't move. The seam sealed with a final click that sounded final enough to make his stomach drop.

Silence followed - so complete it felt like the bunker had stopped breathing.

Marlowe's chest rose and fell in shallow, panicked attempts. His lungs burned. His eyes stung from tears he hadn't noticed forming. He could still hear the laughter, softer now, like it was pleased with how quickly he'd stopped running.

Garrick stepped fully into the chamber. The passage behind him looked narrower than it had a second ago, walls pressing in like a closing throat. He raised the knife a few inches, not rushing, letting the dread build in Marlowe's ribs.

"Seven days," Garrick whispered, tasting the words like a prayer. "You can't leave before it finishes."

Marlowe backed up until his shoulder met the wall. The wall felt closer than it should've been - too smooth, too tight. The chamber had shrunk around him without warning. His breath came in broken gasps that didn't satisfy anything. He tried to inhale and found only stale bunker air, thick as wet cloth.

His mind scrambled for the exit he'd seen - the flicker of light, the taste of outside air. It was gone now, replaced by the sealed metal and Garrick's

shadow. His thoughts felt delayed, like the bunker had started buffering him too. Laughter threaded into his thoughts again, layered over his own heartbeat.

He couldn't make his body move fast enough. He couldn't make the door open. He couldn't even make his panic stop screaming.

Garrick took one more step, and the knife's leather handle creaked softly in his grip. In the dim chamber light, a glitch-like shimmer ran over Garrick's face for a fraction of a second - like Stitch's presence was testing the edges of reality.

Marlowe clamped his jaw shut against a sound that wanted to become a sob. He lifted his hands, scraping at the sealed door one last time, as if frantic rubbing could rewrite the lock. The metal didn't give. It didn't even respond with vibration this time.

It held.

Behind the door, the wet tape-spooling sound clicked once, then again - closer, almost affectionate. The laughter returned, fainter than before but sharper, like it had moved into the room with them.

Garrick's knife hovered near Marlowe's chest. "You wanted air," he said. "Now you'll get what the bunker wants to show you."

Marlowe stared at the sealed exit chamber door, at the seam that had promised outside and then swallowed it shut. His lungs burned until the pain turned numb. His legs shook until they felt like they belonged to someone else. The curse was still ticking - quiet, patient, certain.

The bunker had turned the last route into a trap that didn't open again. And as Garrick closed the distance, the laughter inside Marlowe's head finally synced with his breath, turning panic into rhythm - until running felt like a memory he'd never survive long enough to have.



The Tape Calls, Forcing the Hunt

Marrow in his lungs burned like someone had packed it with sandpaper. Somewhere behind the sealed exit chamber door, the bunker clicked and sighed, slow as a throat working around a swallowed sound. Marlowe's breath came in thin shreds, and then Garrick's voice cut through it - flat, close, and furious - like a blade tapping glass.

"Don't move," Garrick said.

Marlowe didn't answer with words. He just pressed his shoulder harder to the seam where the door met the frame, fingers scrabbling at the vibrating edge as if friction could unmake the trap. The corridor around them didn't feel like a corridor anymore. It felt like a strip of film being yanked from a projector - wood and concrete warping into something that wanted to rearrange itself around the living.

Garrick's steps stopped just out of reach. Static crawled along the walls in faint, invisible threads, and the air smelled faintly of warm plastic and old pennies.

"Garrick," Marlowe rasped, and the name sounded wrong in the bunker's mouth, stretched and warped. "He - he's not - "

"Stitch isn't here," Garrick snapped, and the lie tasted metallic. His tone carried the same stubbornness as when he'd been running outside, when the bridge had buckled under his weight and the laughter under the boards had turned into something wet and delighted. "He's on the tape."

The words landed like a decision made too late. Marlowe's eyes flicked toward the darkness beyond the chamber, toward any seam that might still pretend to be an exit. The bunker answered with a low, mechanical groan - somewhere deeper inside, a hinge grinding like teeth.

Garrick didn't wait for Marlowe to think. He shoved into the corridor side, shoulder first, and the floor beneath him shivered. The lights overhead - if you could call them lights - blinked with the rhythm of a failing VCR. For a second, the hallway behind him wasn't a hallway at all. It was a strip of stairs that led downward into a wall of static. Then the image stuttered back into place, the same corridor pretending it hadn't just tried to become something else.

His knife was in his paw, leather handle slick with sweat. He could feel the tape in his head like a second heartbeat - *Stitch: Forbidden Episode* - its label burned into memory by the moment he'd found it, the moment he'd realized the curse didn't just punish. It recruited.

He wanted the tape back. Not to hide it. Not to destroy it. Garrick wanted to make it move - make it spread - turn the voices into a schedule he could drive, a hunt he could steer. The bunker had already made Marlowe a prisoner. Garrick wasn't going to let it keep him stuck in passive terror while the tape kept doing what it did best: turning watching into obedience.

The obstacle arrived without warning: the corridor junction shifted.

The door seam Marlowe had been fighting began to ripple like a badly edited video. The hinges flexed. The frame bowed inward, then outward, as if the bunker couldn't decide where "closed" should be. The air grew colder, then warmer, then cold again, all in the span of a blink. Garrick's breath fogged in front of him, and the fog didn't drift - it crawled along the floor toward the exit chamber like something seeking a mouth to fill.

"Garrick - stop," Marlowe said again, voice cracking. "You can't - "

"I can," Garrick replied, and the words came out like he'd already said them to the tape. He reached for the thin metal panel beside the exit chamber - an access plate he'd glimpsed in notes and glimpsed again when the corridors rearranged like corrupted film tracks. His fingers hit the plate, and it was wrong. Not rust-wrong. Not dirty-wrong. Wrong like it belonged to a different bunker, a different version of the same place.

The plate was warm.

From inside it, he heard faint, muffled laughter - too distant to be human, too pleased to be random. It synced with the tape static in his ears until it sounded like both were coming from the same source.

Garrick's jaw tightened. He pulled the plate free.

The wall behind it didn't open into wiring or ductwork. It opened into another corridor, narrower than the one he'd been in, with scuffed concrete and a smell of damp carpet. A hallway that hadn't been there a moment ago. The bunker had rerouted itself around his attempt to get the tape's path back.

Marlowe lunged, not with strength so much as desperation. "Don't go in there," he hissed. "That's not the way. It - it keeps - "

Garrick turned his head just enough to look at him. Marlowe's eyes were too bright, pupils stretched thin. His mouth was smeared with something dark - dried blood or old grime - either way it made his face look like it had already been handled by something rough. He looked like a person who'd been chased for hours even though he'd been trapped for what felt like seconds.

"You're trying to save yourself," Garrick said. "So you're stalling."

"I'm trying to keep you alive," Marlowe snapped, and the bunker made the words echo back wrong - one syllable delayed, then repeated in a different pitch, like the sound had been edited. "I heard it. The voices get louder when you - when you - "

Garrick didn't let the sentence finish. He stepped through the newly opened corridor. The air inside tasted like cheap plastic and mildew. His shoulder brushed the wall, and the wall felt soft for half a second - like foam wrapped in concrete - before it hardened again under his palm. The corridor narrowed as he walked, not enough to stop him, but enough to remind him his body was being measured.

His goal tightened in his chest: retrieve the tape. Keep it with him. Make the voices obey his hands instead of his fear.

He pulled the access panel from his pocket - notes he'd torn from the bunker earlier, ink smudged by damp hands and shaking breath. The paper fluttered as the corridor breathed around him. In the dimness, he could read only fragments: Stitch: Forbidden Episode. Seven days. Force viewing.

Force viewing.

That phrase didn't come from the paper. It came from his skull, from the voices that had been growing louder after every kill. They weren't just demanding. They were teaching him the shape of the curse like a salesman showing merchandise - only the product was suffering, and the receipt was blood.

Garrick's steps quickened. The corridor responded by tightening further. His knife arm brushed his side, the leather handle knocking his ribs with each stride. The noise of his feet sounded too loud, then too far away, then close again as the hallway glitched in depth. The floor vibrated under him like the bunker was running on a failing motor.

Behind him, Marlowe's voice came again, thin and frantic. "If you take it - if you play it again - "

Garrick didn't answer. He couldn't afford to let Marlowe's fear become a detour.

The corridor junction opened like a wound.

One moment he was in a narrowing hallway; the next, he stood at a three-way split that looked older than the rest of the bunker. The concrete here was darker, stained with old water. The smell shifted to something sharp and chemical, like burnt insulation. A strip of VHS tape - actual tape, not just static - hung from a pipe at head height, dangling lazily though there was no air movement. Its label was smeared, but the letters were still there if you stared long enough.

Stitch: Forbidden Episode.

Garrick's stomach clenched. He moved toward it, and the hallway floor under his feet made a sound like fabric tearing. Not loud, but intimate. Like the bunker was laughing quietly through its own throat.

The tape wasn't in the same place twice.

The first time he reached for it, his fingers closed on nothing but cold air. The second time, the tape jerked away, still dangling from the pipe, but now farther down the corridor than it had been. He had to step around a bend that didn't exist a breath ago. His sneakers - scuffed, damp - slid on a slick patch of concrete that hadn't been there before.

Marlowe's footsteps pounded somewhere behind the walls, closer than they should have been. "Garrick!" he called, and the name came out like a warning dragged over gravel. "It's bait. It wants you to - "

Garrick turned his head toward the sound. The corridor behind him was wrong. It wasn't the corridor he'd entered. It was a shorter version, a tighter version, one that made the distance between him and Marlowe feel like a lie. Marlowe should have been far enough behind to let Garrick breathe. Instead, the gap looked like it could close if the walls leaned in.

Garrick made a decision anyway, sharp as a knife point.

He didn't chase the dangling tape. He grabbed the pipe the tape was tied to. His palm slammed against metal that felt hot enough to sting. The leather handle of his knife pressed against his ribs as he braced, and his other hand scrabbled at the tie holding the VHS.

The bunker fought him.

The pipe flexed like cartilage. The concrete under his heels squirmed, pushing him forward a half-step, then back, then sideways. The air thickened, and sound warped - his own breathing didn't match his chest. It sounded delayed, as if the bunker was playing him back from earlier footage.

"Stop!" Marlowe screamed, and the scream bent midair into something like a laugh. "It's not for you!"

Garrick's eyes burned. He yanked harder.

The tie snapped.

The VHS tape dropped into his hand with a wet slap, as if it had been soaked in something that didn't dry. The label was intact - *Stitch: Forbidden Episode* - though the ink looked like it had crawled since he'd last seen it. Tiny black smears ringed the edges like the tape had been chewed.

His fingers closed around it. For a second, the static in his ears quieted, replaced by a low, pleased hum that vibrated through his bones.

Then the corridor shuddered like it had been waiting for him to commit.

A line of corridors lit up ahead - faint, sickly blue - like the bunker had drawn path markers on its own skin. Each blue light flickered with the cadence of tape playback. The junction behind him tightened, shrinking the space so fast his shoulder scraped the wall and skin screamed with a fresh burn. Dust rained down in thin flakes that smelled like scorched paper.

Garrick tightened his grip on the tape and ran.

The chase became internal first - his lungs seized, then his legs started negotiating with pain. His feet slapped the floor and slipped on slick concrete that appeared under him like trick glass. The hallway narrowed until his knife arm couldn't swing. His shoulder hit the wall again and again, each impact sending jolts through his body that blurred his vision into streaks.

Behind him, Marlowe's voice chased too, but not with distance. It chased with timing - arriving a fraction of a second after Garrick's own movements, like the bunker was playing him out of sync. Sometimes the words were Marlowe's. Sometimes they were something wearing his voice, stretched and excited.

"Garrick, don't," Marlowe said, and then laughter threaded through the sentence, wet and delighted.

Garrick didn't look back. Looking back was how the curse turned fear into direction. He kept his eyes on the next flickering blue corridor marker, on the way the lights seemed to herd him like a flock being pushed into a pen.

The bunker junction re-routed again, but it did it with purpose now. Corridors that should have split into dead ends became straight shots. Walls that felt solid moments ago grew soft, then hard, then soft again - like the place couldn't decide if it wanted to trap him or reshape him into something that fit.

His sweat soaked his shirt. It ran down his spine in hot lines, then chilled as the air temperature dropped. The smell of damp carpet thickened until it coated his tongue. His mouth tasted like pennies. Every breath felt too small, as if the bunker had lowered the ceiling of his lungs.

Then the VHS player appeared.

Not in a room. Not on a shelf. It was bolted into the wall at shoulder height, absurdly convenient, like the bunker had always been built around this exact moment. A slot yawned open beside it, its edges lined with scratches and old tape burn.

Garrick stumbled to a stop. His shoulder hammered the wall as he leaned in. His chest heaved. His fingers shook violently around the tape label.

Marlowe arrived in the corridor behind him with a scrape and a gasp, breath ragged, voice strained to hold anger and terror in the same throat. "You can't - " he started.

Garrick looked over his shoulder just long enough to see the fear in Marlowe's face shift into something else. Not persuasion. Not reasoning. A kind of baited urgency, like Marlowe was trying to offer Garrick a path that would keep the walls busy somewhere else.

Garrick understood. Marlowe wasn't just trapped. Marlowe was trying to steer Garrick away from the tape to buy himself seconds of hiding.

The voices in Garrick's head rose, not as a warning this time, but as a command that felt like his own thought. Force viewing. Make them watch.

He thrust the tape toward the slot.

The bunker responded instantly: the corridor behind him exhaled, and the walls pressed in, compressing the space until Garrick could feel the pressure on his ribs through his shirt. The air turned stale, thick with static. The VHS player's screen flickered to life with gray-blue noise.

Marlowe lunged forward. "Garrick - !"

Garrick slammed the tape in anyway.

The mechanism swallowed it with a mechanical click that sounded too much like a throat clearing. The screen filled with the first harmless frame - bright colors, childish shapes, a familiar cartoon rhythm that made Garrick's stomach twist with disgust. The bunker smelled suddenly sweeter, like cheap candy and old plastic.

Then the image stuttered.

The edges smeared. The colors bled into bruised reds and sickly greens. Stitch's outline flickered for a fraction of a second in the static - too crisp for comfort, too close to real - grinning like a promise.

The voices surged louder, excited as if the bunker itself had just tasted something it had been hungry for.

Garrick stood with the tape playing, breath ragged, sweat running, his knife arm aching from the corridor's constant jostling. The claustrophobia sharpened into certainty. He wasn't wandering anymore. He wasn't being delayed by glitches and shifting walls. He was locked onto a single line of action, and the bunker was feeding him that line like a track for an oncoming train.

Marlowe backed away from the blue-lit screen, eyes wide, trying to find corners to hide in that didn't exist anymore. "No," he whispered, and his voice cracked into hysteria. "It's not - it's not supposed to - "

Garrick stepped forward, blocking the corridor with his body. His face felt numb, but the tape's laughter vibrating through the wall made his teeth feel like they were vibrating too.

"You wanted me to stop," Garrick said, and the words came out calm only because his panic had been converted into hunger. "You wanted me lost."

The screen glitched again, Stitch's grin flashing in the static like a camera catching a predator. Garrick felt the voices in his skull latch onto the tape's rhythm, turning the hunt into something mechanical - something he could follow without thinking.

Marlowe's eyes darted past Garrick, searching for a safe hiding spot in a bunker that no longer gave them. The corridors behind him were already rearranging, sealing seams with slow, grinding certainty.

Garrick lifted the knife, leather handle slick in his grip, and watched the tape's degraded picture crawl forward, frame by frame, with the inevitability of a

countdown.

He had the tape.

He had the purpose.

Behind the walls, the bunker shifted like it was listening, and every corridor reroute felt like it was choosing the next prey.



Marlowe Watches Stitch Devour the World

The tape's label - *Stitch: Forbidden Episode* - still sat burned into Marlowe's vision even after he yanked it free. The bunker player clacked like it wanted to keep chewing, plastic teeth snapping, and the screen behind the glass kept flickering with a picture that refused to stay inside the monitor. Somewhere beyond the walls, Garrick was hunting the last Sprunkies with the knife in his paw and the tape's countdown already ticking through his head. Marlowe could feel it in his sinuses, metallic and sour, like chewed pennies and old milk.

His lungs wouldn't decide whether to fill or collapse. The air in the screening alcove tasted of warm dust and dead circuitry, and every time the monitor sputtered, the sound came a half-second late - like the bunker was lagging behind itself. Marlowe pressed his hands against the cold metal frame to steady them, but the vibration ran up his wrists anyway, a tremor that made his knuckles feel too small for his bones. He tried to think of Lina's face - trapped somewhere in the bunker's shifting throat - but all he could summon was the tape's distorted grin, its blue-white teeth flashing through the glitch.

"Not again," he whispered, not to anyone, just to the walls. The bunker responded by tightening: the alcove's corners seemed to slide inward by fractions, compressing the air until even his thoughts felt crowded. Behind the monitor glass, the picture warped - colors smearing into a wet, stretched mess - then snapped back like a cut film. For one blink, Marlowe saw Stitch's mouth

where a cartoon character should've been, stitched-together darkness swallowing the frame.

Marlowe wanted one thing this time, immediate and brutal in its simplicity: keep anyone from being forced to watch. He didn't have the strength to win a war against the bunker, against Garrick's knife, against whatever lived in the tape's broken signal. But he could do one clean act - rip the cursed viewing chain apart before it reached its next victim. If Garrick was out there with the tape, if the voices had been pushing him toward the last Sprunkies, then Marlowe needed to get to that tape first or stop the forced viewing long enough to buy distance, breath, a doorway that didn't close like a throat.

The problem was the bunker itself had started behaving like a projector with no off switch.

A thud echoed through the corridor outside the alcove - knife on wood, or something heavy dragged across the floor. A second sound followed, higher, frantic: a Sprunki choke of fear that tried to turn into a laugh and failed. Marlowe forced his gaze to the doorway seam where the corridor should've stayed fixed. It didn't. The line of darkness between walls shimmered, and for a moment it looked like the gap was made of tape splices - ragged, uneven, pulling apart.

He heard Garrick's voice, close enough to ride the air. "You can't hide in there," he said, calm and hungry, the words too steady for what was happening. The knife scrape came next, leather handle squeaking faintly as he adjusted his grip. "Eyes open."

Marlowe backed toward the alcove's only exit, but the exit wasn't an exit anymore. The doorway had become a narrow slot, its edges rippling like the surface of black water when you drop a stone. The floor under his feet felt springy, wrong - like he was standing on a stretched membrane. He grabbed the edge anyway, fingers searching for metal, for hinges, for anything real.

The wall flexed.

He yanked his hand back and tasted blood where his nail had cut him. The sting grounded him for half a heartbeat. Then the monitor on the alcove wall popped brighter, as if responding to his hesitation. The screen flickered to a children's set - bright colors, cheerful shapes - except the cheer didn't land cleanly. The faces on the screen blinked with delays, their pupils drifting toward the camera like they were learning how to look.

Marlowe turned the tape in his mind like a weapon, the way he'd already tried to use it once. He remembered the clack of the player. He remembered the moment his escape attempt fell apart, corridors reshaping around him like they'd been waiting for that exact move. He remembered the bunker closing in so patiently it felt personal.

He couldn't fight the whole bunker. He could only fight the next forced viewing.

The alcove door shivered again, and this time the distortion resolved into a silhouette - human-shaped, but the outline glitched at the edges as if someone had dragged a cursor across it. Garrick slid into view through the warped doorway, knife raised, leather handle catching the monitor's sick light. His eyes were too reflective, the whites glowing faintly with the same blue tint Marlowe had seen in the tape's worst frames.

He held the VHS tape in his other paw like it was proof. The label faced Marlowe, smug as a warning. **Stitch: Forbidden Episode.** The plastic casing looked scuffed, but the screen behind Garrick kept overlaying it with a different image - Stitch's face blooming across the tape label like a bruise that wouldn't stop spreading.

"You shouldn't be here," Garrick said.

Marlowe's mouth went dry. "You shouldn't be doing that."

Garrick's expression didn't shift into anger. It shifted into excitement, like a dog offered a command it understood too well. "The tape wants them." He lifted the tape slightly, and the monitor's audio bled into the corridor - laughter too

cheerful to be human, whispers layered beneath it like static with teeth. "The voices are happy."

Marlowe lunged before he could think better. He didn't have a plan; he had panic. He grabbed for Garrick's wrist, aiming for the knife first because that was the only part that felt like a controllable threat. Garrick jerked away with practiced strength, leather handle scraping against his knuckles. The impact jarred Marlowe's arm to numbness.

"Stop!" Marlowe shouted, and his voice sounded thin inside the alcove, stretched by the bunker's wrong acoustics. The sound returned to him warped - like it had been recorded and played back half a second too late, his own words chasing him from behind.

Garrick stepped in. The air between them tightened, compressing warmth into a suffocating press. Marlowe smelled Garrick's sweat - sharp and sour - mixed with the tape's old-paper odor, the damp tang of something that had been stored too long. The monitor flickered, and in the glass Marlowe saw Stitch's grin again, closer than it should've been. The grin slid across the reflection as if the camera were moving.

"Look," Garrick said, and he didn't point at the tape. He pointed at Marlowe's eyes, as if Marlowe's gaze was already being forced. His voice lowered. "You tried to pull it out. It doesn't care. It follows the viewing."

Marlowe's stomach turned. He tried to blink the image away - tried to stare at Garrick's knife, tried to anchor himself in something he could cut through. But the bunker shoved the tape's picture into the space between them. The monitor flared, and the children's cartoon set on screen became a room with walls that leaned inward. The characters on the screen opened their mouths too wide, and Stitch's stitched darkness crawled across the frame like ink in water.

Marlowe flinched, and the movement was all the permission the bunker needed.

The corridor outside the alcove erupted with noise - wails cut off mid-breath, a wet thump, then frantic scratching like claws scraping for a way out of the world. A Sprunki's voice - Juniper's voice, or someone wearing her timbre - mangled by distance and distortion, cried out, "No - no - eyes open!"

Garrick's gaze snapped toward the sound. For a breath, his attention split. Marlowe seized that fraction of neglect like a blade. He shoved himself sideways, back toward the alcove's monitor and the player slot. His fingers found the casing of the tape sitting in the player - he didn't remember leaving it there, but the bunker had already decided it would be. The plastic was warm, as if it had been running.

The screen showed Stitch where a cheerful character should've been. Stitch's face wasn't just on the monitor; it was in the alcove air, a projected smear that made the walls look like they were made of gums. The corners of the room darkened and swelled, and Marlowe had the sick impression that if he moved wrong, the dark would close around him like a mouth.

He yanked the tape free.

The casing resisted, then surrendered with a sudden jerk that made his shoulder scream. The screen glitched hard enough to smear the image into a brief, terrifying still: Stitch's teeth filling the monitor, then filling the alcove, then filling Marlowe's vision. His eyes watered instantly. His nose filled with the tape's phantom smell - hot plastic and spoiled sugar - and his throat tightened as if the laughter had found a way into his body.

Garrick lunged.

Knife first, blade aimed at Marlowe's ribs. Marlowe twisted, tape casing clutched in both hands like it could stop a strike. The knife caught his forearm instead. Pain exploded - hot and immediate - followed by the wet drag of something tearing. Marlowe staggered, breath catching on a chunk of terror that refused to be inhaled.

"Give it," Garrick demanded, and his voice was thick now, strained by the tape's influence. "Give it back. I need the next viewing."

Marlowe's knees buckled. The alcove floor felt slick, though it wasn't. His skin crawled with the awareness that the bunker's geometry was shifting around their bodies, compressing them into a smaller and smaller pocket of space. The walls rippled again, and the monitor's light pulsed in time with the laughter from the tape - like the building was breathing through a broken speaker.

Marlowe didn't answer. He did something worse than refusing.

He smashed the tape casing against the monitor frame.

Plastic cracked with a sharp pop. The sound echoed too long, stretched into a thin scream. The screen flared white, then went black for half a second - just long enough for Marlowe to feel hope punch through his ribs like a bullet. Then the monitor came back wrong, colors inverted, the children's set replaced by a warped, close-up image: Stitch's eyes, wide and gleaming, staring directly from the screen into Marlowe's face.

The tape didn't just play anymore. It leaked.

The flicker spilled into the alcove like liquid film. Stitch's stitched grin formed along the walls, appearing in the seam lines, in the corners, in the scratches on the metal frame. The shadows stopped being shadows. They deepened into shapes that looked like gums, and the air turned colder, as if the bunker had decided it didn't need Marlowe warm to keep him alive.

Garrick staggered back, knife dropping a fraction as the forced viewing's grip tightened on him too. His eyes unfocused. His mouth opened like he was about to laugh and vomit at the same time. "No... no, that's not - "

Marlowe used the opening. He shoved his shoulder into the warped doorway, feeling the slot flex like a rubber band. It resisted, then gave. He stumbled out of the alcove into a corridor that shouldn't exist - walls too close, ceiling too low,

the floor rising under his feet like the bunker was lifting its throat to swallow him whole.

Behind him, Garrick snarled. "He's cheating the tape!"

The laughter surged - louder, more excited - then warped into whispers that sounded almost like Stitch speaking through multiple mouths at once. The corridor shivered with glitch frames: one second, a straight hallway; the next, a tight spiral; then a brief flash of black water, rippling as if the bunker were built on a drowning surface. Marlowe ran anyway, his injured forearm dragging fire down his skin.

His feet slipped. The floor wasn't flat anymore. It undulated like tape rolling over a head, the texture grabbing at his soles. Every step felt like it was being recorded and played back with slight delay, forcing him to chase his own motion. He stumbled forward, breath burning, lungs scraping like sandpaper. The air smelled like overheated electronics and sweat and something sweet rotting at the back of his tongue.

"Marlowe!" Garrick's voice came from behind, too close, knife scraping again. "Watch it. Watch it. You can't - "

Marlowe didn't look back. He couldn't afford to see Garrick's face when the tape had him. He clutched the partially ripped tape casing in his hands. When he squeezed, the torn plastic edges pressed into his palms, and the pain felt like confirmation that the object was still real. The label was smeared now, the letters warped by the impact.

Stitch: Forbidden Episode.

But the tape wasn't whole. It was broken in a way that made the bunker hesitate, made the corridor distort with little stutters instead of full, smooth shifts. A glitch in the system. A hesitation in the mouth.

He burst around a corner and found the corridor narrowing into a wall seam, a panel of metal with a warped handle that looked like it belonged on a different door in a different time. The seam pulsed faintly with monitor light. Marlowe slammed his hand into it anyway, fingers searching for purchase, forcing the door to be a door.

The handle didn't turn. The metal vibrated like a speaker. In the thin gap between panel and frame, he saw a slice of the screening alcove again - seen through a distorted lens - Stitch's grin plastered across the monitor, and Garrick's face angled toward it, eyes reflecting the tape's image like mirrors.

Marlowe's stomach lurched. The forced viewing wasn't just a single moment. It was a condition the bunker could enforce through space itself. The tape could reach through cracks.

He pressed his forehead against the panel, breathing hard enough to fog the metal. His voice came out broken. "No more."

He tore the tape further.

The plastic gave with an ugly snap, and the sound seemed to travel through the bunker like a signal. The corridor hiccuped. Light stuttered. The air temperature jumped, then dropped hard, and the seam panel shivered as if something behind it had flinched. For one heartbeat, Marlowe felt the pressure in his skull ease - just enough to let him force his next movement.

He yanked the torn tape against the seam's edge, forcing the ripped casing into the gap like a wedge, like a plug. The bunker fought back immediately: the metal tried to close around his hands, the seam narrowing, the corridor trying to fold him back into the alcove's orbit. Pain flared in his forearm where Garrick's knife had bitten earlier. His vision tunneled, then glitched - frame lines appearing across his sight like he was being filmed.

In that glitch, Stitch appeared for the first time without being trapped behind glass.

Not fully. Not clean. Just a fraction of a stitched face crawling across the seam, teeth implied by darkness. The laughter that came from it wasn't sound anymore; it was a pressure behind his eyes, making them ache as if someone had pressed a thumb into the socket. Marlowe gagged, bile rising, and still he shoved until his shoulder screamed.

The seam opened.

Not wide. Not safe. Just enough for him to slip through before the bunker decided to finish closing its mouth. He fell into a tight pocket of space - another corridor, narrower than the last, walls sweating condensation that smelled like old popcorn. Behind him, the panel slammed halfway shut and then stalled, glitching in place, as if his torn tape had jammed the bunker's attempt to correct itself.

Marlowe crawled forward on hands that shook, forearm bleeding slow and hot. Every breath tasted like static. He forced himself not to look back at the seam, not to let Stitch's grin crawl into his vision again.

Somewhere down the shifting corridor, Garrick's voice echoed - angrier now, warped by the tape's interference. "He's - he's ruined it!"

And the bunker, unable to decide what was real, flickered.

Marlowe clutched the torn casing to his chest, the label now split and half-peeled, letters smearing like bruises. He didn't know if he'd bought himself minutes or seconds. He didn't know whether the next forced viewing would still find him through the curse's rules.

But as he crawled into the dark, the corridor's squeeze loosened for the first time since the bunker began listening, and the world stuttered - just long enough to feel like a door was still possible.

Seven Days Starts Counting Out Loud

The dark didn't feel like emptiness anymore. It felt like a mouth that had just loosened its grip - only long enough to prove it could tighten again. Marlowe crawled forward through the corridor's brief slackening, tape casing clutched to his chest with fingers that no longer had the strength to be careful. Behind him, the bunker's walls clicked and re-sealed their seams with a patient, mechanical sound, like someone rewinding a tape and refusing to find the right frame.

Static threaded through the air. Not the soft hiss of old electronics - this was thick, wet noise that made his teeth ache. It carried laughter in wrong places, giggles that skittered along the metal ribs of the passage and then vanished when he tried to locate them. The torn casing pressed into his sternum. Each breath rasped, and each rasp sounded too loud in the narrow throat of the bunker.

He didn't know whether the corridor was opening or simply giving him a false second to die in a different spot. The only certainty was the countdown feeling in his bones, the seven days ticking somewhere behind the walls like a clock with no face.

Marlowe pushed himself up against the narrowing air. His shoulder scraped, skin tearing under the friction, and the pain was so immediate it made him dizzy. Somewhere farther back, the bunker shuddered - like power surged, then stuttered. A faint, electrical odor - hot plastic and damp dust - spilled through the cracks, and with it came the sense that something in the station was alive and listening to the tape more closely than it had any right to.

His goal arrived with the clarity of a knife: get to the control station and change what the curse could do. Not just hide until it reached him. Not just run until the bunker decided the corridor was too small. He had already torn the tape once during the forced viewing climax. He'd felt the loop snag. He'd seen the frames wobble, like the curse didn't like being interrupted.

If he could reach the wires - if he could disrupt the player's sync - maybe he could force the bunker to miscount. Maybe the seven days didn't have to be clean, linear time. Maybe it could be dragged, warped, made to skip.

He scrabbled forward anyway, dragging his torn casing like a stolen piece of proof. His legs shook with the kind of exhaustion that didn't belong to muscles - fatigue that lived in the nerves and told him to stop moving because stopping was safer. But the static laughed each time he slowed, and the laughter sounded pleased, like it had been waiting for him to give up.

The corridor widened just enough to let him turn his head. A smear of emergency light flickered through a side opening: dull red, then green, then back to red, as if the bunker couldn't decide what color meant "safe." Cables ran along the walls in tangled loops, some of them swollen with condensation, some of them frayed like nerves. When Marlowe breathed too close to them, the insulation smelled faintly of pennies and old rain.

He reached the mouth of the station - an open chamber with a low ceiling and a console bristling with switches, meters, and tangled ribbon cables. The air here was colder, the kind of cold that didn't come from outside but from machines that had been running too long and too wrong. A monitor sat dark, but its surface still held a ghost reflection of moving static, faint and restless. Beside it, the VHS player's guts were exposed behind a panel that had been pried open and then resealed badly, as if the bunker had tried to hide its own throat wounds.

The tape wasn't just a tape in his hands anymore. It was an instruction written in flicker and violence, and the bunker had been following it like a set of

coordinates. Marlowe could feel the curse's attention on him, like eyes pressing from the far side of the glass.

"Stop," he whispered, but the word came out as broken breath. "Stop counting out loud."

The bunker replied by stuttering. A relay clicked; the sound reverberated in his ribs. Somewhere behind the walls, a speaker popped, and then - too crisp, too close - counting began.

Not numbers he could read cleanly. It was a rhythm, a voice layered under static, as if the tape's soundtrack had been routed through the walls. A countdown that didn't care about his understanding, only his presence.

Seven days left.

The words felt like a hand closing around his throat. Marlowe stumbled toward the console, ignoring the way his shoulder screamed when he bumped it against a protruding metal brace. He found the control panel with the kind of instinct that comes from panic: his eyes snapped to the wiring junction, the loose bundle of leads feeding the VHS player. His torn casing dug into his chest as if it wanted to be used as a key.

He needed to do something with the loop. If the curse followed the tape's timing, then changing the timing could change the curse's behavior.

His fingers trembled as he reached for a thick cable bound with tape that looked newer than the rest, the adhesive glossy like it had been applied yesterday. When he touched it, the insulation burned his fingertips - heat flaring through his skin with an oily sting. He jerked his hand back, breath caught between pain and fear.

The static laughed again, and now it seemed to come from the console itself. The dark monitor flickered, and for one frame Marlowe saw a distorted image not of Stitch but of a countdown screen - numbers bending like they were made

of soft rubber. The next frame was Stitch's grin, stretched across a smear of color that didn't belong in any broadcast. Then it snapped back to static.

Marlowe swallowed. His tongue tasted copper.

He tried again, pressing his palm against the panel's edge rather than the cable, searching for a switch that could break the player's sync. The console lights blinked: red-red-green-red, out of order. A meter beside him twitched upward, then dropped, then twitched again, like a heartbeat tripping over itself.

"Give me a second," Marlowe said, and heard how pathetic it sounded - like bargaining with a machine that had already decided he was content.

Behind him, the corridor groaned. Not distant - inside the walls, close enough that the sound vibrated through the station floor. The bunker was rearranging itself around his choice to come here. The claustrophobia returned in a new shape: not a narrowing passage, but a chamber that felt like it had no exit once he committed to reaching it.

He turned. The station door behind him wasn't a door anymore. A section of wall had slid half an inch, sealing the gap with a damp, grinding rasp. The seam looked fresh, like the bunker had grown it while he wasn't looking.

The bunker didn't just trap. It corrected.

Marlowe's objective sharpened into something brutal: he had to change the curse without the luxury of running. If he couldn't delay death by hiding, he'd have to disrupt the loop right here, while the station still responded to his hands.

But the obstacle wasn't only the console. It was what the curse had already done to his head. The counting out loud - seven days left - kept syncing with the pulses in his ears until his thoughts felt like they were being dragged into the same rhythm. He could almost feel the tape's frames stacking inside his skull, waiting for the next forced viewing to find him.

He could hide the torn casing under the console and hope the bunker's attention wandered. He could press himself into a corner and make himself small enough to be overlooked by whatever hunted through the tape. The idea was so tempting it made him nauseous.

Because hiding would mean doing nothing, and doing nothing would mean letting the curse complete its pattern.

The counting grew louder. The voice layered under the static shifted closer to clarity, like the bunker was adjusting a microphone. Marlowe flinched as the words sharpened into something almost human.

"Seven," it said, and his skin prickled. "Six - "

"No." Marlowe lunged for the exposed guts of the VHS player. He shoved past the heat-seared cable and grabbed the player's eject lever with both hands. It was slick under his palms, greased by condensation or something worse. The lever wouldn't move. The mechanism resisted with a stubborn, physical refusal.

He yanked harder. His arm screamed. The lever clicked once, then jammed again, like teeth finding the wrong spot in the gear.

The station monitor flickered - an image of the torn casing in his hands, but wrong. The casing label was half peeled in the wrong direction, and the letters were smeared like bruises, not ink. In the reflection he saw himself with his head slightly tilted, eyes too wide, mouth open as if screaming - Except he wasn't screaming. He was breathing through pain, trying not to vomit.

The bunker was replaying him. The curse wasn't just counting down. It was learning him.

"Stop copying me," Marlowe hissed, and the words came out ragged enough that the static swallowed the end.

The counting stuttered. The voice snapped into a new rhythm, and with it came a sound like tape scraping across plastic teeth. The station's lights surged bright, then dimmed, then bright again in violent pulses that made his eyes water.

Marlowe slammed his palms against the open player housing, searching for anything loose. A ribbon cable hung like a loose tendon. He grabbed it, and the instant he pulled, the cable sparked - blue-white arcs jumping along the insulation. The smell of burnt electronics punched his nose. His fingers jerked back, but not fast enough; a thin strip of skin on his knuckle blistered immediately.

Pain anchored him. It was the only thing that felt real.

The VHS player's gears shuddered. The monitor flashed an analog smear: Stitch's distorted silhouette, too close, too inside the frame. For one brief moment, the grin looked like it had been printed directly over his own face, as if the tape could overlay him and make him part of the episode.

Then the image broke apart into glitch blocks that crawled sideways like insects. The countdown voice fractured too, splitting into overlapping versions of itself as if the station couldn't decide which timeline to follow.

Seven days left.

Seven days left.

Seven days left.

Marlowe's breath came in sharp, humiliating pulls. He pressed his torn casing against the player's exposed slot, forcing it toward the mechanism as if brute contact could trick the curse into accepting his interference.

The casing scraped the metal. The smell of old plastic and mold rose up. For a moment, he thought it was pointless - like trying to jam a key into a lock that

had been welded shut.

Then the slot's interior lights blinked in sequence: a single green pulse, then a red one. The monitor's static shifted, as if something had been aligned. The player didn't eject. It didn't accept either. It twitched.

The counting began again, but wrong.

It didn't say seven. It didn't say six. It said:

"Seven - seven - seven..."

A stammering loop of the same day, repeated until the words lost meaning and turned into a chant. The station trembled. The cables on the walls quivered like they were responding to a heartbeat that didn't belong to him.

Marlowe stared at the console, his vision blurred by tears he hadn't meant to shed. His mind tried to catch up to what his hands had done. The torn casing wasn't just a piece of evidence. It was an interruption, a physical error in the tape's path - something the player couldn't reconcile.

He had messed with the loop. Not by waiting for the curse to decide he was safe for a moment, but by making the station misread what it was supposed to show.

The bunker groaned, and the floor beneath him shivered. The sealed seam behind him widened by a fraction - then closed again, as if the bunker had regretted granting him the possibility of escape. The jammed door didn't open fully, but the fact it moved at all told him the curse had just been forced to change its behavior.

A new rule emerged in the air like a bruise forming: the curse could mutate. It could be pushed off its clean track.

Marlowe held his breath, then let it out slowly, careful not to panic into another mistake. He took the torn casing and shoved it deeper into the player slot, not to

play the episode again, but to force the circuitry to re-sync around the damage. His fingers slipped on the casing's torn edges, and the plastic cut him - thin, sharp pain adding to the burn on his knuckle.

The monitor flared. Stitch's grin appeared for a fraction of a second - closer than before, teeth too many, eyes too bright. The laughter hit a half-second late, arriving after the image, like the bunker was losing time.

And with that loss of time, the counting voice began to blur its own certainty. The chant stuttered into a scrambled cadence, as if the days were being reordered inside the station's memory.

"Seven," it said again, but now the next word wasn't a number. It was a sound - like a breath sucked through a broken speaker. Static chewed it down until it was almost nothing.

Marlowe couldn't afford to celebrate. Relief felt dangerous in the bunker; joy might be the signal that made him visible. But he felt something shift in the air anyway. Not safety. Not mercy. Just a delay. A misalignment.

The seven-day curse had been dragged out of its neat track long enough to buy him a day.

He stood, swaying, and wiped his bleeding hand on his shirt. The fabric stuck where his skin smeared. His lungs burned from running and crawling, and now the station's cold air scraped them raw. He leaned into the console for balance, staring at the flickering monitor as the static tried to reassemble itself into a new picture.

The cables on the wall snapped once - like a warning. The lights dimmed, then rose again. The counting voice returned, but it sounded further away, distorted by interference.

Not clear enough to follow.

Clear enough to threaten.

Marlowe backed toward the smallest gap he could find between console and wall, pressing his body into the tightest space he could tolerate. The bunker's pressure didn't ease, but it stopped actively tightening for a moment - as if it had to decide what to do with the altered loop.

He clutched the torn casing to his chest again, feeling the edges bite. His head rang with static and pain. Somewhere inside the walls, the VHS player clicked, searching for the correct frame. Stitch's laughter - always too close, always wrong - flickered at the edge of hearing.

Marlowe looked at the monitor, at the scrambled countdown that couldn't settle on a number. The bunker had been listening to the tape, but now the tape was stammering.

He'd changed what the curse could do.

The station lights blinked one last time - green, then red - and the counting voice dropped to a low, vibrating hum, as if someone had turned the volume down just enough for him to breathe.

For one more day, the bunker had to catch up.

And in that catch-up, the curse mutated - learning from his interference, rewriting its own script in the language of glitches and torn plastic. Marlowe stayed still, blood slick in his palm, waiting for the next frame to lock onto him again.



Stitch's Grin Hits the Camera

The lens-facing screen area in the bunker didn't so much flicker as stutter, like a bad recording trying to remember what it was supposed to show. Garrick stumbled out of a warped corridor with his leather-handled knife clenched so tight the grip felt fused to his palm, and the air around him was colder than it had any right to be - cold enough to raise gooseflesh on his forearms through the damp fabric. Somewhere deeper in the walls, the VHS player chattered in short, angry bursts, and the picture on the big, glassy screen smeared into a smear of color that couldn't decide what shape it wanted to be.

On the screen, Marlowe's borrowed stillness from earlier looked like a warning. Frame by frame, the bunker's altered loop tried to re-lock, the way a camera hunts for focus. Garrick could hear it under everything - the tape's demand in the form of voices that weren't just sound anymore, but pressure, like someone leaning close to his ear with wet breath. He didn't know where Marlowe had gone; he only knew the hunt wasn't finished, that the curse was still chewing through the order of things and spitting out names. He tasted old plastic and overheated dust, and every breath scraped his throat like it had grit in it.

"Where are you hiding?" he called, voice rough, bouncing off the lens housing. "Talk. Stitch wants - "

The screen answered first. Not with words. With a grin.

A glitch snapped across the glass - horizontal tearing that revealed, for a fraction of a second, Stitch's face warped into the wrong angles of the world. His smile was too jagged, too pleased, the teeth like pale stitches pulling apart.

The image collapsed into static so fast Garrick flinched. His knife hand jerked, blade catching the light, and the bunker's walls responded with a wet, mechanical groan, as if the building had been slapped.

He kept moving because stopping felt like agreeing to be filmed.

Marlowe had altered the loop - Garrick felt it in the stutter of the tape and the way the voices changed their tone, less satisfied and more urgent, like a timer that had been reset and was now counting faster. Garrick wanted the curse to complete its mission. He wanted the final target inside the bunker caught by the camera-facing screen and forced to watch until the countdown finished. The voices had said seven days, said it like a promise with teeth. He didn't understand the full mechanism, but he understood the pattern: the tape needed exposure, and the curse needed eyes. If Marlowe was still alive somewhere inside this shrinking maze, he was a problem. If Marlowe had failed, then the tape would pivot to the nearest body that could be broken open for viewing.

Garrick reached the screen area's edge and found the floor wrong. It wasn't just warped; it was subtly tilted toward the lens housing, like the bunker was guiding him, nudging him by force rather than architecture. His shoes squeaked on sticky residue that might've been old spilled soda or dried blood. His ribs tightened with every step, as if the air itself had become thicker, more reluctant to let him breathe.

He looked down at the control panel beside the lens housing: a cracked casing around a VHS player, the buttons smeared with grime and something darker that refused to be only dirt. The tape inside was visible through a fogged window, label partially peeled, letters smeared as though the tape had been handled by wet hands. Garrick leaned closer, and the machine coughed out a thin, electrical hiss. The sound wasn't coming from the player alone - it was coming from the walls, from the ceiling, from inside the lens housing, like the bunker had learned how to scream in static.

"Don't you dare stop," he growled. "Don't you - "

A laugh threaded through the hiss, bright and wrong. It wasn't Marlowe. It wasn't Stabbington Bear. It was something that sounded like a children's show host if that host had been stretched too thin and taught to smile through pain. The voice came from everywhere at once, and for a second Garrick couldn't tell if it was in the room or pressed against his skull.

"Garrick," the voice whispered, stretching his name into something longer, something that didn't belong to him. "Knife... eyes..."

His stomach lurched. The bunker's screen tilted slightly, the lens housing adjusting as if it was tracking him. Garrick felt the urge to back away, but the room wouldn't let him - his feet dragged as though the floor had become a suction trap. His muscles burned with exhaustion he hadn't earned yet, like the chase had been going on longer than it should have. He had been running, fighting, forcing doors open and dodging corridor shifts, and now his legs trembled like they were already tired of surviving.

He wasn't alone in the bunker.

A soft thump came from the far side of the screen area. Not a door closing. A body landing wrong.

Garrick turned fast, knife up, and saw the end of a corridor folding into itself like a paper model being creased. The walls had shifted so the corridor mouth now faced him directly, and the darkness inside it looked deeper than it should - like the bunker had poured more black into that space than anywhere else. A shape moved there, small and frantic, and then the corridor snapped another half-inch narrower, trapping the silhouette mid-motion.

A Sprunkie - one of the remaining ones Garrick had been hunting through the bunker's warped corridors. He couldn't see her face clearly at first. The light from the lens housing caught on torn fabric and a streak of something glistening on the floor. Her gear was shredded in places where it hadn't been before, as if

she'd fought the bunker itself. Her breath came in short, panicked bursts that fogged the air in front of her like she'd run through cold water.

"Help - " she started, voice cracking.

The bunker answered by vibrating. The lens housing clicked, and the screen behind it surged into a new image - color bars, then a children's cartoon frame that didn't belong in a place like this. A bright, innocent landscape flashed for a heartbeat, and Garrick felt his skin crawl because the joy in the frame looked like a lie stitched onto a corpse.

Then the cartoon's sound warped. The narration stuttered into gibberish, and the laughter underneath it rose louder, excited, demanding.

The Sprunkie backed toward the corridor wall, and the wall moved. Not like a door. Like a throat tightening.

Garrick understood the problem immediately, and his mouth went dry. The bunker wasn't just hunting. It was forcing. It was herding bodies into the camera-facing area, aligning them with the lens like a machine feeding a reel. The curse wanted the eyes of someone close enough to be caught by the screen's lock. If Marlowe had altered the loop, the curse was compensating by pulling a different target into the shot.

And Garrick was close enough to be dragged into it too.

"Don't look," he barked at the Sprunkie, though he didn't know if the words mattered. "Run - "

The Sprunkie flinched at his voice as though it was another threat. She tried to bolt toward the corridor opening, but the corridor had already narrowed further, and her shoulder scraped the wall with a wet, tearing sound. She screamed - high and ragged - and the sound bounced through the bunker's walls like it was being recorded and played back with distortion. Her blood slicked her arm, shining faintly in the lens glow.

The tape player in the wall clicked again. A new forced frame loaded on the screen - Stitch's grin, too close. Too crisp. His face filled the glass in a way a camera should never be able to achieve inside a bunker. The grin looked like it was aimed at the Sprunkie's eyes.

Garrick's throat tightened. He could feel the voices now, not as sound but as a command. They wanted the viewing completed. They wanted the spreading of the curse to finish its arc by reaching the last set of eyes that could be made to watch.

He didn't have time to decide whether the curse was right. He only had time to choose whether he'd let the bunker decide for him.

Garrick lunged forward, grabbed the Sprunkie by the shoulder, and yanked her away from the corridor's tightening mouth. Her skin was slick and hot under his fingers. She kicked at him, nails scraping his forearm, and the pain made him dizzy with a sudden, animal rage. He shoved her toward the screen area's flat floor where the lens lock seemed strongest, where the curse's attention would be forced into her.

"Watch," the voices hissed, delighted.

Garrick swallowed around a dry ache. "No," he said, but it came out like he was pleading with the bunker instead of resisting it. He hauled her closer anyway, because the room had already decided how the footage would be captured. Fighting the environment felt like trying to stop a train with bare hands.

The Sprunkie's eyes darted across the lens housing, desperate to avoid the glass. Her pupils were blown wide, the whites smeared with tears. She shook her head so hard her teeth clicked.

"Please - please don't - " she choked.

The screen flashed again - cartoon brightness, then instant distortion. Stitch appeared as a flicker in the corner of the frame first, like he was hiding behind

the picture's edges. The image glitched, and for a brief stutter the audience could see him clearly enough to feel it in their nerves: Stitch's grin cutting across the cartoon landscape like a knife through paper, his fingers - too many, too long - reaching toward the camera.

The Sprunkie convulsed. Her body jerked as if someone had grabbed her from inside her spine and pulled her head toward the screen. Her hands clawed at Garrick's wrist, weak and slippery, as if her strength was being siphoned away one frame at a time.

Garrick tightened his hold, leather grip biting into his own palm. He could smell her sweat - sharp, sour - and beneath it the metallic tang of blood. The bunker was cold, but her skin radiated heat like a fever. Her breathing turned into a ragged wheeze, and then the wheeze broke into sobbing that sounded too much like laughter when it distorted through the walls.

"Garrick," the voices breathed his name again, closer now. "Knife... tape... eyes..."

He didn't look away. If the curse wanted exposure, then he'd make sure it got the right kind of exposure - direct, clean, undeniable. He'd already watched it chew through others. He'd already heard what happened when eyes met the lens. The seven days didn't care who held the knife. They only cared who saw.

The Sprunkie's gaze locked on the screen against her will. Her mouth opened on a silent scream. The cartoon sound drowned into Stitch's laughter, loud enough to rattle Garrick's teeth. On the glass, Stitch's face stretched larger with each glitch, his grin sharpening, his eyes shining wetly like he was looking from behind the tape's surface.

For a moment, the screen stopped behaving like a screen. The picture bled outward into the air. Light from the lens crawled across the room's walls, tinting them sickly colors - greenish cartoon glow, then bruised purple, then harsh white that made every scratch and stain on the bunker look freshly carved. The

air thickened again, pressing on Garrick's lungs. The walls seemed to inch closer, tightening the space around the screen area until it felt like standing inside the throat of a machine.

The Sprunkie's body began to shake hard enough to rattle the floor. Her knees buckled. Garrick caught her before she hit the ground, her blood soaking his sleeve. Her eyes stayed on the glass, glassy and wide, and tears slid down her cheeks in bright tracks that reflected the lens light like beads.

"Stop!" Garrick shouted, and his voice broke on the last word. He didn't know if he was shouting at the Sprunkie, at the tape, at the bunker, or at Stitch himself. "Stop it - "

The screen answered with a new sequence: Stitch devouring characters in warped, stitched-together motion, laughter overlaying every scream. The image was grotesque enough to make Garrick's stomach turn, but what made him sickest was the way the footage looked like it was reacting to the Sprunkie's panic - like the tape had learned her fear and was feeding on it. Each time she flinched away from the screen, the next frame corrected itself, pulling her gaze back.

The bunker's walls groaned and the corridor behind them disappeared, folded into the screen area like the building was swallowing exits. Garrick realized, with a cold clarity, that the bunker was shrinking around the act of viewing. It wasn't just trapping bodies. It was trapping the moment the curse needed.

The Sprunkie's breathing stopped abruptly.

Not slowly. Not with a final breath. It cut off like someone had snapped a tape spool. Her chest went still, and for a heartbeat Garrick thought she'd collapsed from shock. Then her eyes flickered - still aimed at the screen - and the whites turned faintly reflective, like they were catching a countdown light no one else could see.

Her mouth twitched into a smile that didn't belong to her.

Garrick stared at her face, knife hand shaking. The voices rose in volume, excited and hungry, like they'd just watched the final ingredient hit the pot.

"She's done," the bunker whispered, and it sounded like Stitch.

Garrick's stomach clenched. He had wanted the curse to complete the mission, but seeing the consequence up close made his skin crawl in a way the chase never had. The Sprunkie's body went limp, her head lolling against Garrick's forearm. Warm blood slid down his sleeve and pooled at his wrist.

The tape kept playing.

The screen shifted again, and this time the glitch wasn't hiding Stitch in corners. Stitch was already there, directly on-camera - his grin centered, his eyes bright and wet, his face too sharp to be real. The static around him thickened, turning the cartoon frame into a rough canvas of interference. The lens housing clicked like a tongue tasting the air.

Garrick looked down at the Sprunkie's dead weight and then back to the glass. His reflection warped in it - his knife, his wild eyes, his mouth half-open as if he'd been caught making a decision. The voices demanded the last part now, the part that felt like an offering.

He didn't want to give it. But the bunker didn't care what he wanted.

The screen's image snapped into a direct feed of Garrick's own position, as if the camera had found him. In the glass, Stitch leaned closer, his grin widening, and his presence filled the frame so completely the room seemed to disappear around him. The lens light turned the air around Garrick into something harsh and visible, like dust in a spotlight.

The bunker trembled. The walls pressed in. Garrick's legs wobbled, exhausted to the bone, but he forced himself upright because he could feel the trap trying to steal the moment from him. He lifted the tape casing with his free hand, thumb smearing sticky residue across the torn label. The words on it - Stitch:

Forbidden Episode - looked bruised and smeared, as if the ink itself was bleeding out.

He stared into the camera-facing screen.

The image locked. The static sharpened. Stitch's face flickered in and out with each stutter of the tape, but the grin stayed consistent - direct, satisfied, aimed through the glass and into wherever the curse had to go next.

Garrick's mouth moved before he could stop it. "Seven days," he rasped, and the bunker amplified his voice until it sounded like multiple people speaking at once. "Seven days..."

The tape player whined, high and strained. The screen flashed white, then black, then white again, and Stitch's grin hit the camera like a strike. His teeth filled the frame. His eyes gleamed. The static swallowed the last of the cartoon colors until the only thing left was him - close enough to count the stitched edges of his smile, close enough that Garrick felt the pressure of being stared at rather than watched.

The room went silent except for the tape's mechanical chattering.

Then the picture cut.

Static flooded the lens area, a violent bloom of white noise that erased Garrick, erased the bunker, erased the last proof of what had been done. Through the static, Stitch's face appeared for a fraction of a second - grinning, warped, triumphant - already too real to be a recording, already inside the signal. The bunker's air snapped warm and then cold again like a camera flash failing.

A title card blinked through the interference as the tape's final frame stabilized just long enough to be read: "Seven Days..."

And then the static swallowed everything, leaving only the sound of a tape that refused to stop turning.

Final Thoughts

You now have everything you need to succeed with stabbington bear: forbidden episode. The techniques and insights in this book are designed to deliver real results when you put them into practice.

As you continue experimenting, remember that mastery comes from curiosity, patience, and a willingness to try new approaches. Use these foundations as a starting point, then make them your own. The best results happen when you combine what you've learned with your unique perspective and creativity.

Start with what resonates most, build on what works, and don't be afraid to adapt along the way. Thank you for choosing this book: now go create something amazing.

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Stabbington Bear: Forbidden Episode

by 12matt3r

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